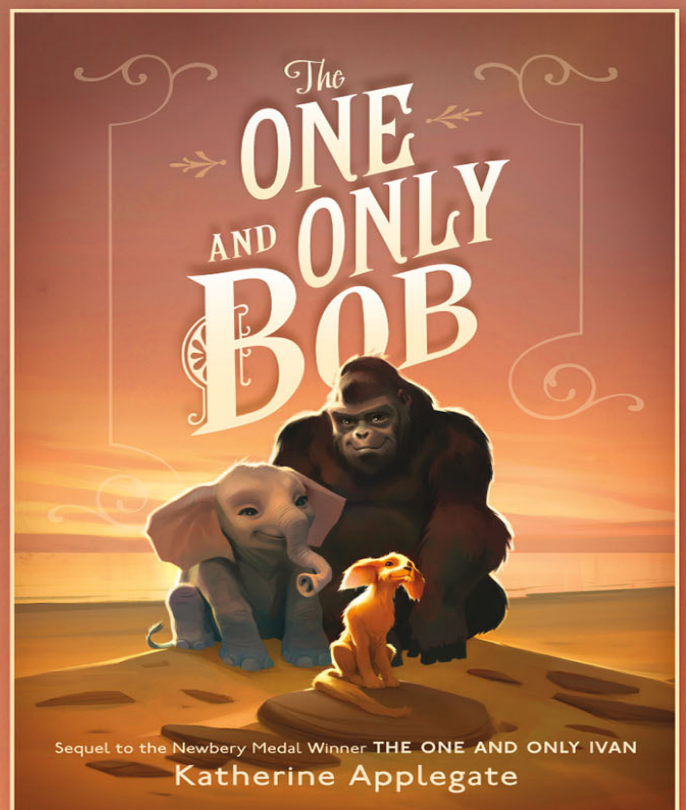
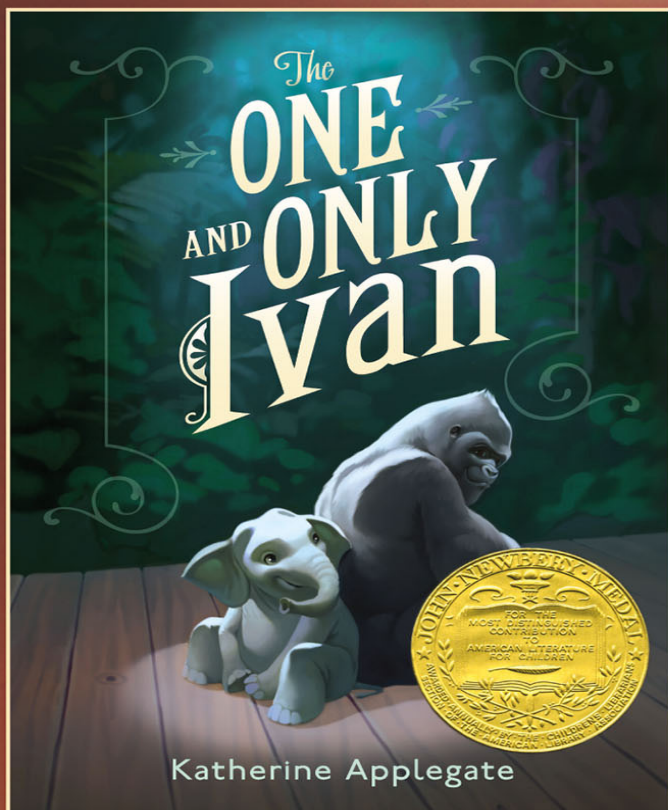


Newbery Medal-Winning Author
Katherine Applegate

IVAN AND FRIENDS COLLECTION



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SOON TO BE A MAJOR MOTION PICTURE!

The ONE AND ONLY Ivan

COMING
SUMMER 2020



#1 *New York Times* Bestseller

Katherine Applegate

KATHERINE APPLEGATE

The
ONE AND ONLY
Ivan

illustrations by
Patricia Castelao

HARPER
An Imprint of HarperCollins Publishers

Dedication

for Julia

Epigraph

*It is never too late to be
what you might have been.*
—George Eliot

Glossary

chest beat: repeated slapping of the chest with one or both hands in order to generate a loud sound (sometimes used by gorillas as a threat display to intimidate an opponent) **domain:** territory **the Grunt:** snorting, piglike noise made by gorilla parents to express annoyance **me-ball:** dried excrement thrown at observers **9,855 days (example):** While gorillas in the wild typically gauge the passing of time based on seasons or food availability, Ivan has adopted a tally of days. (9,855 days is equal to twenty-seven years.)

Not-Tag: stuffed toy gorilla **silverback** (also, less frequently, grayboss): an adult male over twelve years old with an area of silver hair on his back. The silverback is a figure of authority, responsible for protecting his family.

slimy chimp (slang; offensive): a human (refers to sweat on hairless skin) **vining:** casual play (a reference to vine swinging)

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Copyright

hello

I am Ivan. I am a gorilla.

It's not as easy as it looks.



names

People call me the Freeway Gorilla. The Ape at Exit 8. The One and Only Ivan, Mighty Silverback.

The names are mine, but they're not me. I am Ivan, just Ivan, only Ivan.

Humans waste words. They toss them like banana peels and leave them to rot.

Everyone knows the peels are the best part.

I suppose you think gorillas can't understand you. Of course, you also probably think we can't walk upright.

Try knuckle walking for an hour. You tell me: Which way is more fun?

patience

I've learned to understand human words over the years, but understanding human speech is not the same as understanding humans.

Humans speak too much. They chatter like chimps, crowding the world with their noise even when they have nothing to say.

It took me some time to recognize all those human sounds, to weave words into things. But I was patient.

Patient is a useful way to be when you're an ape.

Gorillas are as patient as stones. Humans, not so much.

how I look

I used to be a wild gorilla, and I still look the part.

I have a gorilla's shy gaze, a gorilla's sly smile. I wear a snowy saddle of fur, the uniform of a silverback. When the sun warms my back, I cast a gorilla's majestic shadow.

In my size humans see a test of themselves. They hear fighting words on the wind, when all I'm thinking is how the late-day sun reminds me of a ripe nectarine.

I'm mightier than any human, four hundred pounds of pure power. My body looks made for battle. My arms, outstretched, span taller than the tallest human.

My family tree spreads wide as well. I am a great ape, and you are a great ape, and so are chimpanzees and orangutans and bonobos, all of us distant and distrustful cousins.

I know this is troubling.

I too find it hard to believe there is a connection across time and space, linking me to a race of ill-mannered clowns.

Chimps. There's no excuse for them.

the exit 8 big top mall and video arcade

I live in a human habitat called the Exit 8 Big Top Mall and Video Arcade. We are conveniently located off I-95, with shows at two, four, and seven, 365 days a year.

Mack says that when he answers the trilling telephone.

Mack works here at the mall. He is the boss.

I work here too. I am the gorilla.

At the Big Top Mall, a creaky-music carousel spins all day, and monkeys and parrots live amid the merchants. In the middle of the mall is a ring with benches where humans can sit on their rumps while they eat soft pretzels. The floor is covered with sawdust made of dead trees.

My domain is at one end of the ring. I live here because I am too much gorilla and not enough human.

Stella's domain is next to mine. Stella is an elephant. She and Bob, who is a dog, are my dearest friends.

At present, I do not have any gorilla friends.

My domain is made of thick glass and rusty metal and rough cement. Stella's domain is made of metal bars. The sun bears' domain is wood; the parrots' is wire mesh.

Three of my walls are glass. One of them is cracked, and a small piece, about the size of my hand, is missing from its bottom corner. I made the hole with a baseball bat Mack gave me for my sixth birthday. After that he took the bat away, but he let me keep the baseball that came with it.

A jungle scene is painted on one of my domain walls. It has a waterfall without water and flowers without scent and trees without roots. I didn't paint it, but I enjoy the way the shapes flow across my wall, even if it isn't much of a jungle.

I am lucky my domain has three windowed walls. I can see the whole mall and a bit of the world beyond: the frantic pinball machines, the pink billows of cotton candy, the vast and treeless parking lot.

Beyond the lot is a freeway where cars stampede without end. A giant sign at its edge beckons them to stop and rest like gazelles at a watering hole.

The sign is faded, the colors bleeding, but I know what it says. Mack read its words aloud one day: "COME TO THE EXIT 8 BIG TOP MALL AND VIDEO ARCADE, HOME OF THE ONE AND ONLY IVAN, MIGHTY SILVERBACK!"

Sadly, I cannot read, although I wish I could. Reading stories would make a fine way to fill my empty hours.

Once, however, I was able to enjoy a book left in my domain by one of my keepers.

It tasted like termite.

The freeway billboard has a drawing of Mack in his clown clothes and Stella on her hind legs and an angry animal with fierce eyes and unkempt hair.

That animal is supposed to be me, but the artist made a mistake. I am never angry.



Anger is precious. A silverback uses anger to maintain order and warn his troop of danger. When my father beat his chest, it was to say, *Beware, listen, I am in charge. I am angry to protect you, because that is what I was born to do.*

Here in my domain, there is no one to protect.

the littlest big top on earth

My neighbors here at the Big Top Mall know many tricks. They are an educated lot, more accomplished than I am.

One of my neighbors plays baseball, although she is a chicken. Another drives a fire truck, although he is a rabbit.

I used to have a neighbor, a sleek and thoughtful seal, who could balance a ball on her nose from dawn till dusk. Her voice was like the throaty bark of a dog chained outside on a cold night.

Children wished on pennies and tossed them into her plastic pool. They glowed on the bottom like flat copper stones.

The seal was hungry one day, or bored, perhaps, so she ate one hundred pennies.

Mack said she'd be fine.

He was mistaken.

Mack calls our show "The Littlest Big Top on Earth." Every day at two, four, and seven, humans fan themselves, drink sodas, applaud. Babies wail. Mack, dressed like a clown, pedals a tiny bike. A dog named Snickers rides on Stella's back. Stella sits on a stool.

It is a very sturdy stool.

I don't do any tricks. Mack says it's enough for me to be me.

Stella told me that some circuses move from town to town. They have humans who dangle on ropes twining from the tops of tents. They have grumbling lions with gleaming teeth and a snaking line of elephants, each

clutching the limp tail in front of her. The elephants look far off into the distance so they won't see the humans who want to see them.

Our circus doesn't migrate. We sit where we are, like an old beast too tired to push on.

After our show, humans forage through the stores. A store is where humans buy things they need to survive. At the Big Top Mall, some stores sell new things, things like balloons and T-shirts and caps to cover the gleaming heads of humans. Some stores sell old things, things that smell dusty and damp and long forgotten.

All day, I watch humans scurry from store to store. They pass their green paper, dry as old leaves and smelling of a thousand hands, back and forth and back again.

They hunt frantically, stalking, pushing, grumbling. Then they leave, clutching bags filled with things—bright things, soft things, big things—but no matter how full the bags, they always come back for more.

Humans are clever indeed. They spin pink clouds you can eat. They build domains with flat waterfalls.

But they are lousy hunters.

gone

Some animals live privately, unwatched, but that is not my life.

My life is flashing lights and pointing fingers and uninvited visitors. Inches away, humans flatten their little hands against the wall of glass that separates us.

The glass says you are this and we are that and that is how it will always be.

Humans leave their fingerprints behind, sticky with candy, slick with sweat. Each night a weary man comes to wipe them away.

Sometimes I press my nose against the glass. My noseprint, like your fingerprint, is the first and last and only one.

The man wipes the glass and then I am gone.

artists

Here in my domain, I do not have much to do. You can only throw so many me-balls at humans before you get bored.

A me-ball is made by rolling up dung until it's the size of a small apple, then letting it dry. I always keep a few on hand.

For some reason, my visitors never seem to carry any.

In my domain, I have a tire swing, a baseball, a tiny plastic pool filled with dirty water, and even an old TV.

I have a stuffed toy gorilla, too. Julia, the daughter of the weary man who cleans the mall each night, gave it to me.

The gorilla has empty eyes and floppy limbs, but I sleep with it every night. I call it Not-Tag.

Tag was my twin sister's name.

Julia is ten years old. She has hair like black glass and a wide, half-moon smile. She and I have a lot in common. We are both great apes, and we are both artists.

It was Julia who gave me my first crayon, a stubby blue one, slipped through the broken spot in my glass along with a folded piece of paper.

I knew what to do with it. I'd watched Julia draw. When I dragged the crayon across the paper, it left a trail in its wake like a slithering blue snake.

Julia's drawings are wild with color and movement. She draws things that aren't real: clouds that smile and cars that swim. She draws until her crayons break and her paper rips. Her pictures are like pieces of a dream.

I can't draw dreamy pictures. I never remember my dreams, although I sometimes awaken with my fists clenched and my heart hammering.

My drawings seem pale and timid next to Julia's. She draws the ideas in her head. I draw the things in my cage, simple items that fill my days: an apple core, a banana peel, a candy wrapper. (I often eat my subjects before I draw them.)

But even though I draw the same things over and over again, I never get bored with my art. When I'm drawing, that's all I think about. I don't think about where I am, about yesterday or tomorrow. I just move my crayons across the paper.

Humans don't always seem to recognize what I've drawn. They squint, cock their heads, murmur. I'll draw a banana, a perfectly lovely banana, and they'll say, "It's a yellow airplane!" or "It's a duck without wings!"

That's all right. I'm not drawing for them. I'm drawing for me.

Mack soon realized that people will pay for a picture made by a gorilla, even if they don't know what it is. Now I draw every day. My works sell for twenty dollars apiece (twenty-five with frame) at the gift shop near my domain.

If I get tired and need a break, I eat my crayons.



shapes in clouds

I think I've always been an artist.

Even as a baby, still clinging to my mother, I had an artist's eye. I saw shapes in the clouds, and sculptures in the tumbled stones at the bottom of a stream. I grabbed at colors—the crimson flower just out of reach, the ebony bird streaking past.

I don't remember much about my early life, but I do remember this: Whenever I got the chance, I would dip my fingers into cool mud and use my mother's back for a canvas.

She was a patient soul, my mother.

imagination

Someday, I hope I can draw the way Julia draws, imagining worlds that don't yet exist.

I know what most humans think. They think gorillas don't have imaginations. They think we don't remember our pasts or ponder our futures.

Come to think of it, I suppose they have a point. Mostly I think about what is, not what could be.

I've learned not to get my hopes up.

the loneliest gorilla in the world

When the Big Top Mall was first built, it smelled of new paint and fresh hay, and humans came to visit from morning till night. They drifted past my domain like logs on a lazy river.

Lately, a day might go by without a single visitor. Mack says he's worried. He says I'm not cute anymore. He says, "Ivan, you've lost your magic, old guy. You used to be a hit."

It's true that some of my visitors don't linger the way they used to. They stare through the glass, they cluck their tongues, they frown while I watch my TV.

"He looks lonely," they say.

Not long ago, a little boy stood before my glass, tears streaming down his smooth red cheeks. "He must be the loneliest gorilla in the world," he said, clutching his mother's hand.

At times like that, I wish humans could understand me the way I can understand them.

It's not so bad, I wanted to tell the little boy. With enough time, you can get used to almost anything.

tv

My visitors are often surprised when they see the TV Mack put in my domain. They seem to find it odd, the sight of a gorilla staring at tiny humans in a box.

Sometimes I wonder, though: Isn't the way they stare at me, sitting in my tiny box, just as strange?

My TV is old. It doesn't always work, and sometimes days will go by before anyone remembers to turn it on.

I'll watch anything, but I'm particularly fond of cartoons, with their bright jungle colors. I especially enjoy it when someone slips on a banana peel.

Bob, my dog friend, loves TV almost as much as I do. He prefers to watch professional bowling and cat-food commercials.

Bob and I have seen many romance movies too. In a romance there is much hugging and sometimes face licking.

I have yet to see a single romance starring a gorilla.

We also enjoy old Western movies. In a Western, someone always says, "This town ain't big enough for the both of us, Sheriff." In a Western, you can tell who the good guys are and who the bad guys are, and the good guys always win.

Bob says Westerns are nothing like real life.



the nature show

I have been in my domain for nine thousand eight hundred and fifty-five days.

Alone.

For a while, when I was young and foolish, I thought I was the last gorilla on earth.

I tried not to dwell on it. Still, it's hard to stay upbeat when you think there are no more of you.

Then one night, after I watched a movie about men in black hats with guns and feeble-minded horses, a different show came on.

It was not a cartoon, not a romance, not a Western.

I saw a lush forest. I heard birds murmuring. The grass moved. The trees rustled.

Then I saw him. He was a bit threadbare and scrawny, and not as good-looking as I am, to be honest. But sure enough, he was a gorilla.

As suddenly as he'd appeared, the gorilla vanished, and in his place was a scruffy white animal called, I learned, a polar bear, and then a chubby water creature called a manatee, and then another animal, and another.

All night I sat wondering about the gorilla I'd glimpsed. Where did he live? Would he ever come to visit? If there was a he somewhere, could there be a she as well?

Or was it just the two of us in all the world, trapped in our own separate boxes?

stella

Stella says she is sure I will see another real, live gorilla someday, and I believe her because she is even older than I am and has eyes like black stars and knows more than I will ever know.

Stella is a mountain. Next to her I am a rock, and Bob is a grain of sand.

Every night, when the stores close and the moon washes the world with milky light, Stella and I talk.

We don't have much in common, but we have enough. We are huge and alone, and we both love yogurt raisins.

Sometimes Stella tells stories of her childhood, of leafy canopies hidden by mist and the busy songs of flowing water. Unlike me, she recalls every detail of her past.

Stella loves the moon, with its untroubled smile. I love the feel of the sun on my belly.

She says, "It is quite a belly, my friend," and I say, "Thank you, and so is yours."

We talk, but not too much. Elephants, like gorillas, do not waste words.

Stella used to perform in a large and famous circus, and she still does some of those tricks for our show. During one stunt, Stella stands on her hind legs while Snickers jumps on her head.

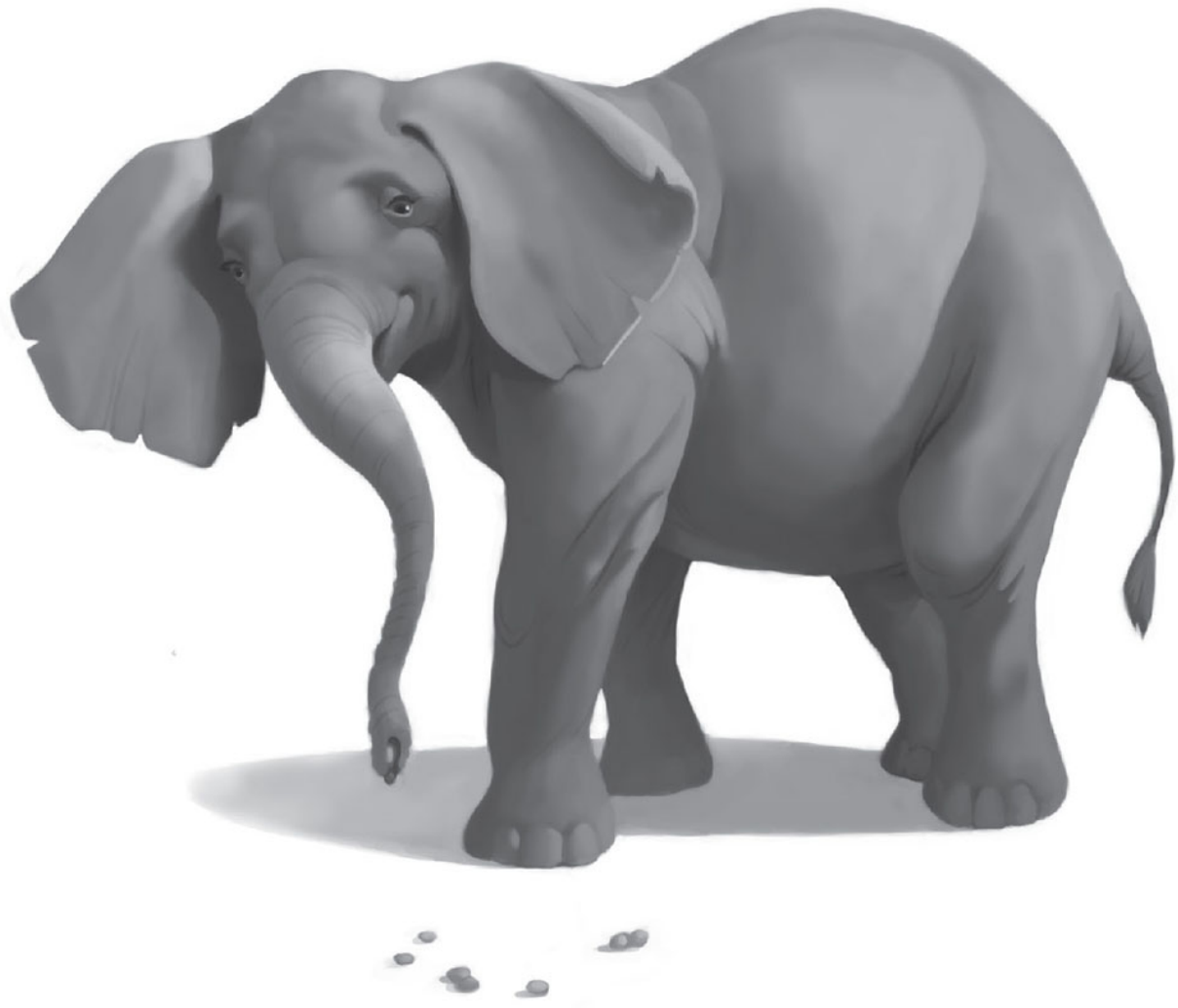
It's hard to stand on your hind legs when you weigh more than forty men.

If you are a circus elephant and you stand on your hind legs while a dog jumps on your head, you get a treat. If you do not, the claw-stick comes swinging.

Elephant hide is thick as bark on an ancient tree, but a claw-stick can pierce it like a leaf.

Once Stella saw a trainer hit a bull elephant with a claw-stick. A bull is like a silverback, noble, contained, calm like a cobra is calm. When the claw-stick caught in the bull's flesh, he tossed the trainer into the air with his tusk.

The man flew, Stella said, like an ugly bird. She never saw the bull again.



stella's trunk

Stella's trunk is a miracle. She can pick up a single peanut with elegant precision, tickle a passing mouse, tap the shoulder of a dozing keeper.

Her trunk is remarkable, but still it can't unlatch the door of her tumble-down domain.

Circling Stella's legs are long-ago scars from the chains she wore as a youth: her bracelets, she calls them. When she worked at the famous circus, Stella had to balance on a pedestal for her most difficult trick. One day, she fell off and injured her foot. When she went lame and lagged behind the other elephants, the circus sold her to Mack.

Stella's foot never healed completely. She limps when she walks, and sometimes her foot gets infected when she stands in one place for too long.

Last winter, Stella's foot swelled to twice its normal size. She had a fever, and she lay on the damp, cold floor of her domain for five days.

They were very long days.

Even now, I'm not sure she's completely better. She never complains, though, so it's hard to know.

At the Big Top Mall, no one bothers with iron shackles. A bristly rope tied to a bolt in the floor is all that's required.

"They think I'm too old to cause trouble," Stella says.

"Old age," she says, "is a powerful disguise."

a plan

It's been two days since anyone's come to visit. Mack is in a bad mood. He says we are losing money hand over fist. He says he is going to sell the whole lot of us.

When Thelma, a blue and yellow macaw, demands "Kiss me, big boy" for the third time in ten minutes, Mack throws a soda can at her. Thelma's wings are clipped so that she can't fly, but she still can hop. She leaps aside just in the nick of time. "Pucker up!" she says with a shrill whistle.

Mack stomps to his office and slams the door shut.

I wonder if my visitors have grown tired of me. Maybe if I learn a trick or two, it will help.

Humans do seem to enjoy watching me eat. Luckily, I am always hungry. I am a gifted eater.

A silverback must eat forty-five pounds of food a day if he wants to stay a silverback. Forty-five pounds of fruit and leaves and seeds and stems and bark and vines and rotten wood.

Also, I enjoy the occasional insect.

I am going to try to eat more. Maybe then we will get more visitors. Tomorrow I will eat fifty pounds of food. Maybe even fifty-five.

That should make Mack happy.

bob

I explain my plan to Bob.

“Ivan,” he says, “trust me on this one: The problem is not your appetite.” He hops onto my chest and licks my chin, checking for leftovers.

Bob is a stray, which means he does not have a permanent address. He is so speedy, so wily, that mall workers long ago gave up trying to catch him. Bob can sneak into cracks and crevices like a tracked rat. He lives well off the ends of hot dogs he pulls from the trash. For dessert, he laps up spilled lemonade and splattered ice cream cones.

I’ve tried to share my food with Bob, but he is a picky eater and says he prefers to hunt for himself.

Bob is tiny, wiry, and fast, like a barking squirrel. He is nut colored and big eared. His tail moves like weeds in the wind, spiraling, dancing.

Bob’s tail makes me dizzy and confused. It has meanings within meanings, like human words. “I am sad,” it says. “I am happy.” It says, “Beware! I may be tiny, but my teeth are sharp.”

Gorillas don’t have any use for tails. Our feelings are uncomplicated. Our rumps are unadorned.

Bob used to have three brothers and two sisters. Humans tossed them out of a truck onto the freeway when they were a few weeks old. Bob rolled into a ditch.

The others did not.



His first night on the highway, Bob slept in the icy mud of the ditch. When he woke, he was so cold that his legs would not bend for an hour.

The next night, Bob slept under some dirty hay near the Big Top Mall garbage bins.

The following night, Bob found the spot in the corner of my domain where the glass is broken. I dreamed that I'd eaten a furry doughnut, and when I woke in the dark, I discovered a tiny puppy snoring on top of my belly.

It had been so long since I'd felt the comfort of another's warmth that I wasn't sure what to do. Not that I hadn't had visitors. Mack had been in my domain, of course, and many other keepers. I'd seen my share of rats zip past, and the occasional wayward sparrow had fluttered in through a hole in my ceiling.

But they never stayed long.

I didn't move all night, for fear of waking Bob.

wild

Once I asked Bob why he didn't want a home. Humans, I'd noticed, seem to be irrationally fond of dogs, and I could see why a puppy would be easier to cuddle with than, say, a gorilla.

"Everywhere is my home," Bob answered. "I am a wild beast, my friend: untamed and undaunted."

I told Bob he could work in the shows like Snickers, the poodle who rides Stella.

Bob said Snickers sleeps on a pink pillow in Mack's office. He said she eats foul-smelling meat from a can.

He made a face. His lips curled, revealing tiny needles of teeth.

"Poodles," he said, "are parasites."

picasso

Mack gives me a fresh crayon, a yellow one, and ten pieces of paper. “Time to earn your keep, Picasso,” he mutters.

I wonder who this Picasso is. Does he have a tire swing like me? Does he ever eat his crayons?

I know I have lost my magic, so I try my very best. I clutch the crayon and think.

I scan my domain. What is yellow?

A banana.

I draw a banana. The paper tears, but only a little.

I lean back, and Mack picks up the drawing. “Another day, another scribble,” he says. “One down, nine to go.”

What else is yellow? I wonder, scanning my domain.

I draw another banana. And then I draw eight more.

three visitors

Three visitors are here: a woman, a boy, a girl.

I strut across my domain for them. I dangle from my tire swing. I eat three banana peels in a row.

The boy spits at my window. The girl throws a handful of pebbles.

Sometimes I'm glad the glass is there.

my visitors return

After the show, the spit-pebble children come back.

I display my impressive teeth. I splash in my filthy pool. I grunt and hoot. I eat and eat and eat some more.

The children pound their pathetic chests. They toss more pebbles.

“Slimy chimps,” I mutter. I throw a me-ball at them.

Sometimes I wish the glass were not there.

sorry

I'm sorry I called those children slimy chimps.

My mother would be ashamed of me.

julia

Like the spit-pebble children, Julia is a child, but that, after all, is not her fault.

While her father, George, cleans the mall each night, Julia sits by my domain. She could sit anywhere she wants: by the carousel, in the empty food court, on the bleachers coated in sawdust. But I am not bragging when I say that she always chooses to sit with me.

I think it's because we both love to draw.

Sara, Julia's mother, used to help clean the mall. But when she got sick and grew pale and stooped, Sara stopped coming. Every night Julia offers to help George, and every night he says firmly, "Homework, Julia. The floors will just get dirty again."

Homework, I have discovered, involves a sharp pencil and thick books and long sighs.

I enjoy chewing pencils. I am sure I would excel at homework.

Sometimes Julia dozes off, and sometimes she reads her books, but mostly she draws pictures and talks about her day.

I don't know why people talk to me, but they often do. Perhaps it's because they think I can't understand them.

Or perhaps it's because I can't talk back.

Julia likes science and art. She doesn't like Lila Burpee, who teases her because her clothes are old, and she does like Deshawn Williams, who teases her too, but in a nice way, and she would like to be a famous artist when she grows up.

Sometimes Julia draws me. I am an elegant fellow in her pictures, with my silver back gleaming like moon on moss. I never look angry, the way I do on the fading billboard by the highway.

I always look a bit sad, though.

drawing bob

I love Julia's pictures of Bob.

She draws him flying across the page, a blur of feet and fur. She draws him motionless, peeking out from behind a trash can or the soft hill of my belly. Sometimes in her drawings, Julia gives Bob wings or a lion's mane. Once she gave him a tortoise shell.

But the best thing she ever gave him wasn't a drawing. Julia gave Bob his name.

For a long time no one knew what to call Bob. Now and then a mall worker would try to approach him with a tidbit. "Here, doggie," they'd call, holding out a French fry. "Come on, pooch," they'd say. "How about a little piece of sandwich?"

But he would always vanish into the shadows before anyone could get too close.

One afternoon, Julia decided to draw the little dog curled up in the corner of my domain. First she watched him for a long time, chewing on her thumbnail. I could tell she was looking at him the way an artist looks at the world when she's trying to understand it.

Finally she grabbed her pencil and set to work. When she was finished, she held up the page.

There he was, the tiny, big-eared dog. He was smart and cunning, but his gaze was wistful.

Under the picture were three bold, confident marks, circled in black. I was pretty certain it was a word, even though I couldn't read it.

Julia's father peered over her shoulder. "That's him exactly," he said, nodding. He pointed to the circled marks. "I didn't realize his name was Bob," he said.

"Me either," said Julia. She smiled. "I had to draw him first."

bob and julia

Bob will not let humans touch him. He says their scent upsets his digestion.

But every now and then I see him sitting at Julia's feet. Her fingers move gently, just behind his right ear.



mack

Usually Mack leaves after the last show, but tonight he is in his office working late. When he's done, he stops by my domain and stares at me for a long time while he drinks from a brown bottle.

George joins him, broom in hand, and Mack says the things he always says: "How about that game last night?" and "Business has been slow, but it'll get better, you'll see," and "Don't forget to empty the trash."

Mack glances over at the picture Julia is drawing. "What're you making?" he asks.

"It's for my mom," Julia says. "It's a flying dog." She holds up her drawing, eyeing it critically. "She likes airplanes. And dogs."

"Hmm," Mack murmurs, sounding unconvinced. He looks at George. "How's the wife doing, anyway?"

"About the same," George says. "She has good days and bad days."

"Yeah, don't we all," Mack says.

Mack starts to leave, then pauses. He reaches into his pocket, pulls out a crumpled green bill, and presses it into George's hand.

"Here," Mack says with a shrug. "Buy the kid some more crayons."

Mack is already out the door before George can yell "Thanks!"

not sleepy

“Stella,” I say after Julia and her father go home, “I can’t sleep.”

“Of course you can,” she says. “You are the king of sleepers.”

“Shh,” Bob says from his perch on my belly. “I’m dreaming about chili fries.”

“I’m tired,” I say, “but I’m not sleepy.”

“What are you tired of?” Stella asks.

I think for a while. It’s hard to put into words. Gorillas are not complainers. We’re dreamers, poets, philosophers, nap takers.

“I don’t know exactly.” I kick at my tire swing. “I think I may be a little tired of my domain.”

“That’s because it’s a cage,” Bob tells me.

Bob is not always tactful.

“I know,” Stella says. “It’s a very small domain.”

“And you’re a very big gorilla,” Bob adds.

“Stella?” I ask.

“Yes?”

“I noticed you were limping more than usual today. Is your leg bothering you?”

“Just a little,” Stella answers.

I sigh. Bob resettles. His ears flick. He drools a bit, but I don't mind. I'm used to it.

"Try eating something," Stella says. "That always makes you happy."

I eat an old, brown carrot. It doesn't help, but I don't tell Stella. She needs to sleep.

"You could try remembering a good day," Stella suggests. "That's what I do when I can't sleep."

Stella remembers every moment since she was born: every scent, every sunset, every slight, every victory.

"You know I can't remember much," I say.

"There's a difference," Stella says gently, "between 'can't remember' and 'won't remember.'"

"That's true," I admit. Not remembering can be difficult, but I've had a lot of time to work on it.

"Memories are precious," Stella adds. "They help tell us who we are. Try remembering all your keepers. You always liked Karl, the one with the harmonica."

Karl. Yes. I remember how he gave me a coconut when I was still a juvenile. It took me all day to open it.

I try to recall other keepers I have known—the humans who cleaned my domain and prepared my food and sometimes kept me company. There was Juan, who poured Pepsis into my waiting mouth, and Katrina, who used to poke me with a broom when I was sleeping, and Ellen, who sang "How Much Is That Monkey in the Window?" with a sad smile while she scrubbed my water bowl.

And there was Gerald, who once brought me a box of fat, sweet strawberries.

Gerald was my favorite keeper.

I haven't had a real keeper in a long time. Mack says he doesn't have the money to pay for an ape babysitter. These days, George cleans my cage and Mack is the one who feeds me.

When I think about all the people who have taken care of me, mostly it's Mack I recall, day in and day out, year after year after year. Mack, who bought me and raised me and says I'm no longer cute.

As if a silverback could ever be cute.

Moonlight falls on the frozen carousel, on the silent popcorn stand, on the stall of leather belts that smell like long-gone cows.

The heavy work of Stella's breathing sounds like the wind in trees, and I wait for sleep to find me.

the beetle

Mack gives me a new black crayon and a fresh pile of paper. It's time to work again.

I smell the crayon, roll it in my hands, press the sharp point against my palm.

There's nothing I love more than a new crayon.

I search my domain for something to draw. What is black?

An old banana peel would work, but I've eaten them all.

Not-Tag is brown. My little pool is blue. The yogurt raisin I'm saving for this afternoon is white, at least on the outside.

Something moves in the corner.

I have a visitor!

A shiny beetle has stopped by. Bugs often wander through my domain on their way to somewhere else.

"Hello, beetle," I say.

He freezes, silent. Bugs never want to chat.

The beetle's an attractive bug, with a body like a glossy nut. He's black as a starless night.

That's it! I'll draw *him*.

It's hard, making a picture of something new. I don't get the chance that often.

But I try. I look at the beetle, who's being kind enough not to move, then back at my paper. I draw his body, his legs, his little antennae, his sour expression.

I'm lucky. The beetle stays all day. Usually bugs don't linger when they visit. I'm beginning to wonder if he's feeling all right.

Bob, who's been known to munch on bugs from time to time, offers to eat him.

I tell Bob that won't be necessary.

I'm just finishing my last picture when Mack returns. George and Julia are with him.

Mack enters my domain and picks up a drawing. "What the heck is this?" he asks. "Beats me what Ivan thinks he's drawing. This is a picture of nothing. A big, black nothing."

Julia's standing just outside my domain. "Can I see?" she asks.

Mack holds my picture up to the window. Julia tilts her head. She squeezes one eye shut. Then she opens her eye and scans my domain.

"I know!" she exclaims. "It's a beetle! See that beetle over there by Ivan's pool?"

"Man, I just sprayed this place for bugs." Mack walks over to the beetle and lifts his foot.

Before Mack can stomp, the beetle skitters away, disappearing through a crack in the wall.

Mack turns back to my drawings. "So you figure this is a beetle, huh? If you say so, kid."

"Oh, that's a beetle for sure," Julia says, smiling at me. "I know a beetle when I see one."

It's nice, I think, having a fellow artist around.



change

Stella is the first to notice the change, but soon we all feel it.

A new animal is coming to the Big Top Mall.

How do we know this? Because we listen, we watch, and most of all, we sniff the air.

Humans always smell odd when change is in the air.

Like rotten meat, with a hint of papaya.

guessing

Bob fears our new neighbor will be a giant cat with slitted eyes and a coiled tail. But Stella says a truck will arrive this afternoon carrying a baby elephant.

“How do you know?” I ask. I sample the air, but all I smell is caramel corn.

I love caramel corn.

“I can hear her,” Stella says. “She’s crying for her mother.”

I listen. I hear the cars charging past. I hear the snore of the sun bears in their wire domain.

But I don’t hear any elephants.

“You’re just hoping,” I say.

Stella closes her eyes. “No,” she says softly, “not hoping. Not at all.”

jambo

My TV is off, so while we wait for the new neighbor, I ask Stella to tell us a story.

Stella rubs her right front foot against the wall. Her foot is swollen again, an ugly deep red.

“If you’re not feeling well, Stella,” I say, “you could take a nap and tell us a story later.”

“I’m fine,” she says, and she carefully shifts her weight.

“Tell us the Jambo story,” I say. It’s a favorite of mine, but I don’t think Bob has ever heard it.

Because she remembers everything, Stella knows many stories. I like colorful tales with black beginnings and stormy middles and cloudless blue-sky endings. But any story will do.

I’m not in a position to be picky.

“Once upon a time,” Stella begins, “there was a human boy. He was visiting a gorilla family at a place called a zoo.”

“What’s a zoo?” Bob asks. He’s a street-smart dog, but there’s much he hasn’t seen.

“A good zoo,” Stella says, “is a large domain. A wild cage. A safe place to be. It has room to roam and humans who don’t hurt.” She pauses, considering her words. “A good zoo is how humans make amends.”

Stella moves a bit, groaning softly. “The boy stood on a wall,” she continues, “watching, pointing, but he lost his balance and fell into the wild cage.”

“Humans are clumsy,” I interrupt. “If only they would knuckle walk, they wouldn’t topple so often.”

Stella nods. “A good point, Ivan. In any case, the boy lay in a motionless heap, while the humans gasped and cried. The silverback, whose name was Jambo, examined the boy, as was his duty, while his troop watched from a safe distance.

“Jambo stroked the child gently. He smelled the boy’s pain, and then he stood watch.

“When the boy awoke, his humans cried out, ‘Stay still! Don’t move!’ because they were certain—humans are always certain about things—that Jambo would crush the boy’s life from him.

“The boy moaned. The crowd waited, hushed, expecting the worst.

“Jambo led his troop away.

“Men came down on ropes and whisked the child to waiting arms.”

“Was the boy all right?” Bob asks.

“He wasn’t hurt,” Stella says, “although I wouldn’t be surprised if his parents hugged him many times that night, in between their scoldings.”

Bob, who has been chewing his tail, pauses, tilting his head. “Is that a true story?”

“I always tell the truth,” Stella replies. “Although I sometimes confuse the facts.”

lucky

I've heard the Jambo story many times. Stella says that humans found it odd that the huge silverback didn't kill the boy.

Why, I wonder, was that so surprising? The boy was young, scared, alone.

He was, after all, just another great ape.

Bob nudges me with his cold nose. "Ivan," he says, "why aren't you and Stella in a zoo?"

I look at Stella. She looks at me. She smiles sadly with her eyes, just a little, the way only elephants can do.

"Just lucky, I guess," she says.

arrival

The new neighbor arrives after the four-o'clock show.

When the truck comes lumbering toward the parking lot, Bob scampers over to inform us.

Bob always knows what's happening. He's a useful friend to have, especially when you can't leave your domain.

With a groan, Mack lifts the sliding metal door near the food court, the place where deliveries are made.

A big white truck is backing up to the door, belching smoke. When the driver opens the truck, I know that Stella is right.

A baby elephant is inside. I see her trunk, poking out from the blackness.



I'm glad for Stella. But when I glance at her, I see she is not glad at all.

"Stand back, everyone!" Mack yells. "We've got a new arrival. This is Ruby, folks. Six hundred pounds of fun to save our sorry butts. This gal is gonna sell us some tickets."

Mack and two men climb into the black cave of the truck. We hear noise, scuffling, a word Mack uses when he's angry.

Ruby makes a noise too, like one of the little trumpets they sell at the gift store.

“Move,” Mack says, but still there is no Ruby. “Move,” he says again. “We haven’t got all day.”

Inside her domain, Stella paces as much as she’s able: two steps one way, two steps the other. She slaps her trunk against rusty metal bars. She grumbles.

“Stella,” I ask, “did you hear the baby?”

Stella mutters something under her breath, a word *she* uses when *she’s* angry.

“Relax, Stella,” I say. “It will be okay.”

“Ivan,” Stella says, “it will never, ever be okay,” and I know enough to stop talking.

stella helps

The men are still yelling. Some of the yelling is at each other, but most of it is at Ruby.

We hear scrambling, pounding, shifting. The side of the truck shudders.

“I’m starting to like this elephant,” Bob whispers.

“I’m getting the big one,” Mack says. “Maybe she can coax the stupid brat out of the truck.”

Mack opens Stella’s door. “Come on, girl,” he urges. He unties the rope attached to the floor bolt.

Stella pushes past Mack, nearly knocking him over. She rushes as best she can, limping heavily, toward the open back door of the truck. She catches her swollen foot on the edge of the ramp and winces. Blood trickles down.

Halfway up the ramp she pauses. The noise in the truck stops. Ruby falls silent.

Slowly Stella makes her way up the rest of the ramp. It groans under her weight, and I can tell how much she is hurting by the awkward way she moves.

At the top of the incline she stops. She pokes her trunk into the emptiness.

We wait.

The tiny gray trunk appears again. Shyly it reaches out, tasting the air. Stella curls her own trunk around the baby’s. They make soft rumbling sounds.

We wait some more. A hush falls over the entire Big Top Mall.

Thud. Thud. Step, step, pause. Step, step, pause.

And there she is, so small she can fit underneath Stella with room to spare. Her skin sags, and she sways unsteadily as she makes her way down the ramp.

“Not the greatest specimen,” Mack says, “but I got her cheap from this bankrupt circus out west. They had her shipped over from Africa. Only had her a month before they went bust.” He gestures toward Ruby. “Thing is, people love babies. Baby elephants, baby gorillas, heck, give me a baby alligator and I could make a killing.”

Stella ushers Ruby toward her domain. Mack and the two men follow. At Stella’s door, Ruby hesitates.

Mack gives Ruby a shove, but she doesn’t budge. “Doggone it, get a clue, Ruby,” he mutters, but Ruby isn’t moving, and neither is Stella.

Mack grabs a broom. He raises it. Instantly, Stella steps in front of Ruby to shield her.

“Get in the cage, both of you!” Mack shouts.

Stella stares at Mack, considering. Gently but firmly, using her trunk, she nudges Ruby into her domain. Only then does Stella enter. Mack slams the door shut with a clang.

I see two trunks entwined. I hear Stella whispering.

“Poor kid,” says Bob. “Welcome to the Exit 8 Big Top Mall and Video Arcade, Home of the One and Only Ivan.”

old news

When Julia comes, she sits by Stella's domain and watches the new baby. She barely talks to me.

Stella doesn't talk to me either. She is too busy nuzzling Ruby.

She is cute, little Ruby, with her ears flapping like palm leaves, but I am handsome and strong.

Bob trots a circle around my belly before settling down in just the right spot. "Give it up, Ivan," he says. "You're old news."

Julia gets out a piece of paper and a pencil. I can see that she is drawing Ruby.

I move to the corner of my domain to pout. Bob grumbles. He doesn't like it when I disrupt his naps.

"Homework," Julia's father scolds. Julia sighs and puts her drawing aside.

I grunt, and Julia glances in my direction. "Poor old Ivan," she says. "I've been ignoring you, haven't I?"

I grunt again, a dignified, indifferent grunt.

Julia thinks for a moment, then smiles. She walks over to my domain, to the spot in the corner where the glass is broken. She slides papers through. She rolls a pencil across my cement floor.

"You can draw the baby elephant too," Julia says.

I bite the pencil in half with my magnificent teeth. Then I eat some paper.

tricks

Even after Julia and her father leave, I try to keep sulking. But it's no use.

Gorillas are not, by nature, pouters.

"Stella?" I call. "It's a full moon. Did you see?"

Sometimes, when we are lucky, we catch a glimpse of the moon through the skylight in the food court.

"I did," Stella says. She is whispering, and I realize that Ruby must be asleep.

"Is Ruby all right?" I ask.

"She's too thin, Ivan," Stella says. "Poor baby. She was in that truck for days. Mack bought her from a circus, the same way he bought me, but she hadn't been there long. She was born in the wild, like us."

"Will she be okay?" I ask.

Stella doesn't answer my question. "The circus trainers chained her to the floor, Ivan. All four feet. Twenty-three hours a day."

I puzzle over why this would be a good idea. I always try to give humans the benefit of the doubt.

"Why would they do that?" I finally ask.

"To break her spirit," Stella says. "So she could learn to balance on a pedestal. So she could stand on her hind legs. So a dog could jump on her back while she walked in mindless circles."

I hear her tired voice and think of all the tricks Stella has learned.

introductions

When I awake the next morning, I see a little trunk poking out between the bars of Stella's domain.

"Hello," says a small, clear voice. "I'm Ruby." She waves her trunk.

"Hello," I say. "I'm Ivan."

"Are you a monkey?" Ruby asks.

"Certainly not."

Bob's ears perk up, although his eyes stay closed. "He's a gorilla," he says. "And I am a dog of uncertain heritage."

"Why did the dog climb your tummy?" Ruby asks.

"Because it's there," Bob murmurs.

"Is Stella awake?" I ask.

"Aunt Stella's asleep," Ruby says. "Her foot is hurting, I think."

Ruby turns her head. Her eyes are like Stella's, black and long-lashed, bottomless lakes fringed by tall grass. "When is breakfast?" she asks.

"Soon," I say. "When the mall opens and the workers come."

"Where"—Ruby twists her head in the other direction—"where are the other elephants?"

"It's just you and Stella," I say, and for some reason, I feel we have let her down.

"Are there more of you?"

“Not,” I say, “at the moment.”

Ruby picks up a piece of hay and considers it. “Do you have a mom and a dad?”

“Well ... I used to.”

“Everyone has parents,” Bob explains. “It’s unavoidable.”

“Before the circus, I used to live with my mom and my aunts and my sisters and my cousins,” Ruby says. She drops the hay, picks it up, twirls it. “They’re dead.”

I don’t know what to say. I am not really enjoying this conversation, but I can see that Ruby isn’t done talking. To be polite, I say, “I’m sorry to hear that, Ruby.”

“Humans killed them,” she says.

“Who else?” Bob asks, and we all fall silent.

stella and ruby

All morning, Stella strokes Ruby, pats her, smells her. They flap their ears. They rumble and roar. They sway as if they're dancing. Ruby clings to Stella's tail. She slips under Stella's belly.

Sometimes they just lean into each other, their trunks twirled together like jungle vines.

Stella looks so happy. It's more fun to watch than any nature show I've ever seen on TV.



home of the one and only ivan

George and Mack are out by the highway. I can see them through one of my windows. They are next to each other on tall wooden ladders, leaning against the billboard that tells the cars to stop and visit the One and Only Ivan, Mighty Silverback.

George has a bucket and a long-handled broom. Mack has pieces of paper. He slaps one against the billboard. George dips the broom into the bucket. He wets the paper with the liquid from the bucket, and somehow the paper stays in place.

They put up many pieces before they are done.

When they climb down from the ladders, I see that they've added a picture of a little elephant to the billboard. The elephant has a lopsided smile. She is wearing a red hat, and her tail curls like a pig's. She doesn't look like Ruby. She doesn't even look like an elephant.

I've only known Ruby one day, and I could have drawn her better.

art lesson

Ruby asks a lot of questions. She says, “Ivan, why is your tummy so big?” and “Have you ever seen a green giraffe?” and “Can you get me one of those pink clouds that the humans are eating?”

When Ruby asks, “What is that on your wall?” I explain that it’s a jungle. She says the flowers have no scent and the waterfall has no water and the trees have no roots.

“I am aware of that,” I say. “It’s art. A picture made with paint.”

“Do you know how to make art?” Ruby asks.

“Yes, I do,” I say, and I puff up my chest, just a little. “I’ve always been an artist. I love drawing.”

“Why do you love it?” Ruby asks.

I pause. I’ve never talked to anyone about this before. “When I’m drawing a picture, I feel ... quiet inside.”

Ruby frowns. “Quiet is boring.”

“Not always.”

Ruby scratches the back of her neck with her trunk. “What do you draw, anyway?”

“Bananas, mostly. Things in my domain. My drawings sell at the gift store for twenty-five dollars apiece, with a frame.”

“What’s a frame?” Ruby asks. “What’s a dollar? What’s a gift store?”

I close my eyes. “I’m a little sleepy, Ruby.”

“Have you ever driven a truck?” Ruby asks.

I don’t answer.

“Ivan?” Ruby asks. “Can Bob fly?”

A memory flashes past, surprising me. I think of my father, snoring peacefully under the sun while I try every trick I know to wake him.

Perhaps, I realize, he wasn’t really such a sound sleeper after all.

treat

“How’s that foot, old girl?” George asks Stella.

Stella pokes her trunk between the bars. She inspects George’s right shirt pocket for the treat he brings her every night without fail.

George doesn’t always bring me treats. Stella’s his favorite, but I don’t mind. She’s my favorite too.

Stella sees that George’s pocket is empty. She gives George a frustrated nudge with her trunk, and Julia giggles.

Stella moves to George’s left pocket and discovers a carrot. Nimbly she removes it.

Mack walks past. “Toilet’s plugged up in the men’s bathroom,” he says. “Big mess.”

“I’ll take care of it.” George sighs.

Mack turns to leave. “Um, before you go, Mack,” George says, “you might want to take a look at Stella’s foot. I think it’s infected again.”

“Darn thing never does heal up right.” Mack rubs his eyes. “I’ll keep an eye on it. Money’s tight, though. Can’t be calling the vet every time she sneezes.”

George strokes Stella’s trunk. She inspects his pockets one more time, just in case.

“Sorry, girl,” George says, as he watches Mack walk away.

elephant jokes

“Ivan? Bob?”

I blink. The dawn sky is a smudge of gray flecked with pink, like a picture drawn with two crayons. I can just make out Ruby in the shadows, waving hello with her trunk.

“Are you awake?” Ruby asks.

“We are now,” says Bob.

“Aunt Stella’s still asleep and I don’t want to wake her ’cause she said her foot was hurting but I’m really, really”—Ruby pauses for a breath—“really bored.”

Bob opens one eye. “You know what I do when I’m bored?”

“What?” Ruby asks eagerly.

Bob closes his eye. “I sleep.”

“It’s a little early, Ruby,” I say.

“I’m used to getting up early.” Ruby wraps her trunk around one of the bars on her door. “At my old circus we always got up when it was still dark and then we had breakfast and we walked in a circle. And then they chained my feet up, and that really hurt.”

Ruby falls silent. Instantly Bob is snoring.

“Ivan?” Ruby asks. “Do you know any jokes? I especially like jokes about elephants.”

“Um. Well, let me see. I heard Mack tell one once.” I yawn. “Uhh ... how can you tell that an elephant has been in the refrigerator?”

“How?”

“By the footprints in the butter.”

Ruby doesn’t react. I sit up on my elbows, trying not to disturb Bob. “Get it?”

“What’s a refrigerator?” Ruby asks.

“It’s a human thing, a cold box with a door. They put food inside.”

“They put food in the door? Or food in the box? And is it a big box?” Ruby asks. “Or a little box?”

I can see this is going to take a while, so I sit up all the way. Bob slides off, grumbling.

I reach for my pencil, the one I snapped in half with my teeth. “Here,” I say, “I’ll draw you a picture of one.”

In the dim light, it takes me a minute to find a piece of the paper Julia gave me. The page is a little damp and has a smear of something orange on it. I think it’s from a tangerine.

I try my best to make a refrigerator. The broken pencil is not cooperating, but I do what I can.

By the time I’m done, the first streaks of morning sun have appeared in flashy cartoon colors. I hold up my picture for Ruby to see.

She studies it intently, her head turned so that one black eye is trained on my drawing. “Wow. You made that! Is this the thing you were telling me about before? Art?”



“Sure is. I can draw all kinds of things. I’m especially good at fruit.”

“Could you draw a banana right now?” Ruby asks.

“Absolutely.” I turn the paper over and sketch.

“Wow,” Ruby says again in an awed voice when I hold up the page. “It looks good enough to eat!”

She makes a happy, lilting sound, an elephant laugh. It’s like the song of a bird I recall from long ago, a tiny yellow bird with a voice like dancing water.

Strange. I’d forgotten all about that bird, how she’d wake me every morning at dawn, when I was still curled safely in my mother’s nest.

It’s a good feeling, making Ruby laugh, so I draw another picture, and another, along the edges of the paper: an orange, a candy bar, a carrot.

“What are you two up to?” Stella asks, moaning as she tries to move her sore foot.

“How are you this morning?” I ask.

“Just feeling my age,” Stella says. “I’m fine.”

“Ivan is making me pictures,” Ruby says. “And he told me a joke. I really like Ivan, Aunt Stella.”

Stella winks at me. “Me too,” she says.

“Ivan? Want to hear my favorite joke?” Ruby asks. “I heard it from Maggie. She was one of the giraffes in my old circus.”

“Sure,” I say.

“It goes like this.” Ruby clears her throat. “What do elephants have that nothing else has?”

Trunks, I think, but I don’t answer because I don’t want to ruin Ruby’s fun.

“I don’t know, Ruby,” I reply. “What do elephants have that nothing else has?”

“Baby elephants,” Ruby says.

“Good one, Ruby,” I say, watching Stella stroke Ruby’s back with her trunk.

“Good one,” Stella says softly.

children

Once I asked Stella if she'd ever had any babies.

She shook her head. "I never had the opportunity."

"You would have made a great mother," I told her.

"Thank you, Ivan," Stella said, clearly pleased. "I like to think so. Having young ones is a big responsibility. You have to teach them how to take mud baths, of course, and emphasize the importance of fiber in their diet." She looked away, contemplating.

Elephants are excellent at contemplating.

"I think the hardest part of being a parent," Stella added after a while, "would be keeping your babies safe from harm. Protecting them."

"The way silverbacks do in the jungle," I said.

"Exactly." Stella nodded.

"You would have been good at protecting, too," I said confidently.

"I'm not so sure," Stella said, gazing at the iron bars surrounding her. "I'm not sure at all."

the parking lot

Mack and George are chatting while George cleans one of my windows.

“George,” Mack says, frowning, “there’s something wrong with the parking lot.”

George sighs. “I’ll take a look as soon as I’m done with this window. What’s the problem?”

“There are cars in it, that’s what’s wrong. *Cars*, George!” Mack breaks into a grin. “I think things are actually starting to pick up a bit. It’s gotta be the billboard. People see that baby elephant and they just have to stop and spend their hard-earned cash.”

“I hope so,” George says. “We sure could use the business.”

Mack’s right. I have noticed more visitors coming since he and George added the picture of Ruby to the sign. People crowd around Ruby and Stella’s domain, oohing and ahing at the sight of a such a tiny elephant.

I gaze out at the huge sign that makes humans stop and spend their hard-earned cash. I have to admit that the picture of Ruby is rather cute, even if she doesn’t look like a real elephant.

I wonder if Mack could add a little red hat and a curly tail to the picture of me. Maybe then more visitors would stop by my domain.

I could use a few oohs and ahhs myself.

ruby's story

“Ivan, tell me another joke, please!” Ruby begs after the two-o’clock show.

“I think I may have run out of jokes,” I admit.

“A story, then,” Ruby says. “Aunt Stella’s sleeping. And there’s nothing to do.”

I tap my chin. I’m trying hard to think. But when I gaze up at the food court skylight, I’m mesmerized by the elephant-colored clouds galloping past.

Ruby taps her foot impatiently. “I know! *I’ll tell you* a story,” she says. “A real live true one.”

“Good idea,” I say. “What’s it about?”

“It’s about *me*,” Ruby lowers her voice. “It’s about me and how I fell into a hole. A *big* hole. Humans dug it.”

Bob pricks his ears and joins me by the window. “I always enjoy a good digging story,” he says.

“It was a big hole full of water near a village,” Ruby says. “I don’t know why humans made it.”

“Sometimes you just need to dig for the sake of digging,” Bob reflects.

“We were looking for food,” Ruby says, “my family and I. But I wandered off and got lost and went too close to the village.” Ruby looks at me, eyes wide. “I was so scared when I fell into that hole.”

“Of course you were,” I say. “I would have been scared too.”

“Me too,” Bob admits. “And I *like* holes.”

“The hole was huge.” Ruby pokes her trunk between the bars and makes a circle in the air. “And guess what?” She doesn’t wait for an answer. “The water was all the way up to my neck and I was sure I was going to die.”

I shudder. “What happened then?” I ask.

“I’ll tell you what happened,” Bob says darkly. “They captured her and put her in a box and shipped her off and here she is. Just like they did with Stella.” He pauses to scratch an ear. “Humans. Rats have bigger hearts. Roaches have kinder souls. Flies have—”

“No, Bob!” Ruby interrupts. “You’re wrong. These humans helped me. When they saw I was trapped, they grabbed ropes and they made loops around my neck and my tummy. The whole entire village helped, even little kids and grandmas and grandpas, and they all pulled and pulled and...”

Ruby stops. Her lashes are wet, and I know she must be remembering all the terrible feelings from that day.

“... and they saved me,” she finishes in a whisper.

Bob blinks. “They *saved* you?” he repeats.

“When I was finally out, everyone cheered,” Ruby says. “And the children fed me fruit. And then all those humans led me back to my family. It took the whole day to find them.”

“No way,” Bob says, still doubtful.

“It’s true,” Ruby says. “Every word.”

“Of course it’s true,” I say.

“I’ve heard rescue stories like that before.” It’s Stella’s voice. She sounds weary. Slowly she makes her way over to Ruby. “Humans can surprise you sometimes. An unpredictable species, *Homo sapiens*.”

Bob still looks unconvinced. “But Ruby’s here now,” he points out. “If humans are so swell, who did that to her?”

I send Bob a grumpy look. Sometimes he doesn't know when to keep quiet.

Ruby swallows, and I'm afraid she's going to cry. But when she speaks, her voice is strong. "Bad humans killed my family, and bad humans sent me here. But that day in the hole, it was humans who saved me." Ruby leans her head on Stella's shoulder. "Those humans were good."

"It doesn't make any sense," Bob says. "I just don't understand them. I never will."

"You're not alone," I say, and I turn my gaze back to the racing gray clouds.

a hit

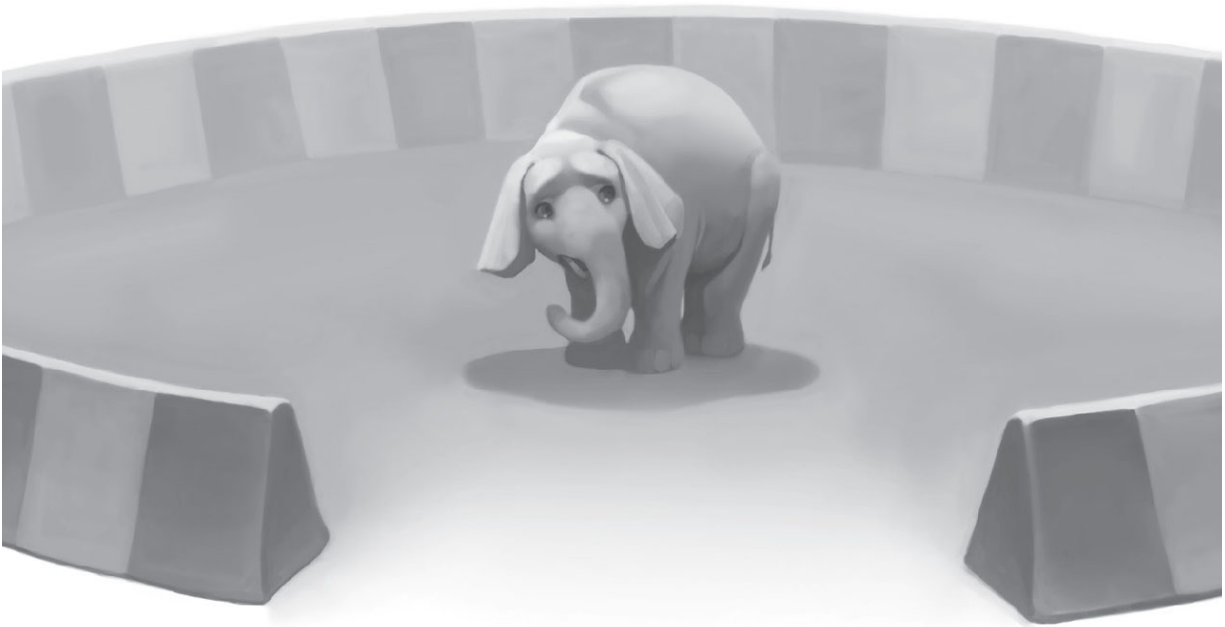
Stella's foot hurts too much for her to do any hard tricks for the two-o'clock show. Instead, Mack pulls her, limping, into the ring, where she tracks a circle in the sawdust.

Ruby clings to her like a shadow. Ruby's eyes go wide when Snickers jumps on Stella's back, then leaps onto her head.

At the four-o'clock show, Stella can only get as far as the entrance to the ring. Ruby refuses to leave her side.

At the seven-o'clock show, Stella stays in her domain. When Mack comes for Ruby, Stella whispers something in her ear. Ruby looks at her pleadingly, but after a moment, she follows Mack to the ring.

Ruby stands alone. The bright lights make her blink. She flaps her ears. She makes her tiny trumpet sound.



The humans stop eating their popcorn. They coo. They clap.

Ruby is a hit.

I don't know whether to be happy or sad.

worry

When Julia arrives after the show, she brings three thick books, one pencil, and something she calls Magic Markers.

“Here, Ivan,” she says, and she slides two Magic Markers and a piece of paper into my domain.

I like the sundown colors, red and purple. But I don’t feel like coloring. I’m worried about Stella. All evening she’s been quiet, and she hasn’t eaten a bit of her dinner.

Julia follows my gaze. “Where is Stella, anyway?” she asks, and she goes to Stella’s gate. Ruby extends her trunk and Julia pats it. “Hi, baby,” she says. “Is Stella all right?”

Stella is lying in a pile of dirty hay. Her breath is ragged.

“Dad,” Julia calls, “could you come here a minute?”

George sets aside his mop.

“Do you think she’s okay, Dad?” Julia asks. “Look at the way she’s breathing. Can we call Mack? I think there’s something really wrong.”

“He must know about her.” George rubs his chin. “He always knows. But a vet costs money, Jules.”

“Please?” Julia’s eyes are wet. “Call him, Dad.”

George gazes at Stella. He puts his hands on his hips and sighs. He calls Mack.

I can’t hear all of his words, but I can see George’s lips tighten into a grim line.

Gorilla expressions and human expressions are a lot alike.

“Mack says the vet’s coming in the morning if Stella’s not any better,” he tells Julia. “He says he’s not going to let her die on him, not after all the money he’s put into her.”

George strokes Julia’s hair. “She’ll be all right. She’s a tough old girl.”

Julia sits by Stella’s domain until it’s time to go home. She doesn’t do her homework. She doesn’t even draw.

the promise

My domain gleams with moonlight when I awake to the sound of Stella's calls.

"Ivan?" Stella says in a hoarse whisper. "Ivan?"

"I'm here, Stella." I sit up abruptly, and Bob topples off my stomach. I run to a window. I can see Ruby next to Stella, sleeping soundly.

"Ivan, I want you to promise me something," Stella says.

"Anything," I say.

"I've never asked for a promise before, because promises are forever, and forever is an unusually long time. Especially when you're in a cage."

"Domain," I correct.

"Domain," she agrees.

I straighten to my full height. "I promise, Stella," I say in a voice like my father's.

"But you haven't even heard what I'm asking yet," she says, and she closes her eyes for a moment. Her great chest shudders.

"I promise anyway."

Stella doesn't say anything for a long time. "Never mind," she finally says. "I don't know what I was thinking. The pain is making me addled."

Ruby stirs. Her trunk moves, as if she is reaching for something that isn't there.

When I say the words, they surprise me. “You want me to take care of Ruby.”

Stella nods, a small gesture that makes her wince. “If she could have a life that’s ... different from mine. She needs a safe place, Ivan. Not—”

“Not here,” I say.

It would be easier to promise to stop eating, to stop breathing, to stop being a gorilla.

“I promise, Stella,” I say. “I promise it on my word as a silverback.”

knowing

Before Mack, before Bob, even before Ruby, I know that Stella is gone.

I know it the way you know that summer is over and winter is on its way. I just know.

Stella once teased me that elephants are superior because they feel more joy and more grief than apes.

“Your gorilla hearts are made of ice, Ivan,” she said, her eyes glittering.
“Ours are made of fire.”

Right now I would give all the yogurt raisins in all the world for a heart made of ice.

five men

Bob heard from a rat, a reliable sort, that they tossed Stella's body into a garbage truck.

It took five men and a forklift.

comfort

All day I try to comfort Ruby, but what can I say?

That Stella had a good and happy life? That she lived as she was meant to live? That she died with those who loved her most nearby?

At least the last is true.

crying

Julia cries all evening, while her father sweeps and mops and dusts and cleans the toilets.

When George sees Mack, he runs to him. I can only hear a few of his words. *Vet. Should have. Wrong.*

Mack shrugs. His shoulders droop. He leaves without a word.

When George wipes the fingerprints off my glass, his cheeks are wet. He doesn't meet my eyes.

the one and only ivan

When all the humans have left, I send Bob to check on Ruby. “How is she?” I ask when he returns.

“She was shivering,” Bob says. “I tried to cover her with hay. And I told her not to worry, because you were going to save her.”

I glare at him. “You *told* her that?”

“You promised Stella.” Bob lowers his head. “I wanted to make the kid feel better.”

“I shouldn’t have made that promise, Bob. I just wanted—” I point to Stella’s domain, and for a moment, it seems like I’ve forgotten how to breathe. “I wanted to make Stella happy, I guess. But I can’t save Ruby. I can’t even save myself.”

I flop onto my back. The cement is always cold, but tonight it hurts.

Bob leaps onto my belly. “You are the One and Only Ivan,” he says. “Mighty Silverback.”

He licks my chin, and he’s not even checking for leftovers.

“Say it,” Bob commands.

I look away.

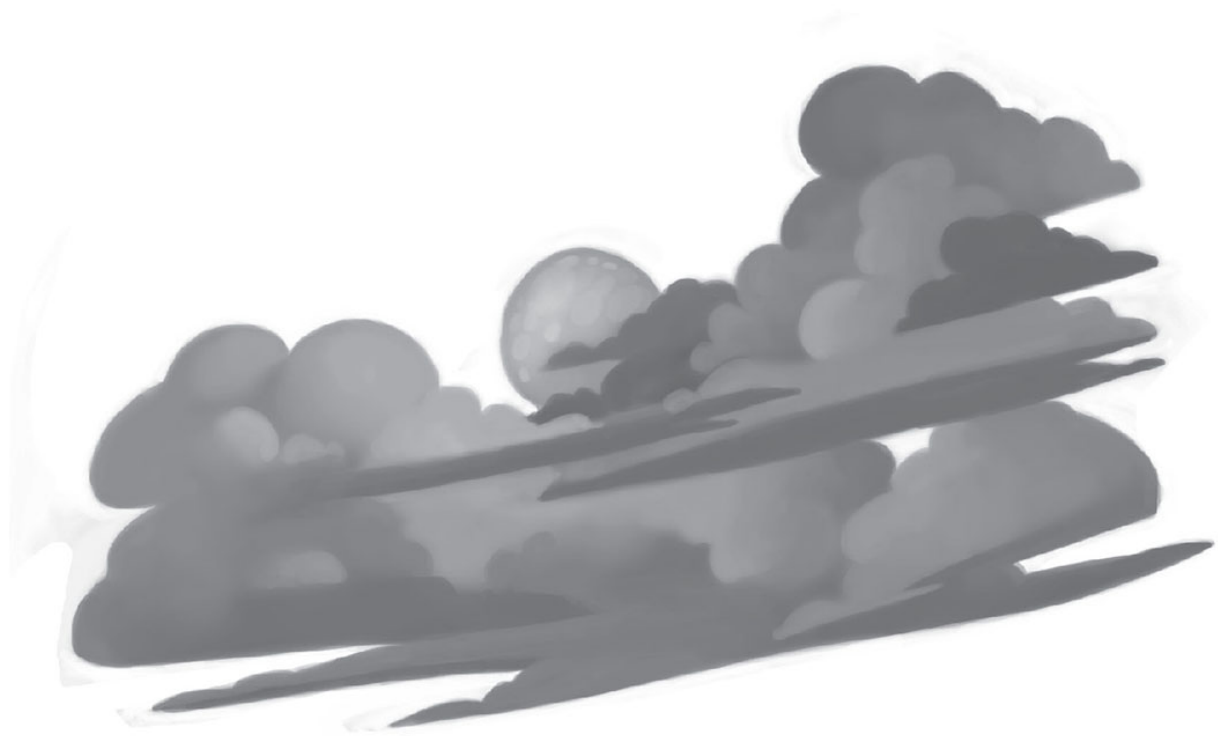
“Say it, Ivan.”

I don’t answer, so Bob licks my nose until I can’t stand it any longer.

“I am the One and Only Ivan,” I mutter.

“And don’t you ever forget it,” he says.

When I gaze at the food-court skylight, the moon Stella loved is shrouded in clouds.



once upon a time

All night, Ruby moans and snuffles. I pace my domain. I don't want to fall asleep, in case she needs something.

"Ivan," Bob says gently, "get some sleep. Please. For your sake. And for mine."

Bob can't sleep unless he is on my stomach.

I hear a stirring. "Ivan?" Ruby calls.

I rush to my window. "Ruby? Are you all right?"

"I miss Aunt Stella," Ruby sobs. "And I miss my mom and my sisters and my aunts and my cousins, too."

"I know," I say, because it's all I can think of.

Ruby snuffles. "I can't sleep. Do you know any stories the way Aunt Stella did?"

"Not really," I admit. "Stories were Stella's specialty."

"Tell me a story about when you were little," Ruby pleads. She puts her trunk between the bars. "Please, Ivan?"

I scratch the back of my head. "I don't remember things, Ruby," I admit.

"It's true," Bob says, trying to be helpful. "Ivan has a terrible memory. He's the opposite of an elephant."

Ruby lets out a long, shivery breath. "Oh, well. That's okay. Night, Ivan. And Bob."

I listen to Ruby's soft sobs for long, horrible minutes.

Then I hear myself saying, “Once upon a time there was a gorilla named Ivan.”

And, slowly and deliberately, I try to remember.

the grunt

I was born in a place humans call central Africa, in a dense rain forest so beautiful, no crayons could ever do it justice.

Gorillas don't name their newborns right away, the way humans do. We get to know our babies first. We wait to see hints of what might yet be.

When they saw how much she loved to chase me around the forest, my parents decided on my twin sister's name: Tag.

Oh, how I loved to play tag with my sister! She was nimble, but when I got too close, she would leap onto my unsuspecting father. Then I would join her and we would bounce on that tolerant belly until he gave us the Grunt, the rooting-pig sound that meant *Enough!*

That game never got old.

Although my father might have disagreed.

mud

It didn't take long for my parents to find my name. All day long, every day, I made pictures. I drew on rocks and bark and my poor mother's back.

I used the sap from leaves. I used the juice from fruit. But mostly I used mud.

And that is what they called me: Mud.

To a human, *Mud* might not sound like much. But to me, it was everything.

protector

My family, which humans call a troop, was just like any other gorilla family. There were ten of us—my father, the silverback; my mother and three other adult females; a juvenile male called a blackback; and two other young gorillas. Tag and I were the babies of the group.

We squabbled now and then, as families will. But my father knew how to keep us in line with a simple scowl. And for the most part, we were happy to do what we were meant to do: to feed and forage and nap and play.

My father was a master at leading us to the ripest fruit for our morning feast and the finest branches for our night nests. He was everything a silverback is meant to be: a guide, a teacher, a protector.

And nobody could chest beat like my father.

a perfect life

Gorilla babies and elephant babies and human babies are not so different, except that a gorilla gets to spend the day riding on his mother's back, like a cowboy on a horse. It's a pretty great system, from the baby's point of view.

Slowly, carefully, a young gorilla begins to venture farther and farther away from the safety of his mother's arms. He learns the skills he will need as an adult. How to make a nest of branches (weave them tightly or they will fall apart in the middle of the night). How to beat your chest (cup your palms to amplify the sound). How to go vining from tree to tree (don't let go). How to be kind, be strong, be loyal.

Growing up gorilla is just like any other kind of growing up. You make mistakes. You play. You learn. You do it all over again.

It was, for a while, a perfect life.

the end

One day, a still day when the hot air hummed, the humans came.

vine

After they captured my sister and me, they put us in a cramped, dark crate that smelled of urine and fear.

Somehow I knew that in order to live, I had to let my old life die. But my sister could not let go of our home. It held her like a vine, stretching across the miles, comforting, strangling.

We were still in our crate when she looked at me without seeing, and I knew that the vine had finally snapped.

the temporary human

It was Mack who pried open that crate, Mack who bought me, and Mack who raised me like a human baby.

I wore diapers. I drank from a bottle. I slept in human beds, sat in human chairs, listened while human words swarmed around me like angry bees.

Mack had a wife back then. Helen was quick to laugh, but quick to anger, too, especially when I broke something, which was often.

Here is what I broke while I lived with Mack and Helen: 1 crib 46 glasses

7 lamps

1 couch

3 shower curtains 3 shower-curtain rods 1 blender

1 TV

1 radio

3 toes (my own) I broke the blender when I squeezed three tubes of toothpaste and a bottle of glue into it. I broke my toes attempting to swing from a lamp fixture on the ceiling. I broke forty-six glasses ... well, it turns out there are many ways to break a glass.

Every weekend, Mack and Helen took me in their convertible to a fast-food restaurant, where they ordered me French fries and a strawberry shake. Mack loved to see the expression on the cashier's face when he drove up and said, "Could I have some extra ketchup for my kid?"

I went to baseball games, to the grocery store, to a movie theater, even to the circus. (They didn't have a gorilla.) I rode a little motorbike and blew out candles on a birthday cake.

My life as a human was a glamorous one, although my parents, traditional sorts, would not have approved.



hunger

In my new life as a human, I was well tended. I ate lettuce leaves with Thousand Island dressing, and caramel apples, and popcorn with butter. My belly ballooned.

But hunger, like food, comes in many shapes and colors. At night, lying alone in my Pooh pajamas, I felt hungry for the skilled touch of a grooming friend, for the cheerful grunts of a play fight, for the easy safety of my nearby troop, foraging through shadows.

Remember what happened to Tag, I told myself. Don't think about the jungle.

Still, sometimes I lay awake, wishing for the warmth of another just like me, asleep in a night nest of tender prayer-plant leaves.

I liked having sips of soda poured into my mouth like a bubbling waterfall. But every now and then, I longed to search for a tender stalk of arrowroot, to feel the tease of a mango, just out of reach.

still life

One day Helen came home with something large and flat, wrapped in brown paper.

“Look what I bought today,” she said excitedly as she tore off the paper. “A painting to go over the livingroom couch.”

“Fruit in a bowl,” Mack said with a shrug. “Big deal.”

“This is fine art. It’s called a ‘still life,’” Helen explained. “And I think it’s lovely.”

I dashed over to examine the painting, marveling at the colors and shapes.

“See?” said Mack’s wife. “Ivan likes it.”

“Ivan likes to roll up poop and throw it at squirrels,” Mack said.

I couldn’t take my eyes off the apples and bananas and grapes in the picture. They looked so real, so inviting, so ... edible.

I reached out to touch a grape, and Helen slapped my hand. “Bad boy, Ivan. Don’t touch.” She jerked her thumb at Mack. “Honey, go get a hammer and a nail, would ya?”

While Mack and Helen were busy in the living room, I wandered into the kitchen. A cake covered in thick chocolate frosting sat on the counter.

I like cake—love it, in fact—but it wasn’t eating I was thinking about. It was painting.

The frosting peaked and dipped like waves on a tiny pond. It looked rich and gooey, dark and smooth.

It looked like mud.

I scooped up a handful of frosting. I scooped up another.

I headed to the refrigerator door. It was perfect: an empty, white, waiting canvas.

The frosting wasn't as easy to work with as jungle mud. It was stickier and, of course, more tempting to eat.

But I kept at it. I scraped off every last bit of that frosting.

I may have eaten a little cake, too.

I don't remember what I was trying to paint. A banana, most likely. I suppose I knew I was going to get in trouble.

But at that moment, I just didn't care. I wanted to make something, anything, the way I used to.

I wanted to be an artist again.

punishment

I soon learned that humans can screech even louder than monkeys.

After that, I was never allowed in the kitchen.

babies

Back in those days, the Big Top Mall was smaller. It had a pony ride, a wooden train that bustled around the parking lot, a few bedraggled parrots, and a surly spider monkey.

But when Mack brought me—a baby gorilla dressed in a crisp tuxedo—to the mall, everything changed.

People came from far and wide to have their pictures taken with me. They brought me blocks and a toy guitar. They held me in their laps. Once I even held a baby in mine.

She was small and slippery. Bubbles flowed from her lips. She squeezed my fingers. Her rear was puffy with padding. Her legs bowed like bent twigs.

I made a face. She made a face. I grunted. She grunted.

I was so afraid she would fall that I squeezed her tightly, and her mother yanked her away.

I wonder if my mother ever worried about dropping us. We always held on, but that's easier to do when your mother is furry.

Human babies are an ugly lot. But their eyes are like our babies' eyes.

Too big for their faces, and for the world.

beds

One day, after many weeks of loud talking, Helen packed a bag and slammed the front door and never came back.

I don't know why. I never know the why of humans.

That night, I slept with Mack in his bed.

My old nests were woven of leaves and sticks and shaped like his bathtub, cool green cocoons.

Mack's bed, like mine, was flat, hot, without sticks or stars.

Still, he made a sleeping sound like the rumble my father used to make when all was well, a sound from deep inside his belly.

my place

Mack grew sullen. I grew bigger. I became what I was meant to be, too large for chairs, too strong for hugs, too big for human life.

I tried to stay calm, to move with dignity. I did my best to eat daintily. But human ways are hard to learn, especially when you're not a human.

When I saw my new domain, I was thrilled, and who wouldn't have been? It had no furniture to break. No glasses to smash. No toilets to drop Mack's keys into.

It even had a tire swing.

I was relieved to have my own place.

Somehow, I didn't realize I'd be here quite so long.

Now I drink Pepsi, eat old apples, watch reruns on TV.



But many days I forget what I am supposed to be. Am I a human? Am I a gorilla?

Humans have so many words, more than they truly need.

Still, they have no name for what I am.

nine thousand eight hundred and seventy-six days

Ruby is finally asleep. I watch her chest rise and fall. Bob, too, is snoring.

But my mind is still racing. For perhaps the first time ever, I've been remembering.

It's an odd story to remember, I have to admit. My story has a strange shape: a stunted beginning, an endless middle.

I count all the days I've lived with humans. Gorillas count as well as anyone, although it's not a particularly useful skill to have in the wild.

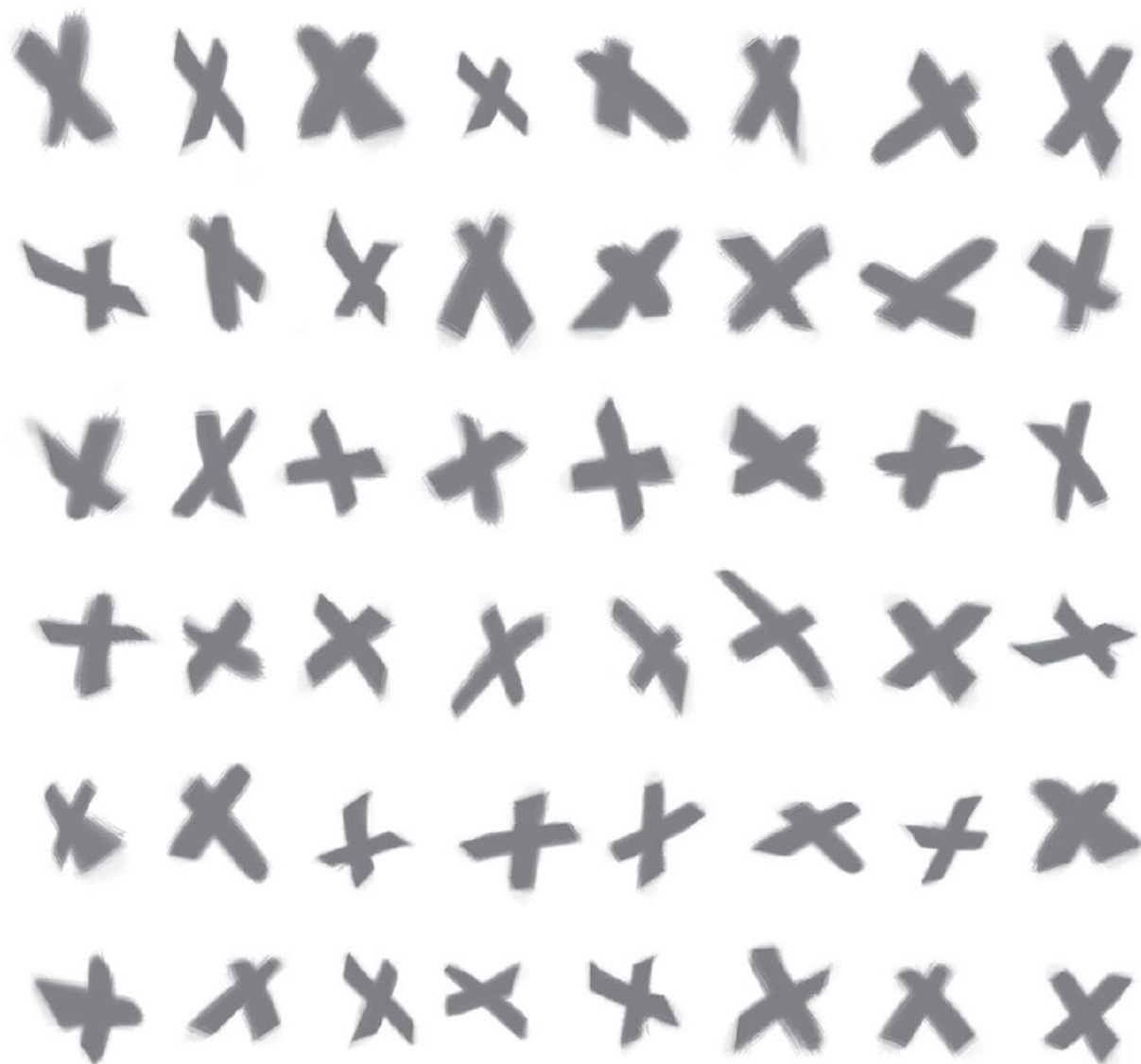
I've forgotten so many things, and yet I always know precisely how many days I've been in my domain.

I take one of the Magic Markers Julia gave me. I make an X, a small one, on my painted jungle wall.

I make more X's, and more. I make an X for every day of my life with humans.

My marks look like this: ✕ ✕ ✕ ✕ ✕ ✕ ✕ ✕

The rest of the night, I mark the days, and when I am done, my wall looks like this:



And so on, until there are nine thousand eight hundred and seventy-six X's marching across my wall like a parade of ugly insects.

a visit

It's almost morning when I hear steps. It's Mack. He has a sharp smell. He weaves as he walks.

He stands next to my domain. His eyes are red. He is staring out the window at the empty parking lot.

"Ivan, my man," he mumbles. "Ivan." He presses his forehead against the glass. "We've been through a lot, you and me."

a new beginning

We don't see Mack for two days. When he returns, he doesn't talk about Stella.

Mack says he is anxious to teach Ruby some tricks. He says the billboard is bringing in more visitors. He says it's time for a new beginning.

All afternoon and into the evening Mack works with Ruby. Ruby's feet are looped with rope so that she cannot run. A heavy chain hangs off her neck. Mack shows her Stella's ball, her pedestal, her stool. He introduces her to Snickers.

When Ruby obeys Mack, he gives her a cube of sugar or a bit of dried apple. When she doesn't, he yells and kicks at the sawdust.

When George and Julia arrive, Mack is still training Ruby. Julia sits on a bench and watches them. She draws a little, but mostly she keeps her eyes on Ruby.

Bob watches too. He's hiding in the corner of my domain under Not-Tag. It's raining outside, and Bob does not like damp feet.

Ruby trudges behind Mack, her head drooping. Endlessly they circle the ring. Sometimes Mack slaps her flank with his hand.

Suddenly Ruby jerks to a stop. Mack pulls the chain hard, but Ruby refuses to move.

"Come on, Ruby." Mack is almost pleading. "What is your problem?"

"She's exhausted," I say to myself. "That's the problem."

Mack groans. "Idiot elephant."

“Idiot human,” Bob mutters.

“Walk, Ruby,” I say, although I know she’s too far away to hear me. “Do what he says.”

“Walk,” Mack commands. “Now.”

Ruby doesn’t walk. She plops her rump on the sawdust floor.

“I think maybe she’s tired,” Julia says.

Mack wipes his forehead with the back of his arm. “Yeah, I know. We’re all tired.”

He pushes Ruby with the heel of his boot. She ignores him.

George looks over from the food court, where he is wiping off tables. “Mack,” he yells, “maybe you should call it a day. I’ll close up.”

Mack yanks on Ruby’s chain. She’s as anchored as a tree trunk. He pulls harder and falls to his knees. “That does it,” Mack says. He brushes sawdust off his jeans. “I am through playing around.”

Mack stomps off to his office. When he returns, he is carrying a long stick. The gleaming hook on its end is almost beautiful, like a sliver of moon.

It’s a claw-stick.

Mack pokes Ruby with the sharp point. Not hard. Just a touch.

I can tell he wants her to see how much it can hurt.

I growl low in my throat.

Ruby doesn’t budge. She is a gray, unmoving boulder. She closes her eyes, and for a moment I wonder if she might have fallen asleep.

“I’m warning you,” Mack says. He breathes out. He stares at the ceiling.

Ruby makes a huffing sound.

“Fine,” Mack says. “You want to play it that way?”

He draws back the claw-stick.

“No!” Julia cries.

“I’m not gonna hurt her,” Mack says. “I just want to get her attention.”

Bob snarls.

Mack swings. The hook slices the air just a few inches above Ruby’s head.

“See why you don’t want to mess with me?” Mack says. He draws back the claw-stick again. “Now *move!*”

Ruby jerks her head, flinging her trunk toward Mack.

She makes a noise that sends the sawdust scattering. It makes my glass shiver.

It is the most beautiful mad I have ever heard.

Ruby’s trunk slaps into Mack.

I don’t see exactly where she strikes him—somewhere below his stomach, I think—and I know he must be uncomfortable, because Mack drops the claw-stick and falls down on the ground and curls into a ball and howls like a baby.

“Direct hit,” Bob says.

poor mack

Mack groans. He stumbles to his feet and hobbles off toward his office. Ruby watches him leave. I can't read her expression. Is she afraid? Relieved? Proud?

When Mack is gone, George and Julia lead Ruby from the ring. "It's okay, baby, it's okay," Julia says, stroking Ruby's head.

They settle Ruby in her domain and make sure she has fresh water and food. Before long, Ruby's dozing.

"Dad?" Julia asks as George locks Ruby's iron door. "Do you think Mack would ever hurt Ruby?"

"I don't think so, Jules," George says. "At least I hope not."

"Maybe we could call someone."

George scratches his chin. "I wish I could help Ruby, but I wouldn't know how. I mean, who would I call? The elephant cops? Besides"—George looks down—"I need this job, Jules. *We* need this job. Your mom, the doctor bills..." He kisses the top of Julia's head. "Back to work. You and me both."

Julia sighs and reaches for her backpack. She removes a piece of paper, a bottle of water, and a small metal box.

"Homework first," George says, wagging a finger. "Then you can paint."

"It's for art class," Julia explains. "We're doing watercolors. I'm going to paint Ruby."

George smiles. "All right, then. Just don't forget your spelling."

“Dad?” Julia asks again. “Did you see Mack’s face when Ruby hit him?”

George nods. “Yes,” he says solemnly. “I did.” He shakes his head. “Poor Mack.”

He turns away, and only then do I hear him laughing.

colors

Julia opens the metal box. I see a row of little squares. Green, blue, red, black, yellow, purple, orange: The colors seem to glow.

She pulls out a brush with a thin tuft of a tail at its end. She dips the brush in water and wets the paper, then taps at the red square.

When the brush meets the damp paper, pink petals of color unfurl like morning flowers.

I can't take my eyes off that magical brush. For a moment, I'm not thinking about Ruby and Mack and the claw-stick and Stella.

Almost.

Julia touches red again, then blue, and there, suddenly, is the purple of a ripe grape. She touches the blue, and her paper turns to summer sky. Black and white, and now I see that she is painting a picture of Ruby. I can make out her floppy ears, her thick legs.

Julia stops painting. She takes a few steps back, hands on her hips, gazing at her work.

She scowls. "It's not right," she says. She glances over her shoulder at me. I try to look encouraging.

Julia starts to crumple up the paper, then reconsiders. Instead she slides it into my cage at the spot where my glass is broken. "Here you go," she says. "A Julia original. That'll be worth millions someday."

Gingerly I pick up the paper. I do not eat a single bite of it.

"Oh. Hey, I almost forgot." Julia runs to her backpack. She pulls out three plastic jars—one yellow, one blue, one red.

She opens the jars, and an odd, not-food smell hits my nose. Julia pushes the jars, one by one, through the opening. Then she slides some paper through.

“These are called finger paints,” she says. “My aunt gave them to me, but really, I’m too old for finger painting.”

I stick a finger into the red jar. The paint is thick as mud. It’s cool and smooth, like bananas underfoot.

I pop my finger into my mouth. It’s not exactly ripe mango, but it’s not bad.

Julia laughs. “You don’t eat it. You paint with it.” She grabs a piece of paper and presses her finger on it. “See? Like this.”

I place my finger on a piece of paper. I lift it, and a red mark is there.

I get a bigger glob from the pot and slap my hand down on the page. When I pull my hand off the paper, its red twin stays behind.

This isn’t like the ghostly handprints on my glass, the ones my visitors leave behind.

This handprint can’t be so easily wiped away.



a bad dream

I lie awake, peeling dried red paint off my fingertips. Bob, who accidentally walked on one of my paintings, is licking his red paws.

Every so often, I glance over at the empty ring. The claw-stick glints in the moonlight.

“Stop! No!” Ruby’s frantic cries startle me.

“Ruby,” I call, “you’re having a bad dream. You’re okay. You’re safe.”

“Where’s Stella?” she asks, gulping air. Before I can answer, she says, “Never mind. I remember now.”

“Go back to sleep, Ruby,” I say. “You’ve had a hard day.”

“I can’t go back to sleep,” she says. “I’m afraid I’ll have the same dream. There was a sharp stick, and it hurt...”

I look at Bob, and he looks back at me.

“Oh,” Ruby says. “Oh. Mack.” She puts her trunk between the bars. “Do you think—” She hesitates. “Do you think Mack is mad because I hurt him today?”

I consider lying, but gorillas are terrible liars. “Probably,” I finally say.

“He ran away after that,” Ruby says.

Bob gives a scornful laugh. “Crawled away is more like it.”

We are quiet for a while. Branches claw at the roof. A light rain drums. One of the parrots murmurs something in her sleep.

Ruby breaks the silence. “Ivan? I smell something funny.”

“He can’t help it,” Bob says.

“I believe she’s referring to the finger paints Julia gave me,” I say.

“What are finger paints?” Ruby asks.

“You make pictures with them,” I explain.

“Could you make a picture of me?”

“Maybe someday.” I remember Julia’s picture, the one that will be worth a million dollars. I hold it up to the glass. “Look. It’s you. Julia made it.”

“It’s hard to see,” Ruby says. “There’s not much moonlight. Why do I have two trunks?”

I examine the picture. “Those are feet.”

“Why do I have two feet?”

“That’s called artistic license,” Bob says.

Ruby sighs. “Could you tell me another story?” she asks. “I don’t think I can ever go back to sleep.”

“I told you all I remember,” I say with a helpless shrug.

“Then tell me a new story,” she says. “Make something up.”

I try to think, but my thoughts keep returning to Mack and his claw-stick.

“Anything yet?” Ruby asks.

“I’m working on it.”

“Ivan?” Ruby presses. “Bob said you are going to save me.”

“I…” I search for true words. “I’m working on that, too.”

“Ivan?” Ruby says in a voice so low I can barely hear her. “I have another question.”

I can tell from the sound of her voice that this will be a question I don’t want to answer.

Ruby taps her trunk against the rusty iron bars of her door. “Do you think,” she asks, “that I’ll die in this domain someday, like Aunt Stella?”

Once again I consider lying, but when I look at Ruby, the half-formed words die in my throat. “Not if I can help it,” I say instead.

I feel something tighten in my chest, something dark and hot. “And it’s not a domain,” I add.

I pause, and then I say it. “It’s a cage.”

the story

I look at the ring, layered with fresh sawdust. I look at the skylight, at the half-hidden moon.

“I just thought of a story,” I say.

“Is it a made-up story or a true one?” Ruby asks.

“True,” I say. “I hope.”

Ruby leans against the bars. Her eyes hold the pale moon in them, the way a still pond holds stars.

“Once upon a time,” I say, “there was a baby elephant. She was smart and brave, and she needed to go to a place called a zoo.”

“What’s a zoo?” Ruby asks.

“A zoo, Ruby, is a place where humans make amends. A good zoo is a place where humans care for animals and keep them safe.”

“Did the baby elephant get to the zoo?” Ruby asks softly.

I don’t answer right away. “Yes,” I say at last.

“How did she get there?” Ruby asks.

“She had a friend,” I say. “A friend who made a promise.”

how

It takes a long time, but finally Ruby returns to sleep.

“Ivan,” Bob whispers, yawning, “what you said ... about the zoo. How are you going to do it?”

Suddenly I feel as if I could sleep for a thousand days. “I don’t know,” I admit.

“You’ll think of something,” Bob says confidently, his voice trailing off as his eyes close.

“What if I don’t?” I ask, but Bob is already asleep.

His little red feet dance, and I know he’s running in his dreams.

remembering

Bob and Ruby sleep on.

I don't sleep. I think about the promise I made to Stella, and the pictures I've made for Ruby. And I remember.

I remember it all.

what they did

We were clinging to our mother, my sister and I, when the humans killed her.

They shot my father next.

Then they chopped off their hands, their feet, their heads.

something else to buy

There is a cluttered, musty store near my cage.

They sell an ashtray there. It is made from the hand of a gorilla.

another ivan

When morning comes and the parking lot glimmers with dew, I see the billboard on the highway.

There I am: the One and Only Ivan, bathed in the pink light of dawn. I look so angry, with my furrowed brow and clenched fists.

I look the way my father did, the day the men came.

I am, I suppose, a peaceful sort. Mostly I watch the world go by and think about naps and bananas and yogurt raisins.

But inside me, hidden, is another Ivan.

He could tear a grown man's limbs off his body.

In the flicker of time it takes a snake's tongue to taste the air, he could taste revenge.

He is the Ivan on the billboard.

I stare at the One and Only Ivan, at the faded picture of Stella, and I remember George and Mack on their ladders, adding the picture of Ruby to bring new visitors to the Exit 8 Big Top Mall and Video Arcade.

I remember the story Ruby told, the one where the villagers came to her rescue.

I hear Stella's kind, wise voice: *Humans can surprise you sometimes.*

I look at my fingers, coated in red paint the color of blood, and I know how to keep my promise.

days

During the days, I wait. During the nights, I paint.

I worry when Mack takes Ruby into the ring.

He carries the claw-stick with him all the time now. He doesn't use it. He doesn't have to.

Ruby isn't fighting back anymore. She does whatever Mack asks.

nights

I close my eyes. I dip my fingers into the paint.

When I'm done with one piece of paper, I set it aside to dry.

It's so small, just one sheet. And I'm going to need so many.

I move on to the next, and the next, and the next.

It's a giant puzzle, and I'm making the pieces one by one.

By morning, my floor is covered with paintings.

I hide the paintings under my pool of dirty water before Mack can see them.
I don't want them to end up in the gift store, selling for twenty dollars
apiece (twenty-five with frame).

These paintings are for Ruby. Every one of them.

project

“Ivan,” Ruby asks one morning when I am trying to nap, “why are you always so sleepy during the day?”

“I’ve been working on a project at night,” I tell her.

“What’s a project?”

“It’s ... a thing. A painting. It’s a painting for you, actually,” I answer.

Ruby looks pleased. “Can I see it?”

“Not yet.”

Ruby pokes with annoyance at her roped foot. She takes a breath. “Ivan? Do I have to do the shows with Mack today?”

“I’m afraid so. I’m sorry, Ruby.”

Ruby dips her trunk in her water bucket. “That’s okay,” she says. “I already knew the answer.”

not right

It's night again, and everyone's asleep. I look at the picture I've just made, one of dozens.

It's smudged and torn, a muddy blur.

I place it beside the others lining my floor.

The colors are wrong. The shapes are off. It looks like nothing.

It's not what I'm trying to create. It's not what it's meant to be.

It's not right, and I don't know why.

Across the parking lot the billboard beckons, as it always does: COME TO THE EXIT 8 BIG TOP MALL AND VIDEO ARCADE, HOME OF THE ONE AND ONLY IVAN, MIGHTY SILVERBACK!

If I could use human words to say what I need to say, this would all be so easy.

Instead, I have my pots of paint and my ragged pages.

I sigh. My fingertips glow like jungle flowers.

I try again.

going nowhere

I watch Ruby plod around the ring in endless circles, going nowhere.

More visitors have been coming, but not many. Mack says Ruby's not picking up the slack after all. He says he's cutting back on our food. He says he's turning off the heat at night to save money.

Ruby looks thinner to me, more wrinkled than Stella ever was.

"Do you think Ruby's eating enough?" I ask Bob.

"I don't know. I'll tell you one thing, though: You're sure as heck painting enough." Bob wrinkles his nose. "That stench is unbelievable. And I found yellow paint in my tail this morning."

Bob isn't happy about my night painting. He says it's unnatural.

Now, while I work at my art, Bob sleeps on Not-Tag. He claims he prefers her because she doesn't snore. He says her belly doesn't rise and fall and make him seasick.

"What is this plan of yours, anyway?" Bob asks. "If you explained it to me, I could help out." He gnaws at his tail. "Maybe I could come up with something that doesn't involve ... you know, paint."

"I can't explain it," I tell him. "It's an idea in my head, but I can't get it right. And anyway, I'm almost out of supplies. I should have known I wouldn't have enough." I kick at my tire swing. It's spattered with drops of blue paint. "It's a stupid idea."

"I doubt that," Bob says. "Smelly, yes. Stupid? Never."

bad guys

Most of the day I doze. Late in the afternoon, Mack approaches.

Bob slips under Not-Tag. He prefers to keep a low profile around Mack.

Mack's gaze falls on my pool. A corner of one of my paintings is visible. "What's that, big guy?" he asks.

I calmly eat an orange, ignoring him, but my heart is racing.

Mack kicks at my plastic pool. Underneath it are all the paintings.

Mack yanks on a piece of paper. It slips out easily, and he doesn't seem to notice the other paintings.

The page is striped with green, which is what happens when blue paint and yellow paint get together. It's supposed to be a patch of grass.

"Not bad. Where'd you get the paint, anyway? George's kid?" He considers. "Hmm. I'll bet I can get thirty for this picture, maybe even forty."

Mack turns on my TV. It's a Western. There's a human with a big hat and a small gun. He has a shiny star pinned to his chest. That means he is the sheriff and he will be getting rid of all the bad guys.

"If this sells quick, I'm getting you some more of that paint, buddy," Mack says.

He walks away with my painting. Ruby's painting. For a moment, I imagine what it would feel like to be the sheriff.



ad

“Good news, huh?” Bob says when Mack’s out of earshot. “Looks like you might be getting some more supplies.”

“I don’t want to paint for Mack,” I say. “I’m painting for Ruby.”

“You can do both,” Bob says. “You’re an artist, after all.”

While I watch the movie, I try to come up with a new hiding place for my paintings. Maybe, I think, I could fold them, once they’re dry, and stuff them into Not-Tag.

It’s a long movie. At the end, the sheriff marries the woman who owns the saloon, which is a watering hole for humans but not horses.

It’s been a long time since I’ve seen a Western that was also a romance.

“I liked that movie,” I say to Bob.

“Too many horses, not enough dogs,” he comments.

An ad comes on.

I don’t understand ads. They’re not like Westerns, where you know who the bad guy is supposed to be. And they’re hardly ever romantic, unless the man and the woman are brushing their teeth before they face lick.

I watch an ad for underarm deodorant. “How do you know who’s who if they don’t smell?” I ask Bob.

“Humans reek,” Bob replies. “They just don’t notice because they have incompetent noses.”

Another ad comes on. I see children and their parents buying tickets, just like the tickets Mack sells. They laugh, enjoying their ice cream cones as

they walk down a path.

They pause to watch two sleepy-eyed cats, huge and striped, dozing in long grass.

Tigers. I know, because I saw them on a nature show once.

Words flash on the screen, accompanied by a drawing of a red giraffe. The giraffe vanishes, and I see a human family staring at another kind of family. Elephants, old and young. They're surrounded by rocks and trees and grass and room to wander.

It's a wild cage. A zoo. I see where it begins, and where it ends, the wall that says you are this and we are that and that is how it will always be.

It's not a perfect place. Even in just a few fleeting seconds on my TV screen, I can see that. A perfect place would not need walls.

But it's the place I need.

I gaze at the elephants, and then I look over at Ruby, small and alone.

Before the ad ends, I try to remember every last detail. Rocks, trees, tails, trunks.

It's the picture I need to paint.

imagining

It's different now, when I paint.

I'm not painting what I see in front of me. A banana. An apple. I'm painting what I see in my head. Things that don't exist.

At least, not yet.

not-tag

I pull out Not-Tag's stuffing. Carefully I fill her with my paintings, hiding them so Mack won't sell them. She's large, bigger than Bob, but I still have to crumple a few of them.

Bob tries to settle on her for a nap. "You've killed her," he complains.

"I had to," I say.

"I miss your stomach," Bob admits. "It's so ... spacious."

When Julia arrives, she notices that I've used up my paints and paper. "Wow." Julia shakes her head. "You are one serious artist, Ivan."

one more thing

My finger painting has sold for forty dollars (with frame). Mack is happy. He brings me a huge pile of paper and big buckets of paint.

“Get to work,” he says.

I paint for Mack during the day, and for Ruby at night.

I nap when I can.



But my nighttime picture isn't quite right. It's big, that's for sure. When I place all the pieces on the floor of my cage side by side, the cement is almost completely covered.

But something is still missing.

Bob says I'm crazy. "There's Ruby," he says, pointing with his nose. "There's the zoo. There are other elephants. What's wrong with it?"

"It needs one more thing," I say.

Bob groans. “You’re being a temperamental artist. What could be missing?”



I stare at the huge expanse of colors and shapes. I don’t know how to explain to Bob that it isn’t done yet.

“I’ll just have to wait,” I say at last. “Something will come to me, and then I’ll know my painting is finally ready.”

the seven-o'clock show

During the last show of the day, Ruby seems tired. When she stumbles, Mack reaches for the claw-stick.

I tense, waiting for her to strike back.

Ruby doesn't even flinch. She just keeps plodding along, and after a while, Snickers jumps onto her back.

twelve

I lie in my cage, with Bob on my stomach. We are watching Julia do her homework.

She doesn't seem to be enjoying it. I can tell because she is sighing more than usual.

Again, for the hundredth time, or maybe the thousandth, I wonder what is missing from my painting.

And for the hundredth time, or maybe the thousandth, I don't have any answer.

"Dad," Julia says as George passes by with a mop, "can I ask you a question?"

"*May* I," George corrects. "Ask away."

Julia glances down at a piece of paper. "What's the difference between the word spelled P-R-I-N-C-I-P-A-L and the one spelled P-R-I-N-C-I-P-L-E?"

"The first one is the head of a school, like Ms. Garcia. The second one is a belief that helps you know what's right or wrong." He smiles. "For example, it's against my principles to do my daughter's homework for her."

Julia groans. "If I'm going to be an artist when I grow up, why do I need to know how to spell?"

With a laugh, George heads off.

Poor Julia, I think. Gorillas get by just fine without learning how to spell. All those endless letters, those sticks and circles and zigzags, filling up books and magazines, billboards and candy wrappers.

Words.

Humans love their words.

I leap up. Bob goes flying, straight into my pool.

A word.

“You know how I feel about wet feet!” Bob yells. He scrambles out of the water, shaking each foot in dismay.

I look out my window at the billboard. I can still hear Mack’s voice in my head: “COME TO THE EXIT 8 BIG TOP MALL AND VIDEO ARCADE, HOME OF THE ONE AND ONLY IVAN, MIGHTY SILVERBACK!”

I count to twelve, and then I count again, just to be sure.

H

I lay out sixteen pieces of poster board. Four down, four across.

A perfect square.

“What are you up to?” Bob demands. “I’m guessing it doesn’t involve sleep.”

“It has to do with the billboard.”

“That sign’s a monstrosity. Particularly since I’m not featured.”

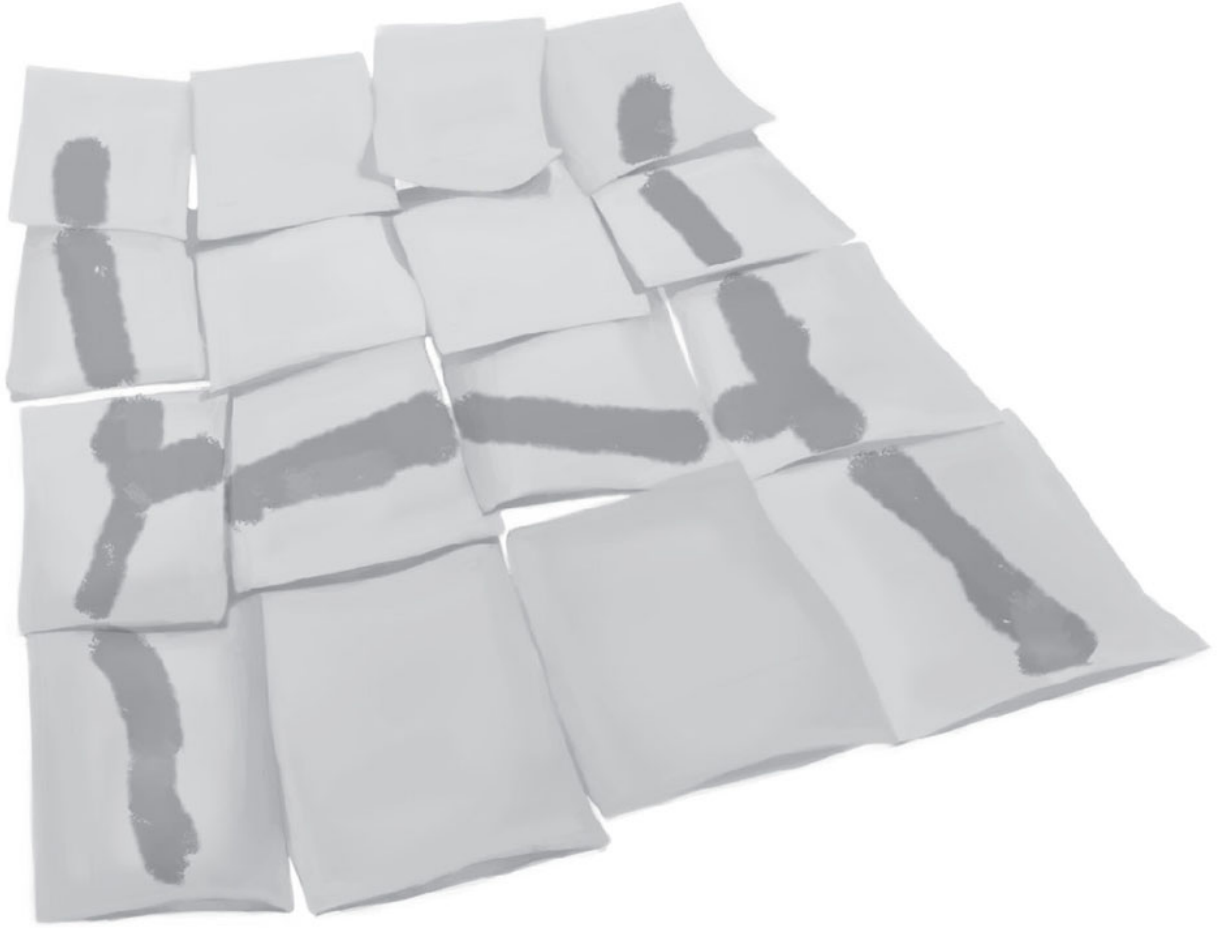
I grab my bucket of red paint. “You’re not on the billboard because you’re not in the show,” I point out.

“Technically, I don’t even live here,” Bob says with a sniff. “I am homeless by choice.”

“I know. I’m just saying.”

I study the billboard. Then I make two fat lines, like broom handles. Another fat line connects them.

I stand back. “What do you think?”



“What is it? No, wait: let me guess. A ladder?”

“Not a ladder,” I say. “A *letter*. At least I think that’s what they’re called. I have to make three more.”

Bob cuddles up next to Not-Tag. “Why?” he asks, yawning.

“Because then I’ll have a word. A very important word.” I dip my fingers into the paint.

“What word?” Bob asks.

“Home.”

Bob closes his eyes. “That’s not so important,” he says quietly.

nervous

All day long I knuckle walk circles around my cage.

I'm so nervous I can't nap. I can't even eat.

Well, not very much, anyway.

I'm ready to show Julia what I've made.

It has to be Julia. She's an artist. Surely she'll look, truly look, at my painting. She won't notice the smudges and tears. She won't care if the pieces don't quite fit together. She'll see past all of that.

Surely Julia will see what I've imagined.

I watch Ruby trudge sullenly through the four-o'clock show, and I wonder: What will happen if I fail? What if I can't make Julia understand?

But of course I know the answer. Nothing. Nothing will happen.

Ruby will remain the main attraction at the Exit 8 Big Top Mall and Video Arcade, conveniently located off I-95, with shows at two, four, and seven, 365 days a year, year after year after year.

showing julia

It's time to show my work.

The mall is silent, except for Thelma the macaw, who is practicing a new phrase: "Uh-oh!"

Julia is finishing her homework. George is sweeping outside. Mack has gone home for the night.

I grab Not-Tag and carefully pull out the folded papers. So many paintings! Page after page. Piece after piece of my giant puzzle.

I pound on my glass, and Julia glances over.

Fingers trembling, I hold up one of my paintings. It's brown and green, a corner piece.

Julia smiles.

I display another picture, and then another and another and another, each one a tiny part of the whole.

Julia looks confused. "But ... what is it?" she asks. She shrugs. "It doesn't matter. It's pretty just as it is."

"Uh-oh," says Thelma.

No, I think. *No*.

It does matter.

more paintings

George calls out to Julia. He's done for the night. "Grab your backpack," he says. "And hurry. It's late."

"Gotta go, Ivan," Julia says.

Julia doesn't understand.

I have to find the right pieces. I dig through the pile. They're here somewhere. I know they are.

I find one, another one, another. I try to hold four of them up against the glass.

"Bob," I say, "help me. Hurry!"

Bob grabs paintings with his teeth and drags them to me.

One by one, I shove pictures through the window crack. They crumple and tear.

There are too many pieces. My puzzle is too big.

"Careful, Ivan," Julia says. "Those might be worth millions someday. You never know." She arranges the paintings into a neat stack. "I suppose Mack's going to want to sell these in the gift shop."

She still doesn't understand.

I shove more out the hole and more and more, all of them, one after another.

"So Ivan's been painting, has he?" George says as he puts on his coat.

"A lot," says Julia with a laugh. "A *whole* lot."

“You’re not taking all those home with you, are you?” George asks. “I mean, no offense to Ivan, but they’re just blobs.”

Julia thumbs through the towering stack of paintings. “They might not be blobs to Ivan.”

“Let’s leave those by the office,” George suggests. “Mack’ll want to try selling them. Although why anyone would pay forty bucks for a finger painting a two-year-old could do, I don’t know.”

“I like Ivan’s work,” Julia says. “He puts his feelings into them.”

“He puts his hair into them,” George says.

Julia waves good-bye. “Night, Ivan. Night, Bob.”

I press my nose against the glass and watch her walk away. All my work, all my planning, wasted.

I look at Ruby, sleeping soundly, and suddenly I know she’ll never leave the Big Top Mall. She’ll be here forever, just like Stella.

I can’t let Ruby be another One and Only.

chest-beating

Often, when visitors come to see me, they beat their hands against their puny chests, pretending to be me.

They pound away, soundless as the wet wings of a new butterfly.

The chest beating of a mad gorilla is not something you ever want to hear. Not even if you're wearing earplugs.

Not even if you're three miles away, wearing earplugs.

A real chest beating sends the whole jungle running, as if the sky has broken open, as if men with guns are near.

angry

Thump.

The sound—my sound—echoes through the mall.

George and Julia spin around.

Julia drops her backpack. George drops his keys. The pile of pictures goes flying.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

I bounce off the walls. I screech and bellow. I beat and beat and beat my chest.

Bob hides under Not-Tag, his paws over his ears.

I'm angry, at last.

I have someone to protect.

puzzle pieces

After a long while, I grow quiet. I sit. It's hard work, being angry.

Julia looks at me with wide, disbelieving eyes.

I'm panting. I'm a little out of shape.

"What the heck was that?" George demands.

"Something's really wrong," Julia says. "I've never seen Ivan act this way."

"He seems to be calming down, thank goodness," George says.

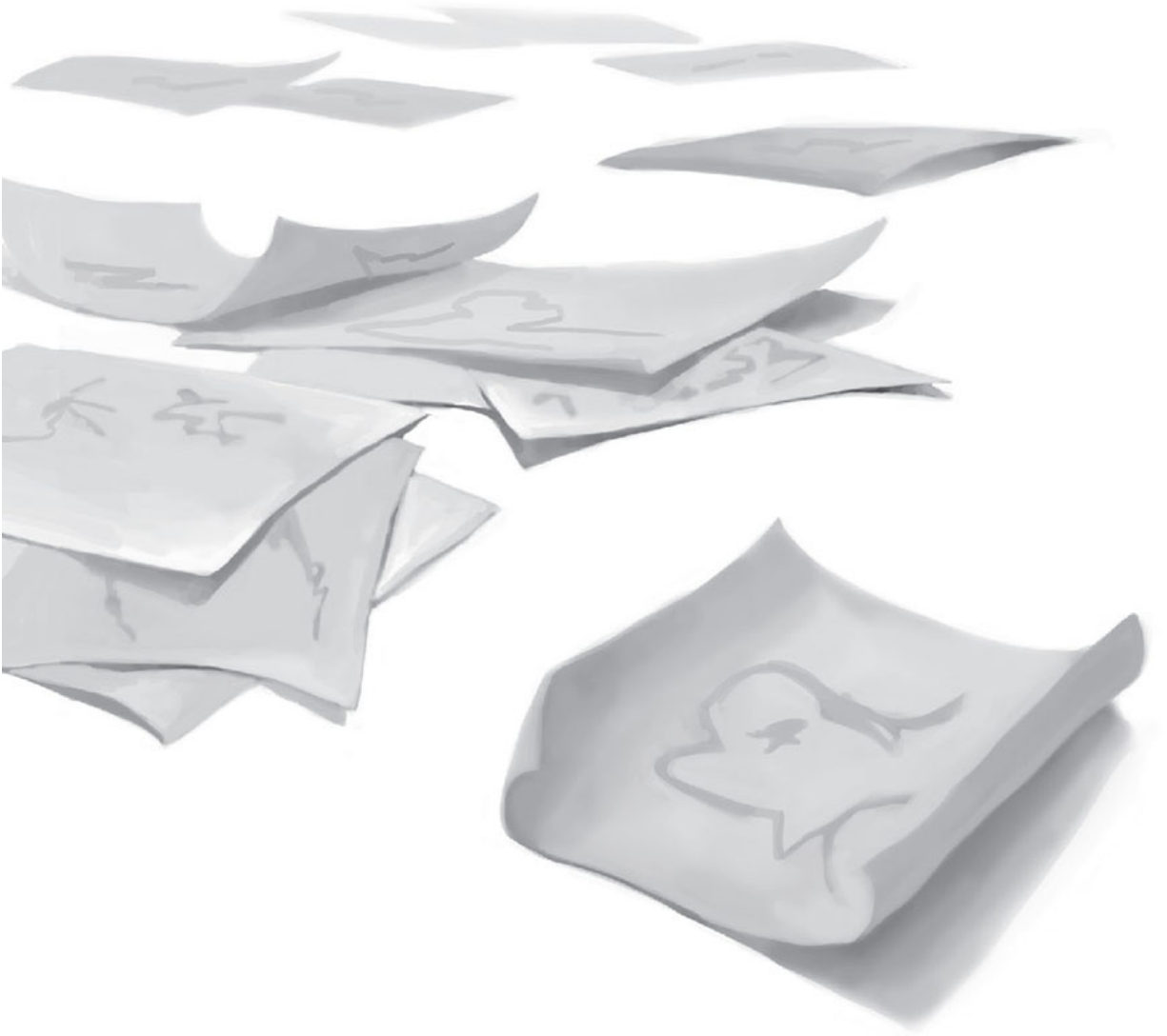
Julia shakes her head. "He's still upset, Dad. Look at his eyes."

My pictures are scattered all over the floor like huge autumn leaves.

"What a mess," George says, sighing. "Wish I hadn't bothered sweeping tonight."

"Do you think Ivan's okay?" Julia asks.

"Probably just a temper tantrum," George says. He reaches under a chair to retrieve a brown and red picture. "Can't say I blame the guy, stuck in that tiny cage all these years."



Julia starts to answer, but then she freezes. She cocks her head.

She stares at her feet, where my pictures lie in disarray.

“Dad,” she whispers. “Come see this.”

“I’m sure he’s another Rembrandt,” George says. “Let’s pick these up and get going, Jules. I’m exhausted.”

“Dad,” she says again. “Seriously. Look at this.”

George follows her gaze. “I see blobs. Many, many blobs, along with the occasional swirl. Please, can we go home now?”

“That’s an *H*, Dad.” Julia kneels down, straightening one picture, then another. “That’s an *H*, and here”—she grabs more pictures—“put this one here, and, I don’t know, maybe that one. You have an *E*.”

George rubs his eyes. I hold my breath.

Julia is running now. She picks up one picture, sets down another. “It’s like a puzzle, Dad! This is *something*. It’s a word, maybe words. And a picture of something. A giant picture.”

“Jules,” George says, “this is crazy.” But he’s looking at the floor too, wandering from picture to picture and scratching his head.

“*H*,” Julia says. “*E. O.*”

“Hoe?”

Julia chews her lower lip. “*H, E, O*. And that looks a lot like an eye.”

“*H, E, O, I*.” George writes in the air with his finger. “*I, E, O, H*.”

“Not the letter. An actual eye. And that’s a foot. Or maybe a tree. And a trunk. Dad, I think that’s a trunk!”

Julia runs to my window. “Ivan,” she whispers, “what did you make?”

I stare back. I cross my arms.

This is taking much longer than I’d thought it would.

Humans.

Sometimes they make chimps look smart.

finally

Julia and George take the pictures to the ring, where there's room to see them all.

An hour passes as they try to assemble my puzzle. Ruby's awake now, and she and Bob and I watch.

"Ivan," Ruby says, "is that a picture of me?"

"Yes," I say proudly.

"Where am I supposed to be?"

"That's a zoo, Ruby. See the walls and the grass and the people looking at you?"

Ruby squints. "Who are all those other elephants?"

"You haven't met them," I say. "Yet."

"It's a very nice zoo," Ruby says with an approving nod.

Bob nudges me with his cold nose. "It is indeed."

In the ring, Julia pumps her fist in the air. "Yes!" she cries. "I told you, Dad! There it is: H-O-M-E. *Home*."

George gazes at the letters. He spins around to look at me. "Maybe it's just a coincidence, Jules. You know, a once-in-a-trillion kind of thing, like that old saying about the chimp and the typewriter. Give him long enough and he'll write a novel."

I make a grumbling noise. As if a chimp could write a letter, let alone a book.

“Then how do you explain the rest of it?” Julia demands. “The picture of Ruby in the zoo?”

“How do you know it’s a zoo?” George asks.

“See the circle on the gate? There’s a red giraffe in it.”

George squints and tilts his head. “Are you sure that’s a giraffe? I was thinking more along the lines of a deformed cat.”

“It’s the logo for the zoo, Dad. It’s on all their signs. Explain that.”

George gives her a helpless smile. “I can’t. I can’t begin to. I’m just saying there has to be a logical explanation.”

“Look how big this is.” Julia puts the last piece of Ruby’s right ear into place. “It’s huge.”

“It is definitely large,” George agrees.

Julia watches me. She chews on her thumbnail. I see the question in her eyes.

She turns back to the paintings and stares at them, looking, truly looking.

A slow smile dawns on Julia’s face.

“Dad,” she says, “I have an idea. A big idea.” Julia races around the edge of my painting, her arms spread wide. “*Billboard* big.”

“I’m not following you.”

“I think this is meant to be on a billboard. That’s what Ivan wants.”

George crosses his arms over his chest. “What Ivan wants,” he repeats slowly. “And you know this because ... you two have been chatting?”

“Because I’m an artist, and he’s an artist.”

“Uh-huh,” says George.

Julia clasps her hands together. “Come on, Dad. I’m begging you.”

George shakes his head. “No. I’m not doing that. No billboard, no way.”

“I’ll get the ladder,” Julia says. “You get the glue. I know it’s dark out, but the billboard’s lit.”

“Mack’ll fire me, Jules.”

Julia considers. “But think of the publicity, Dad! Everybody would know about Ruby.”

“You want me to put up a sign that shows Ruby in a zoo with the word *home* on it in giant letters?” George gestures toward my pictures. “A sign, incidentally, that just happens to have been made by a *gorilla*?”

“Exactly.”

“And you want me to do it without Mack’s permission?” George asks.

“Exactly.”

“No,” George says. “No way.”

Julia goes to the edge of the ring, careful not to step on any of my paintings. She picks up Mack’s claw-stick. She walks back and hands it to her father.

George runs a finger along the blade.

“She’s just a baby, Dad. Don’t you want to help her?”

“But how would it help, Jules? Even if lots of people see Ivan’s sign, it doesn’t mean anything’s going to change.”

“I’m not exactly sure yet.” Julia shakes her head. “Maybe people will see the sign, and they’ll know this isn’t where Ruby belongs. Maybe they’ll want to help too.”

George sighs. He looks at Ruby. She waves her trunk.

“It’s a matter of principle, Dad. P-R-I-N-C-I-P-A-L.”

“L-E,” George corrects.

“Dad,” Julia says softly, “what if Ruby ends up like Stella?”

George looks at me, at Ruby, at Julia.

He drops the claw-stick.

“The ladder,” he says quietly, “is in the storage locker.”

the next morning

I watch Mack's car slam to a halt in the parking lot.

He leaps out. He stares at the billboard. His jaw is open. He doesn't move for a long time.

mad human

A mad gorilla is loud. But a mad human can be loud too.

Especially when he is throwing chairs and turning over tables and breaking the cotton-candy machine.

phone call

Mack is kicking a trash can across the food court when the phone rings.

He answers it, red-faced and sweating.

“What the—” he demands.

He glares at me.

“I don’t know what you’re—” he starts to say, but then he stops to listen.

“Who? Julia who?” he asks. “Oh, sure. George’s kid. *She’s* the one who called you?”

More talking. With the phone to his ear, Mack comes closer to my cage, eyeing me suspiciously.

“Yeah, yeah,” he says. “He paints. Sure. We’ve been selling his art for quite a while now.”

There is another long pause. “Yeah. Absolutely. It was my idea.”

Mack nods. A smile starts at the corners of his mouth.

“Photos? No problem. You want to see him in action? Come on down, have a look. We’re open 365 days a year. Can’t miss us. We’re right off I-95.”

Mack picks up the overturned trash can. “Yeah, I think he’ll be adding more pictures. It’s a, you know, what do you call it? A work in progress.”

When the call is done, Mack shakes his head. “Impossible,” he says.

An hour later, a man with a camera comes to take my picture. He is from the local paper, the one Julia called.

“How about you take one of me with the elephant?” Mack suggests. He drapes his arm around Ruby’s back, grinning as the camera clicks.

“Perfect,” the man says.

“Perfect,” Mack agrees.



a star again

A photo of my billboard is in the newspaper. Mack tapes the story onto my window.

Each day more curious people arrive. They park in front of the billboard. They point and shake their heads. They take photos.

Then they come into the mall and buy my paintings.

While visitors watch, I dip my hands in fresh buckets of paint. I make pictures for the gift shop, and pictures to add to the billboard. Trees with birds. A newborn elephant with glittering black eyes. A squirrel, a bluebird, a worm.

I even paint Bob so he can be on the billboard too. I can tell he likes the picture, although he says I didn't quite capture his distinguished nose.

Every afternoon, Mack and George add my new pictures to the billboard. People slow their cars while they work. Drivers honk and wave.

My gift-shop pictures now cost sixty-five dollars (with frame).

the ape artist

I have new names. People call me the Ape Artist. The Primate Picasso.

I have visitors from morning till night, and so does Ruby.

But nothing's changed for her. Every day at two, four, and seven, Ruby plods through the sawdust with Snickers on her back.

Every night she has bad dreams.

"Bob," I say, after I've soothed Ruby to sleep with a story, "my idea isn't working."

Bob opens one eye. "Be patient."

"I'm tired of being patient," I say.

interview

This evening a man and woman come to interview Mack and also George and Julia.

The man has a large and heavy camera perched on his shoulder. He films me as I make my pictures. He films Ruby in her cage, with her foot roped to the bolt in the floor.

“Mind if I take a look around?” he asks.

Mack waves a hand. “Be my guest.”

While Mack and the woman talk, the cameraman walks through the mall. He pans his camera right and left, up and down.

When his eyes fall on the claw-stick, he stops. He trains his camera on the gleaming blade. Then he moves on.

the early news

Mack turns on the TV.

We are on *The Early News at Five O'Clock*.

Bob says don't let it go to my head.

There we all are. Mack, Ruby, me. George and Julia. The billboard, the mall, the ring.

And the claw-stick.

signs on sticks

In the morning, several people gather in the parking lot. They're carrying signs on sticks.

The signs have words and pictures on them. One has a drawing of a gorilla cradling a baby elephant.

I wish I could read.

protesters

More people with signs come today. They want Ruby to be free. Some of them even want Mack to shut down the mall.



In the evening, George and Mack talk about them. Mack says they're protesting the wrong guy. He says they're going to ruin everything. He says thanks for nothing, George.

Mack stomps off. George, holding his mop, watches him leave. He rubs his eyes. He looks worried.

"Dad," Julia says, looking up from her homework. "You know what my favorite sign was?"

“Hmm?” George asks. “Which one?”

“The one that said ‘Elephants Are People Too.’”

George gives her a tired smile.

He goes back to work. His mop moves across the empty food court like a giant brush, painting a picture no one will ever see.

check marks

A tall man with a clipboard and pencil comes to visit. He says he is here to inspect the property.

He doesn't say much more, but he makes many check marks on his paper.

He looks at my floor. Check. He examines Ruby's hay. Check. He eyes our water bowls. Check.

Mack watches him, scowling.

Bob is outside, hiding near the Dumpster. He does not want to be a check mark.

free ruby

Every day there are more protesters, and cameras with bright lights. Sometimes the people carrying signs shout, “Free Ruby! Free Ruby!”

“Ivan,” Ruby asks, “why are those people yelling my name? Are they mad at me?”

“They’re mad,” I say, “but not at you.”

A week later, the inspecting man comes back with a friend, a woman with smart, dark eyes like my mother’s. She has a white coat on, and she smells like lobelia blossoms. Her hair is thick and brown, the color of a rotten branch teeming with luscious ants.

She watches me for a long time. Then she watches Ruby.

She talks to the man. They both talk to Mack. The man gives Mack a sheet of paper.

Mack covers his face.

He goes to his office and slams the door.

new box

Something strange is happening. The white-coated woman is back with other humans.

They place a large box in the center of the ring.

It's Ruby sized.

And suddenly I know why the woman is here. She's here to take Ruby away.



training

The woman leads Ruby to the box. She places an apple inside. “Good girl, Ruby,” she says kindly. “Don’t be afraid.”

Ruby inspects the box with her trunk. The woman makes a clicking sound with a little piece of metal she is holding in her hand. She gives Ruby a piece of carrot.

Each time Ruby touches the box, she gets a click and a treat.

“Why is she making that clicking noise?” I ask Bob.

“They do that to dogs all the time,” Bob says. I can tell he doesn’t approve. “It’s called clicker training. They want Ruby to associate the noise with the treat. When she does something they want, they make that noise.”

“Great job, Ruby,” the woman says. “You’re a quick study.”

After many clicks and carrots, she takes Ruby back to her cage.

“Why is that lady giving me carrots when I touch the box?” Ruby asks me.

“I think she wants you to go inside,” I explain.

“But there’s nothing inside,” Ruby says, “except an apple.”

“Inside that box,” I say, “is the way out.”

Ruby tilts her head. “I don’t get it.”

“See the picture of the red giraffe on the box? I think the lady is from the zoo, Ruby. I think she’s getting ready to take you there.”

I wait for Ruby to trumpet with joy, but instead she just stares at the box in silence.

“I’m not sure you understand. That box might be taking you to a place where there are other elephants,” I say. “A place with more room, and humans who care about you.”

But even as I say these words, I remember with a shudder the last box I was in.

“I don’t want a zoo,” Ruby says. “I want you and Bob and Julia. This is my home.”

“No, Ruby,” I say. “This is your prison.”

poking and prodding

The lady comes again. She brings an animal doctor with an awful smell and a dangerous-looking bag.

He spends an hour with Ruby, poking and prodding. He looks at her eyes, her feet, her trunk.

When he's done with Ruby, he enters my cage. I wish I could hide under Not-Tag like Bob.

Instead I do a nice, loud chest beat, and after a moment the doctor retreats.

"We're going to need to put this one under," he says.

I'm not quite sure what he means. But I strut around my cage feeling victorious anyway.

no painting

No one asks me to paint today. No one asks Ruby to perform.

There are no shows. No visitors, unless you count the protesters.

Mack stays in his office all day.

more boxes

I wake up from a long morning nap. Bob is on my belly, but he isn't asleep. He's watching the ring, where four men are placing a large metal box.

It's me sized.

"What's that?" I ask, still blurry from sleep.

Bob nuzzles my chin. "I believe that box is for you, my friend."

I'm not sure what he means. "Me?"

"They brought in a bunch of boxes while you were sleeping. Looks to me like they're taking the whole lot of you," he says casually, licking a paw. "Even Thelma."

"Taking?" I repeat. "Taking us where?"

"Well, some to the zoo, probably. Others to an animal shelter where humans will try to find them homes." Bob shakes himself. "So. I guess all good things must come to an end, huh?"

His voice is bright, but his eyes are faraway and sad. "I'm going to miss your stomach, big guy."

Bob shuts his eyes. He makes an odd noise in his throat.

"But ... what about you?" I ask.

I can't tell if Bob's just pretending to sleep, but he doesn't answer.

I gaze at the huge, shadowy box, and suddenly I understand how Ruby feels. I don't want to go into that box.

The last time I was in a box, my sister died.

good-bye

When George and Julia come that night, George doesn't get his mop or his broom. He gathers up his tools and belongings while Julia runs to my cage.

"This is my last night, Ivan," she says, and she presses her palm to my glass. "Mack fired my dad." Tears slip down her cheeks. "But the zoo lady said maybe they'll have an opening there in a while, cleaning cages and stuff."

I walk to the glass that separates us. I put my hand where Julia's is, palm to palm, finger to finger. My hand is bigger, but they're not so very different.

"I'm going to miss you," Julia says. "And Ruby and Bob. But this is a good thing, really it is. You deserve a different life."

I stare into her dark eyes and wish I had words for her.

Sniffing, she goes to Ruby's cage. "Have a good life, Ruby," she says.

Ruby makes a little rumbling sound. She puts her trunk between the bars and touches Julia's shoulder.

"Where is Bob, anyway?" Julia asks. She looks around, under tables, in my cage, by the trash can. "Dad," she calls, "have you seen Bob?"

"Bob? Nope," George says.

Julia's brow wrinkles. "What's going to happen to him, Dad? What if Mack shuts down the whole mall?"

"He says he's going to try to keep it open without the animals," George says. He stuffs his hands in his pockets. "I'm worried about Bob too. But he's a survivor."

“You know what, Dad?” Julia gets a gleam in her eye. “Bob could live with us. Mom loves dogs, and he could keep her company, and—”

“Jules, I’m not even sure I have a job yet. I may not even be able to feed you, let alone some mutt.”

“My dog-walking money—”

“Sorry, Jules.”

Julia nods. “I understand.”

She starts to leave, then runs back to my cage. “I almost forgot. This is for you, Ivan.”

She slips a piece of paper into my cage. It’s a drawing of Ruby and me.

We’re eating yogurt raisins. Ruby is playing with another baby elephant, and I’m holding hands with a lovely gorilla.

She has red lips and a flower in her hair.

I look, as I always do in Julia’s pictures, like an elegant fellow, but something is different about this drawing.

In this picture, I am smiling.



click

The door to my cage is propped open. I can't stop staring at it.

My door. Open.

The giant box has been moved, and it's open too. The humans have pushed it up against my doorway.

If I walk through my door, I enter their box.

The zoo lady, whose name is Maya, is here again.

Click. Yogurt raisin.

Click. Tiny marshmallow.

Click. Ripe papaya.

Click. Apple slice.

Hour after hour, click after click.

I look over at Ruby. She waits to see what I will do.

I touch the box.

I sniff the dark interior, where a ripe mango awaits.

Click, click, click.

I have to do it. Ruby is watching me from between the bars of her cage, and this box is the way out.

I step inside.

an idea

After I leave the box and step back into my cage, I get an idea, a good one.

I tell Bob he can sneak into my box with me and live at the zoo.

“Have you forgotten? I’m a wild beast, Ivan,” he says, sniffing the floor for crumbs. “I am untamed, undaunted.”

Bob samples a piece of celery and spits it out. “Besides, they’d notice. Humans are dumb, but they’re not that dumb.”

respect

“Ivan?” Ruby says. “Do you think the other elephants will like me?”

“I think they’ll love you, Ruby. You’ll be part of their family.”

“Do you think the other gorillas will like you?” Ruby asks.

“I’m a silverback, Ruby. A leader.” I pull back my shoulders and hold my head high. “They don’t have to like me. They have to respect me.”

Even as I tell her this, I wonder if I can ever command their respect.

I haven’t had much practice being a real gorilla, much less a silverback.

“Do you think the other elephants will know any jokes?”

“If they don’t,” I tell her, “you can teach them.”

Ruby flaps her ears. She flicks her tail. “You know what, Ivan?”

“What?” I ask.

“I think I’m going to go in the box tomorrow.”

I gaze at her fondly. “I think that’s a good idea. And I think Stella would have agreed.”

“Do you think the other elephants will know how to play tag? I love tag.”

“Me too,” I say, and I think of my nimble sister racing through the brush, always just out of my reach.

photo

Late at night, Mack opens my cage. The full moon falls on his sagging shoulders. He seems smaller somehow.

Bob, instantly alert, leaps off my stomach and dives under Not-Tag.

“Don’t bother hiding, dog,” Mack says. “I know you sleep in here.” Mack settles onto my tire swing. “Might as well stay one more night. Your buddy’s leaving tomorrow.”

Tomorrow? My stomach drops. I’m not ready. I need more time. I haven’t said my good-byes. I haven’t thought this through.

Mack pulls a small photo out of his shirt pocket. It’s me when I was young. Mack and I are in the front seat of his convertible.

I’m wearing a baseball cap and eating an ice cream cone.

I was a handsome lad, but I have to admit I look ridiculous. Nothing like a real gorilla.

“We had some laughs, didn’t we, guy?” Mack says. “Remember when we went on that roller coaster? Or that time I tried to teach you to play basketball?” Mack shakes his head, chuckling. “You had a lousy jump shot.”

He stands, sighs, looks around. He puts the photo back in his pocket.

“I’m going to miss you, Ivan,” he says, and then he leaves. He doesn’t look back.

leaving

Early in the morning, Maya arrives with many other humans.

Some have white coats. Some have rustling papers. They are hushed, busy, determined.

Ruby enters her box first.

“I’m scared, Ivan,” she calls from inside the box. “I don’t want to leave you.”

A part of me doesn’t want her to leave either, but I know I can’t tell her that.

“Think of all the amazing stories you can share with your new family,” I say.

Ruby falls silent.

“I’ll tell them your elephant joke,” she says after a long pause. “The one about the refrigerator.”

“I bet they’d like that. And be sure to tell them about Bob and Julia and me.” I clear my throat. “And Stella.”

“I’ll remember everyone,” Ruby says. “Especially you.”

Before I can say any more, they roll her cage out to a waiting truck.

It’s my turn.

Bob is hiding in a corner, behind my pool. The humans don’t even notice him.

While they're busy making sure my box is ready, Bob sneaks over. He licks my chin, just in case there are any leftovers.

"You," I whisper, "are the One and Only Bob."

I reach for Not-Tag. She is a limp rag without her stuffing. Dribbles of paint cover her fur.

I hold her out to Bob. He tilts his head, confused.

"To help you sleep," I say.

Bob takes her in his teeth and slips away.



good boy

“Good Ivan, good boy,” Maya says when I lumber into my box. I hear the clicker, and I’m rewarded with a tiny marshmallow.

When I’m settled, Maya gives me a sweet drink that tastes of mango and something bitter.

My eyelids grow heavy. I want to see what happens next, but I am sleepy, so sleepy.

I dream I’m with Tag and we’re swinging from vines while Stella watches. The sun slices through the thick ceiling of trees and the breeze tastes like fruit.

moving

My eyes flutter open.

The box is moving.

I am in the grumbling belly of some great beast.

I fall back asleep.

awakening

I awake to glass and steel. It's a new cage not unlike my old cage, except that it's much cleaner.

Maya's here, and other humans I recognize.

"Hey there, Ivan," Maya says. "He's coming to, guys."

I have three walls of glass. The fourth wall is a curtain of wooden slats strung together.

This doesn't look like the zoos on TV. Where are the other animals?

Where are the gorillas?

Is this where Ruby ended up? In a cage just like her old cage, still alone? Is she cold? Hungry? Sad?

Is there anyone to tell her stories when she can't get to sleep?

missing

I miss my old cozy cage.

I miss my art.

But most of all, I miss Bob.

My belly's cold without him.

food

The food is fine here.

No soda, though, or cotton candy.

not famous

I have no visitors here, no sticky-fingered children or weary parents.

Only Maya and her humans come, with their soothing voices and soft hands.

I wonder if I have stopped being famous.

something in the air

Endless days pass, and then I notice something.

A change.

I don't know what it is, but I taste it in the air, like faroff rain clouds gathering.

a new tv

Maya brings me a TV. It is bigger than my old one.

She turns it on. “I think you’re going to like this show,” she says, smiling.

I’m hoping for a romance, or maybe a Western.

But it’s a nature show, one without human voices or ads. It’s a show about gorillas being gorillas. I watch them eat and groom and play-fight. I even watch them sleep.

I wonder why Mack never put on this channel.

the family

Every day I watch the gorillas on the TV screen. It's a small family and an odd one, just three females and a juvenile male, without a silverback to protect them.

They groom each other and eat and sleep, then groom each other some more. They are a contented group, placid and good-natured, although, like any family, they bicker from time to time.

excited

This morning, for some reason, there is no gorilla show on TV.

Maya and the other humans are excited. They chirp like birds at dawn.

“Today’s the day,” they say.

I’ve watched many humans watch me, but never have they looked so happy.

Maya goes to the wall of wooden slats.

She grins goofily.

She pulls a string.

what I see

Gorillas.

Three females and a juvenile male.

It's the family I've been watching. But they're not on a TV screen.

They're on the other side of the glass, watching me watching them.

I see me.

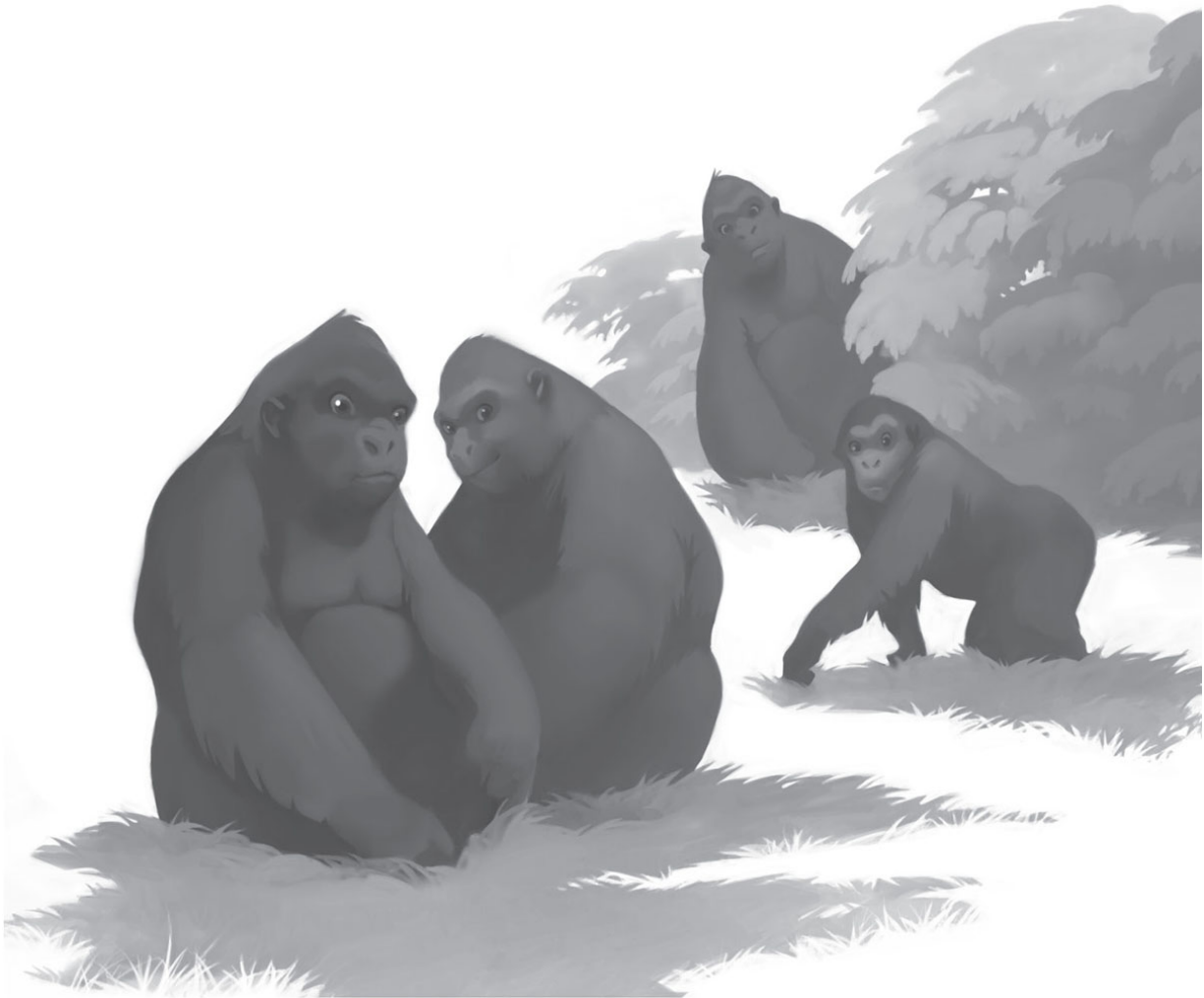
Lots of me.

still there

I cover my eyes.

I look again.

They are still there.



watching

Every day, I watch them through my window, the way my visitors used to watch me.

See how they chase, groom? See how they play, sleep? See how they live?

They're graceful the way Stella was, moving just enough, only as much as they need.

They stare at me, heads tilted, pointing and hooting, and I wonder: Are they as fascinated by me as I am by them?

she

Her hoots make my ears hurt.

I admire her intact canines from afar.

Her name is Kinyani.

She is faster than I am, spry and probably smarter, although I am twice her size and that, too, is important.

She is terrifying.

And beautiful, like a painting that moves.

door

Today the humans lead me to a door.

On the other side, Kinyani and the others wait for me.

I'm not ready for this. I'm not ready to be a silverback.

I'm Ivan, just Ivan, only Ivan.

I decide it's not a good day to socialize.

I'll try again tomorrow.

wondering

All night I lie awake, wondering about Ruby.

Has she already walked through a door like the one I'm facing?

Was she as scared as I am? Scared the way she must have been that day she fell in the hole?

I think of Ruby's endless curiosity, and of the questions she loved to ask. *Have you ever danced with a tiger, Ivan? Will your fur turn blue? Why doesn't that little boy have a tail?*

If Ruby were here with me, she'd be asking: *What's on the other side of the door, Ivan?*

Ruby would want to know, and she would have been through that door by now.

ready

“Want to try again, Ivan?” Maya asks. I think of Ruby, and I tell myself it’s time.

The door opens.

outside at last

Sky.
Grass.
Tree.
Ant.
Stick.
Bird.
Dirt.
Cloud.
Wind.
Flower.
Rock.
Rain.

Mine.
Mine.
Mine.

oops

I sniff, approach, strut a bit, but the others don't welcome me. They have sharp teeth and loud voices.

Did I do something wrong?

Kinyani chases me. She throws a stick at me. She corners me.

I know that she's testing me to see if I'm a true silverback, one who can protect her family.

I cower and hide my eyes.

Maya lets me back into my cage.

what it was like

I lie awake and try to remember what it was like, being a gorilla.

How did we move? How did we touch? How did we know who was boss?

I try to think past the babies and the motorbikes and the popcorn and the short pants.

I try to imagine Ivan as he might have been.

pretending

The juvenile male approaches. He's eyeing my food hungrily.

I imagine a different Ivan, my father's son.

I grumble and swat and swagger. I beat my chest till the whole world hears.

Kinyani watches, and so do the others.

I move toward the young upstart, and he retreats.

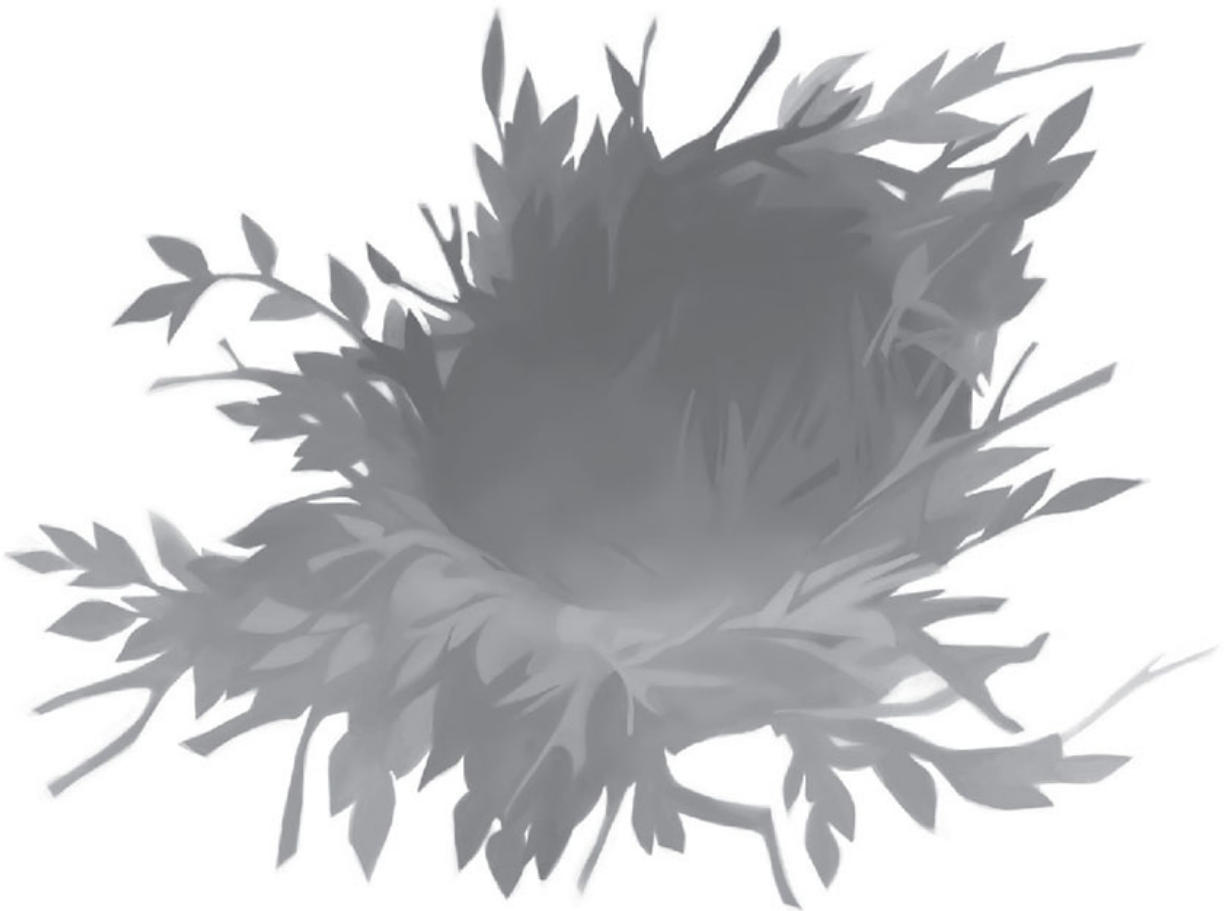
Almost as if he believes I'm the silverback I'm pretending to be.

nest

I'm making a nest on the ground. It isn't a true jungle nest. The leaves are inferior and the sticks are brittle. They snap when I weave them into place.

The others watch, grunting their disapproval: *too small, too flimsy, an ugly thing to see.*

But when I climb into that leafy cradle, it's like floating on treetop mist.



more tv

Maya wants me to go back to my glass cage. I can tell, because she is tempting me toward the door with a trail of tiny marshmallows.

I try to ignore her. I don't want to leave the outside. It's a cloudless day, and I've found just the right spot for a nap. But I relent when she adds yogurt raisins to the trail. She knows my weaknesses all too well.

In the glass cage, the TV is on. It's another nature show, jerky and unfocused.

I expect to see gorillas, but none appear.

I hear a shrill sound, like a toy trumpet.

My heart quickens.

I rush close to the screen, and there she is.

Ruby.

She is rolling in a lovely pool of mud with two other young elephants.

Another elephant approaches. She towers over Ruby. She strokes Ruby, nudges her. She makes soft noises.

They stand side by side, just the way Stella and Ruby used to do. Their trunks entwine. I see something new in Ruby's eyes, and I know what it is.

It's joy.

I watch the whole thing, and then Maya plays it again for me, and again. At last she turns off the TV and carries it out of the cage.

I put my hand to the glass. Maya looks over.

Thank you, I try to say with my eyes. Thank you.

it

Kinyani ambles toward me. She taps me on the shoulder and knuckle runs away.

I watch her, arms crossed over my chest. I'm careful not to make a sound.

I'm not sure what we're doing.

She ambles back, shoves at me, dashes past. And then I realize what's happening.

We're playing.

We're playing *tag*.

And I'm it.

romance

Make eye contact.

Show your form.

Strut.

Grunt.

Throw a stick.

Grunt some more.

Make some moves.

Romance is hard work.

It looks so easy on TV.

I'm not sure I will ever get the hang of it.

more about romance

I wish Bob were here. I could use some advice.

I try to recall all the romance movies we watched together.

I remember the talking, the hugging, the face licking.

I'm not very good at this.

But it's fun trying.

grooming

Is there anything sweeter than the touch of another as she pulls a dead bug from your fur?

talk

Gorillas aren't chatty, like humans, prone to gossip and bad jokes.

But now and again we swap a story under the sun.

One day it's my turn.

I tell my troop about Mack and Ruby and Bob and Stella and Julia and George, about my mother and father and sister.

When I am done, they look away, silent.

Kinyani moves closer. Her shoulder brushes mine, and we let the sun soak into our fur. Together.

the top of the hill

I've explored every nook and cranny of this place, except for a hill at the far end where workers have been repairing a wall.

They're finally gone. They've left behind fresh white brick and a mound of black dirt.

While the others laze in the morning sun, I want to explore the hilltop. They've been there before, and I have not. Everything is still fresh to my eyes.

I take my time going uphill, savoring the feel of grass on my knuckles. The breeze carries the shouts of children and the drowsy hum of bumblebees. Near the top of the hill is a low-limbed tree, the kind my sister would have loved.

The wall is endless, clean and white, stretching far down to the habitats beyond my own. It's high and wide, carefully built to keep us in and others out.

This is, after all, still a cage.

It rained last night, and the pile of dirt is soft to the touch. I scoop up a handful and breathe in the loamy smell.

It's a rich brown color, heavy and cool in my palm.

And the wall waits, like an endless blank billboard.

the wall

It's a big wall.

But it's a big pile of dirt, and I'm a big artist.

I slap handfuls of mud on the warm cement. I make a handprint.

I tap my nose with a muddy finger. I make a noseprint.

I slide my palms up and down. The mud is thick and hard to use. But I keep moving and scooping and spreading.

I don't know what I'm making, and I don't care. I make swoops and swirls and thick lines. Figures and shapes. Light and shadow.

I'm an artist at work.

When I'm done, I step back to admire my work. But it's a large canvas, and I'd like to get a better view.

I go to the thick-limbed tree and grab the lowest branch. I try to swing my legs.

Umph. I land hard. I'm too big to climb, I suppose.

I try again anyway, and this time I pull myself onto the first limb, gasping for breath.

One more limb, two, and I can't go any farther. Perched halfway up the tree, I see my troop, still dozing contentedly.

I take in the wall, splattered and splashed with mud. Not much color, but lots of movement. I like it. It feels dreamy and wild, like something Julia might have made.

From my seat in the tree, I can see beyond the wall. I see giraffes and hippos. I see deer with legs like delicate twigs. I see a bear snoozing in a hollow log.

I see elephants.

safe

She's far away, belly deep in tall grass with others by her side.

Ruby.

"She's here, Stella," I whisper. "Ruby's safe. Just like I promised."



I call to Ruby, but the wind tugs at my words and I know she'll never hear me.

Still, Ruby pauses for a second, her ears spread wide like tiny sails.

Then, with lumbering grace, she moves on through the grass.

silverback

It's a cloudy evening, chill and drizzly. Dinner is on its way, but I don't care.

At night we sleep in our den, but I'm always the last to head inside. I've been inside long enough.

This time of day, there aren't many visitors. Just a few stragglers, leaning on the wall that separates us. They point, take a couple photos, then head over to the nearby giraffes.

One of the keepers is beckoning. Reluctantly I turn to go.

Out of the corner of my eye, I see someone running. I pause.

It's a girl with dark hair, lugging a backpack. A man follows behind, racing to catch up.

"Ivan!" the girl yells. "Ivan!"

It's Julia!

I scramble to the edge of the wide moat that skirts the wall.

Julia and George wave to me. I dash back and forth, hooting and grunting, doing a gorilla dance of happiness.

"Calm down," says a voice. "You're behaving like a chimp."

I freeze.

A tiny, nut-brown, big-eared head pops out of Julia's backpack.

"Nice place," Bob says.

“Bob,” I say. “It’s really you.”

“In the flesh.”

“How ... where...” I can’t seem to find any words.

“George’s job at the zoo doesn’t start till next month, so he and Julia made an agreement. She’s walking three extra dogs to cover my food. And get this: they’re *all poodles*.”



“You said you didn’t want a home,” I say.

“Yeah,” Bob says. “But Julia’s mom likes my company. So I figure I’m doing everybody a favor. It’s a win-win.”

Julia pushes Bob’s head back inside her backpack. “You’re not supposed to be here,” she reminds him.

“Ivan looks great, doesn’t he, Jules?” George asks. “Stronger. Happier, even.”

Julia holds up a little photo, but it’s too far away for me to see. “It’s Ruby, Ivan. She’s with other elephants now. Because of you.”

I know, I want to tell her. I saw with my own eyes.

We stare across the expanse that separates us. After a while, George pats Julia’s arm. “Time to go, Jules.”

Julia gives a wistful smile. “Bye, Ivan. Say hello to your new family.” She turns to George. “Thank you, Dad.”

“For what?”

“For—” She gestures toward me. “For this.”

They turn to leave. The lamps that light the zoo pathways blink on, blanketing the world with yellow light.

I can just make out Bob’s little head sticking out of Julia’s backpack. “You are the One and Only Ivan,” he calls.

I nod, then turn toward my family, my life, my home.

“Mighty Silverback,” I whisper.



Acknowledgments

My thanks to the talented folks at HarperCollins for their expertise and enthusiasm. A special shout-out to art director extraordinaire, Amy Ryan; to the incomparable Sarah Hoy for her lovely book design; and to copyeditor Renée Cafiero, the best in the biz.

Most of all, I'm indebted to Anne Hoppe, my remarkable editor, who has the ear of a poet, the eye of an artist, and the patience of a preschool teacher (and those are just a few of her superpowers). Thank you, Anne, for everything. I couldn't have done this without you. Really.

To my parents, Roger and Suzanne; my siblings, Stu, Martha, and Lisa; my dear, old (but not *that* old!) friends Lisa Leach and Suzanne Hultman: I know how truly lucky I am to have you in my life.

And to Julia, Jake, and Michael: Humans have so many words, more than we truly need. Still, there are no words that can ever express how much I love you all.

Bonus Material

The
ONE
AND ONLY
Ivan

BONUS MATERIAL

*Sneak peek at **The One and Only Bob***

Author's Note

Ivan's Signature

Excerpt from *The One and Only Bob*

Read on for a special look at the sequel to
The One and Only Ivan, starring Bob

The ONE AND ONLY BOB



Sequel to the Newbery Medal Winner **THE ONE AND ONLY IVAN**

Katherine Applegate

canine glossary



let's play



life's good



get lost



I'm scared



I'm cool



I surrender

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I harass innocent squirrels. I hog the couch. I lick myself in the presence of company.

I'm no saint, okay?



and while i'm at it

I may or may not have eaten a pepperoni pizza with anchovies when nobody was looking.

Also, I may or may not have eaten a coconut vanilla birthday cake when nobody was looking.

Also, I may or may not have eaten a Thanksgiving turkey (except for the stuffing—way too much rosemary) when nobody was looking.

Nobody looking. That seems to be the common thread.

As they say on the crime shows: motive and opportunity.

robert

Name's Bob.

I'm a mutt of uncertain heritage. Definitely some Chihuahua, with a smidgen of papillon on my father's side.

You're probably thinking I'm some wimpy lap dog. The kind you see poking out of an old lady's purse like a hairy key chain. But size ain't everything.

It's swagger. Attitude. You gotta have the moves.

Probably I shoulda been named Bruiser or Bamm-Bamm or Bandit, but Bob's what I got and Bob'll do me just fine.

Julia named me. Long time ago. She's my girl. She calls me "Robert" when I get on her nerves.

Happens pretty often, to be honest.

numero uno

There's an old saying about us dogs, goes like this: *It's no coincidence that man's best friend can't talk.*

Lemme tell you something. If we *could* talk to people, they'd get an earful.

You ever hear anyone mention man being dog's best friend?

Nope?

Didn't think so.

Way I've always figured it, end of the day, you gotta be your own best friend. Look out for numero uno.

Learned that one the hard way.

That's not to say I don't have a best pal. I do.

Gorilla, name of Ivan. Big guy and I go way, way back.

Gorilla and dog. Yep, I know. You don't see that every day. Long story.

I love that big ol' ape. Ditto our little elephant friend, Ruby.

They're the best.

how we met

The first time I met Ivan, I was a homeless puppy. Desperate, starving, all alone.

It was the middle of the night, and I'd slipped into the mall where Ivan lived in a cage. I wandered a bit, grateful for the warmth, confused by the weird assortment of sleeping animals I found there, checking every trash can for anything edible.

There was a small hole in a corner of Ivan's enclosure. He was fast asleep, cuddled up with a worn stuffed animal that looked like a weary gorilla.

He was snoring, and man, that guy snored like a pro.

In his open palm was a chunk of banana, and—I still get shivers when I think about this—I ate it right out of his hand.

Guy coulda squeezed his fingers shut and I woulda popped like a puppy balloon. But he just kept on sleeping.

And then—more shivers—I am either a maniac or the bravest dog on the planet, probably a little of both—I hopped up onto that big, round, furry tummy of his.

That's right. I climbed Mount Ivan.

Crazy, I know. I have no idea what I was thinking. Maybe I was so exhausted I went a little bonkers. Maybe he just looked so warm and cozy that I figured it was worth taking a chance.

I did my bed boogie. Dogs don't feel right till we do a quick dance before settling.

Once I had things just so, I lay down in a little puppy lump and rode the waves on that tummy like a puny boat on a great brown sea.

When Ivan opened his eyes the next morning, he didn't seem surprised in the least to find a puppy snoozing on his belly. He refused to move until I woke up.

I think he was as glad as I was to have found a new friend.



Author's Note

The One and Only Ivan is a work of fiction, but the inspiration for this imagined tale lies in a true story.

Ivan, a real gorilla, lived at Zoo Atlanta, but on the way to that happy ending, he spent almost three decades without seeing another of his own kind.

After being captured as an infant in what is now the Democratic Republic of the Congo (Ivan's twin sister died en route to the U.S. or shortly thereafter), Ivan was raised in a home until he became unmanageable. At that point he was added to an odd collection of animals housed at a circus-themed mall in Washington state.

Ivan spent twenty-seven years of his life alone in a cage. Over time, as an understanding of primate needs and behavior grew, public discomfort with Ivan's lonely state grew as well, particularly after he was featured in a *National Geographic* special entitled *The Urban Gorilla*. A public outcry followed, including heartfelt letters from children. When the mall where Ivan lived went bankrupt, he was placed on permanent loan to Zoo Atlanta, which houses the largest group of captive western lowland gorillas in the nation.

Ivan became a beloved celebrity at Zoo Atlanta, where he lived contentedly with Kinyani and other gorillas. He was known for his paintings, which were often "signed" with his thumbprint.

Ivan and Kinyani were real gorillas—and so, by the way, was Jambo, whose story Stella tells to Ivan and Bob. But all other characters and situations in this novel are entirely the product of my imagination. When I started to write about the grim facts of Ivan's solitary existence, a new tale slowly began to take shape. At least on the page, where anything is possible, I wanted to give Ivan (even while captive behind the walls of his tiny cage) a voice of his own and a story to tell. I wanted to give him someone to protect, and the chance to be the mighty silverback he was always meant to be.

Visit [HarperCollins.com](https://www.harpercollins.com) for more resources for *The One and Only Ivan*!

Ivan's Signature

Dear Reader,

Every summer, my friend Donna and I rely on students, teachers, librarians, and authors from around the world to help us pick a character from a children's book to take on a literary road trip. During the 2012 road trip, we traveled over 4,000 miles with a stuffed gorilla who wore a personalized T-shirt that author Katherine Applegate had specially made, and a copy of *The One and Only Ivan*.

If I asked stuffed-animal Ivan to write about the most memorable afternoon during our journey, I know he would waste few words describing when the REAL Ivan stood five feet from us and signed my copy of *The One and Only Ivan*. My eyes fill with tears just thinking about that memorable afternoon. I can still see Ivan's loving caretaker, Jodi, feeding him blueberries. I hear her say, "Ivan, are you ready to sign your book?" She gently guides his finger into a can of green paint. He presses down inside the book, leaving his distinguished mark. After he signs the book, he does not let us out of his sight—it looks as though the deepest, wisest thoughts are running through his head.

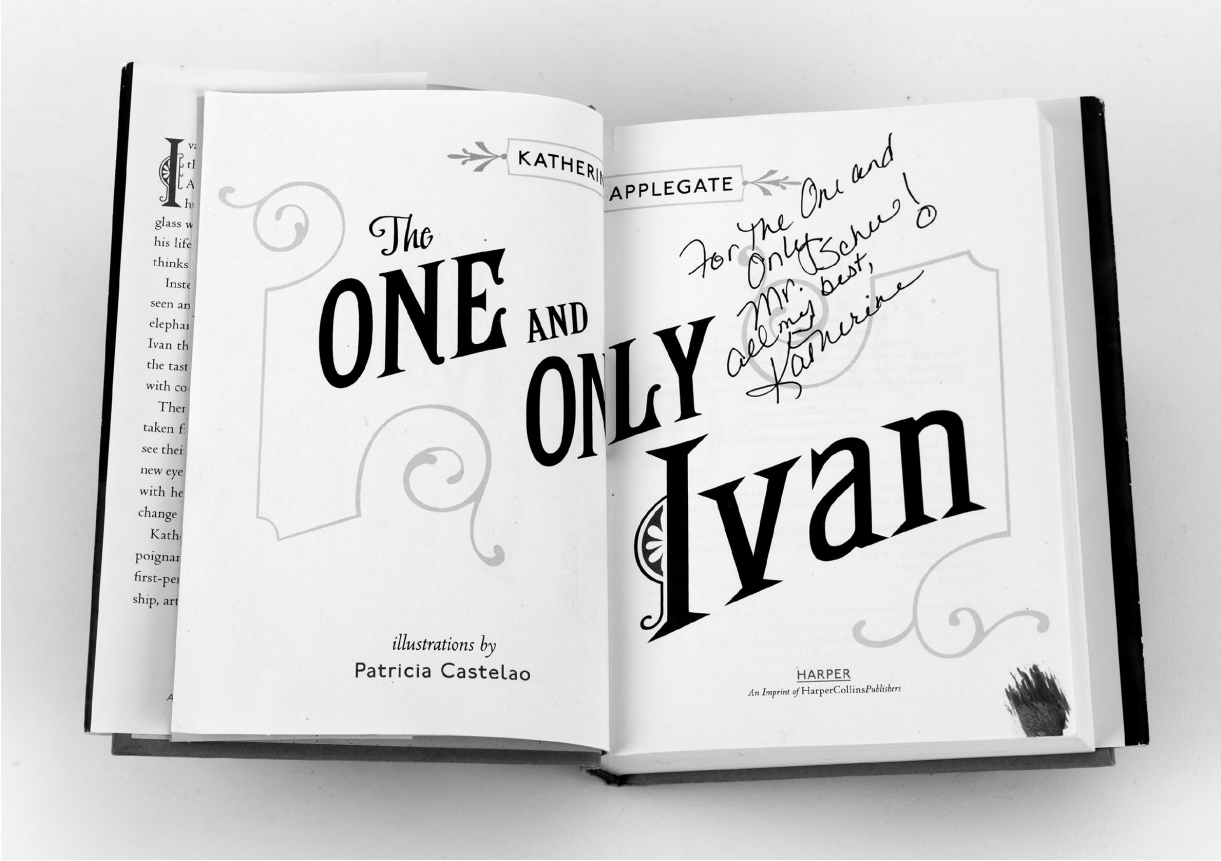
I sent Jodi the following email message on January 28, 2013, the day *The One and Only Ivan* won the Newbery Medal:

Dear Jodi, "I hope *The One and Only Ivan* wins the Newbery Medal" is the last thing you said to me when I met you and Ivan. It happened! It really happened! It fills my heart with joy to know kids will always know about Ivan, the mighty silverback, who touched your heart and mine. Thank you for taking care of Ivan for so many years.

Best, John

I'm so happy to be able to share Ivan's signature with you.

—John Schumacher



Credits

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Cover design by Sarah Hoy

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The One and Only Ivan

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First Edition

The ONE AND ONLY BOB



Sequel to the Newbery Medal Winner **THE ONE AND ONLY IVAN**

Katherine Applegate

KATHERINE APPLEGATE

The
ONE AND ONLY BOB

illustrations by
Patricia Castelao

HARPER
An Imprint of HarperCollinsPublishers

Dedication

*for my family:
human, feline,
and—of course—canine*

Epigraph

For small creatures such as we the vastness is bearable only through love.

—Carl Sagan

To err is human; to forgive, canine.

—Unknown

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then, to my surprise
yay
traffic stop
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hero
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Four

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I think he was as glad as I was to have found a new friend.

the amazing history of man's best friend

Before long, me and Ivan were best buddies.

We're an unlikely pair, sure. Ivan's calm and serene, a philosopher, an artist. I wish I could be more like that. No one's ever accused me of being levelheaded.

Hotheaded, sure.

And I can't talk pretty like Ivan can. I'm a street dog, after all. And proud of it.

Still, we clicked, in a way I never had with humans. "Man's best friend"? No way. "Gorilla's best friend"? You bet.

Seems to me the first time I ever heard that phrase—"man's best friend"—was while I was watching TV with Ivan.

Back in the day, Ivan had this little television, and we watched a lot of stuff together. Old movies, Westerns, cartoons, you name it. Poor guy was stuck in a cage, didn't have a lot else to do except throw me-balls at gaping humans.

Anyways. Me and Ivan, big fans of the tube. Cat food commercials. Pro bowling. *Dancing with the Stars*. What's not to like?

Once we watched this special on the nature channel. It was called *The Amazing History of Man's Best Friend*. Show was all about famous dogs. There were rescue dogs and therapy dogs and war dogs and fire dogs and movie dogs and this dogs and that dogs. And between you and me, most of 'em were just plain overachievers.

Then they got to this dog named Hach-something-or-other. Hatchet-toe, maybe? Seems his owner died (for the record, I object to the word “owner,” but we’ll set that aside for now), and Hach-something-or-other sat around for over nine years in the same spot at the same train station, day after day, waiting for him to return.

Thing is, the narrator guy was blabbing on and on about this dog, really over-the-top stuff: *How loyal! How loving! Break out the Kleenex! Blah blah blah, wah wah wah! Man’s best friend!*

They made a statue of this dog. I kid you not.

A statue of the dog who sat around nine years waiting for a dead guy.

in my opinion

That dog was a ninny.

A numskull.

A nincompoop.

i'm yours

Lemme tell you about being man's best friend.

Being man's best friend can mean a lot of things. Companionship. Belly rubs. Tennis balls.

But it can also mean a dark, endless highway and an open truck window.

It can mean the smell of the wet wind as hands grab the box you're in with your brothers and sisters and you go sailing into the unkind night and still, still, crazy as it sounds, you're thinking, *But I'm yours, I'm yours, I'm yours.*

no one

That's what being man's best friend can get you.

A black highway.

An empty box.

And no one in the world but you.

early days

I don't remember much about my early puppy days. It was three years ago, but sometimes it feels like three hundred. Mostly I recall fighting with my sibs for the primo meal spot. Lots of squirming and squeaking. Everything soft and milk-smelling and movable. Like we were one great big complicated animal.

I never met my dad, and my mom didn't say much about him, except that he was trouble. Mom had a beautiful fawn coat. Chihuahua, some this, some that. Nice messy bloodline.

Mutts rule.

Mom crooned to us. Told us stories. Laid down the law.

I wonder if she knew she didn't have much time to prepare us for the world.

We were born in a dark place. Probably under some porch stairs, I suspect, since I remember the sound of boots plodding up and down, the biting and ugly smell of human feet.

They called my mom Reo. And they fed her most days, though sometimes she had to fend for herself.

She never showed fear toward them, or respect. Indifference, I guess you'd say. Unless they tried to handle one of us. She growled then, hoping to make it clear that we were hers and hers alone.

I myself got picked up a couple times. The hands reached in, grabbed. They were rough and smelled of strange scents, bitter and meaty.

My mom's growl made me fearless, and I wriggled and yipped. The hands shoved me back to the warm place, where I could sleep and drink and

dream in safety.

Still, I understood, in my simple puppy way, that dogs belonged to humans, and that was how it would always be.

boss

My mom wasn't much for names. She'd had a lot of litters. I guess she'd run out of ideas.

My brother "First" was, natch, the firstborn. "Runt," my youngest bro, was the last. "Dot" had a little spot on her back, and "Yip" was always complaining. I was "Rowdy." Goes without saying. And that left my oldest sister. We all called her "Boss."

Boss was small but mean, with a distinctive sharp-sounding bark. She could outmaneuver any of us to the best spot for dining.

I admired her grit. Even if she did get on my nerves.

When we got a bit older, less blind, more cocky, I fought her off occasionally. But mostly Boss won. She was fearless, that pup.

alone

The truck happened without warning one night. They threw us in a box, left my mom behind. I can still hear her frantic howls.

I landed in a muddy ditch. It was a cloudy night, nearly freezing. Even the moon had abandoned me.

And the smells! Everything so wild and unknown. Animals with big jaws and bigger appetites. Birds that swooped in to kill. Death and life all mixed up together.

I searched for my siblings until the truth became clear: I was utterly alone.

cars

The next morning I began my slow journey, moving through the tall, wet grass, my limbs stiff from the cold.

Now and then, I'd drink from a mud puddle or gnaw on some grass. By evening I was wobbly with hunger and thirst.

I followed the highway. Every time a four-wheeled creature roared by, I froze in fear. And yet—and this is what slays me—I knew that cars meant humans, and humans meant the possibility of living, just as much as they meant the possibility of dying.

the owl

Darkness had fallen when it came out of nowhere, the owl.

A shadow in a shadow.

They don't make a sound, you know. Not a sound.

It's quite impressive, when you think about it.



luck

Just as her talons, those marvelous weapons, raked my fur, I caught my right front foot in a small hole and stumbled.

If she'd gotten hold of my body, I wouldn't be here. But all she managed to do was grab my tail.

Only time in my life I've regretted my handsome hindquarters.

I was airborne, hanging upside down, dizzy and dazed. And just crazy enough to think, *Hey, I'm actually flying*, before the terror hit full force.

I caught a whiff of other animals below. Later I found out they were pocket gophers, but back then I just knew I was smelling something completely foreign.

The owl must have decided the gophers would make a more satisfying meal. She let loose her grip, and I plummeted to the earth.

more luck

Maybe it was my puppy fat, or my soft bones, or my incredible good fortune.

But I didn't die.

Didn't even break anything.

I'd flown twice in my short life and lived to tell the tale.

will

I found a small hollow at the base of a fallen tree. Poked my nose in and got a swat and hiss from a grouchy raccoon.

Kept going. Waddling, whimpering.

Lights ahead. New, strange smells.

Kept going.

Kept going.

It's amazing how much the sheer will not to die can keep you moving.

exit 8

I finally came to a small road curving off the main highway. Exit 8, turned out to be. A big billboard overhead had a picture of a terrifying animal on it.

Course I didn't know what a billboard was. Didn't know that the scary animal was a gorilla, let alone that he would become my dearest friend.

But something told me to follow the off-ramp.

And eventually I ended up at the Exit 8 Big Top Mall and Video Arcade, Home of the One and Only Ivan.

history

I made it to the mall. Slept in dirty hay by some garbage bins. The next night, I found that hole in Ivan's cage. Stole his banana. Slept on his belly. And the rest, as they say, is history.

For two years, I lived at that seedy old place that was part mall, part circus, and all crummy.

But that was nothing compared to Ivan. He spent twenty-seven lousy years there. And our dear friend Stella, an old circus elephant, was stuck there for most of her life, too.

When Stella passed away, it nearly broke Ivan's heart. I tried like crazy to get him through those dark days. But what really saved him, I think, was Ruby, our baby elephant friend.

Before Stella died, Ivan promised her he'd get Ruby outa that awful place. And to my amazement, he actually pulled it off.

Ivan and Ruby and a bunch of our other pals ended up going to different places, zoos and sanctuaries that knew how to take care of them. They're with others of their own kind. And they're loved and well cared for. It's been over a year now since we all moved, and they seem so much happier.

Me, I lucked out. My girl, Julia, whose dad had worked at the mall, decided her family needed a dog. Who was I to argue? Two square meals, my own bed, all the belly rubs I could beg for. What dog in his right mind would say no to that?

The best part is, we don't live far from Ivan and Ruby. I get to see 'em all the time.

I'm glad they're nearby. And I'm thrilled they've settled in so well. Really. It's a solid solution.

But it's not a perfect one.

tennis ball

The way I understand things, it's like this. We live on a lonely ball called Earth, and humans have basically been throwing it against the wall for so long that the poor ol' ball is falling apart.

It's like me with a tennis ball, chewing away until it's nothing but pieces of slimy rubber that taste like, well, slimy rubber.

And that means there aren't as many places left for wild animals.

Seems there are good zoos and bad zoos and good sanctuaries and bad sanctuaries, just like there are good dog families and bad dog families. The good places are trying to keep wild species healthy and safe. They don't want endangered animals to go away forever.

They also don't want the Earth to turn into a slimy, dilapidated tennis ball.

Although honestly, slimy rubber doesn't taste half bad.

You should try it sometime.

The thing is, I would give anything to see my dear pal Ivan deep in the jungles of Africa, where he was born. Or to see Ruby running across the savanna with a herd of elephants, her big ol' ears flapping in the wind.

I'd give up a mile-high pile of bacon cheeseburgers to see that happen. I really would.

But it ain't happening. I get that, and so do they.

When you're an animal, it helps to be a realist.



Two



dream

This morning I wake up in my cozy bed, way too early for Julia to make me breakfast. She and her mom and dad are still asleep, and even the guinea pigs are silent. My belly grumbles, and once again I curse my thumblessness.

Humans are one big design flaw. The inferior noses. The inscrutable, humdrum rumps. And don't get me started on their—ahem—odor. But the opposable thumb idea? Yeah, that was a nice upgrade.

The cans I could open! The doorknobs I could conquer!

Anyways. I feel worried. Off.

Worry's a waste of time. And it doesn't fit with my tough-guy act. But sometimes I can't seem to help myself.

Before I woke up, I'd been dreaming about Ivan and Ruby and Stella.

It wasn't a nice dream, a fun-and-run toe-twitcher.

Nope. This one was a nightmare. A bad one.

We were swimming, all four of us, in a black, raging river. For some reason, I was in the lead. And I kept looking back, telling them I was gonna save them.

Me. Save them. Two elephants and a gorilla.

As I paddled like mad, their voices faded. I looked behind me and they'd vanished.



And then I heard it.

A faint bark.

That bark.

I woke up then, like I always do.

I did an all-over shake, trying to toss off the stench of nightmare that clung to me like shampoo after a bath.

I told myself to chill. Get a grip. Stop worrying about nothing.

And yet, some primitive part of my brain—the wolf in me, maybe—is on edge.

A lot can go wrong in the moment left to chance, the blink of an eye, the bounce of a bone.

There are so many ways the world can find to fail you.

the smell of a storm

By the time everyone else wakes up, I've calmed down. But the wind outside sure hasn't.

It's an early-fall Saturday, gusty, with scraps of sun. Clouds bouncing off each other like bunnies in a basket. Messages on the wind pouring in from everywhere. From dogs making their daily rounds, from feral cats, from anxious raccoons.

Basically everybody is asking the same thing: *What is the deal with the weather today?*

I already know. Weather channel was on last night, with a screen full of big, white, cotton-candy-looking swirls. Julia's dad, George, has already taped up several windows. Sara, her mom, packed an emergency bag just in case we have to evacuate.

Another hurricane is on its way. Third this season. Not as big as the last couple, but slow-moving. I've seen the routine, know the ropes.

Once breakfast is done, I sit on the couch in the living room, waiting impatiently for Julia to come home so she can take me on our daily stroll. She has a dog-walking service, and she's out walking other dogs.

I get my own private walk, 'cause she's my own private girl.

I can practically taste the storm coming through the open window: the back-of-my-throat tingle, the metallic edge, the fizzy energy.

But it's more than that. It's as if the air is up to no good, sneaking up on the world and looking for trouble.

on the poetry of stink

Of course, not everybody can smell what I'm smelling. My nose is a zillion times more powerful than a human's.

Dogs are experts at odor. Students of stink. We analyze the air the way humans read poetry, searching for invisible truths.

And we don't just smell the good and bad stuff that people notice with their substandard schnozzes. The usual suspects: popcorn and lilacs and freshly sharpened pencils. Diapers and brussels sprouts and freaked-out skunks.

No, our noses get it all, the whole shimmery double rainbow in April. Humans, they're lucky to get a cloudy day in November.

We get that molecule of roast beef dancing on the wind fifty miles from the tidy kitchen where it just slid out of the oven.

We get the cherry lollipop under the back seat of the Honda sixteen cars up on the highway at rush hour.

We get things humans can't even dream of getting. We're the ones who find the miracle earthquake baby cuddled in her crib under tons of rubble.

We're the ones who find lost hikers in the wilderness after a quick whiff of a sweaty sock.

We can even tell when someone's sick. We can smell seizures and cancer and migraine headaches. Try getting your guinea pig to do that.

We smell feelings, too. Sad has a sharp scent, with an undertone of sweetness. Sad smells like being lost in a winter forest as the sun goes down.

And happy? Happy is the best, but there's a touch of wistfulness around the edges. Happy smells like bacon ice cream served up in an expensive leather shoe.

You're going to love every minute of it, but you know it won't last forever.

the news

Sometimes when Julia and I go for walks, I'll brake at a corner (corners are the best for fresh news), and she'll tug and say, *C'mon, Bob, there's nothing there.*

Oh, but there is.

Here's the thing about poop and pee. I get that humans are not into them. I see the bathroom doors shut tight. The embarrassed, downcast gazes.

You guys are totally missing out. There's a whole lot of info hiding in your average pee mail. When dogs want to share the latest gossip, we just wait until nature calls. You'd be amazed what we can learn during a quick bathroom break.

People read the news. Check the TV. Browse the web.

I linger over a fire hydrant and inhale the whole wide world.

My ears, by the way, are almost as remarkable as my nose. I pick up on all kinds of things humans can't hear.

What we do with our noses and our ears is kinda like taking a big ol' knot and loosening it up. Separating out the strands. Unbraiding things.

People smell a reeking pile of trash in a Dumpster. We smell a dollop of cream cheese, a hint of peanut butter, a smattering of Froot Loops.

People hear the roar of a crowd in a stadium. We hear a strain of whiny four-year-old, a whisper of worried superfan, a note of grumpy hot dog vendor.

Man, dogs are cool.

snickers

While I watch from my perch on the back of the couch, Julia passes by on the sidewalk. George asked her to keep her dog-walking route close to home, in case the weather changes.

She's wearing a shiny purple raincoat and leading three dogs: a goofy mutt named Winston, a timid dachshund named Oscar Mayer, and . . . *her*.

Snickers.

An old nemesis of mine, Snickers is a fluffy white poodle with delusions of grandeur. A big, snooty, pain in the puffball.

Ooh, that pooch drives me crazy.

Our mutual dislike goes back to my early days as a stray. Snickers was a fancy, pampered, sleep-on-a-pink-satin-pillow kinda gal. Her owner, Mack, ran the mall where I lived with Ivan and Ruby.

That's where I first encountered Snickers. She teased me mercilessly, and beneath the fuzzy facade, I always suspected there was a little, I dunno, spark there.

Anyways. After the mall closed down, Snickers, being Snickers, landed on her feet. Mack married an older widow lady with more money than sense, and she dotes on that ridiculous poodle. Mack's too lazy to walk Snickers himself, so he hired Julia to do it.

"Lookin' good, Snick baby!" I call through the open window, and she gives me her curled-lip, squinty-eyed face, which, come to think of it, is pretty much how she always looks.

As usual, Snickers is dressed to the max. She's wearing a pink poncho, a sparkly rain hat, and teensy pink boots.

"Those boots were made for mockin'," I add for good measure.

It feels good, giving her some grief. But before I can really relish the moment, another annoying acquaintance of mine appears.

nutwit

Nutwit, the gray squirrel who lives in the live oak in our front lawn, jumps to a lower branch, looking at me with barely concealed pity.

I hate pity. Especially the barely concealed kind.

“I don’t know why you taunt her,” he says. “You’re hardly in a position to talk, Bob. You *are* Snickers.”

“Come over here to the window and say that.”

“So you can, what, drool me to death?”

“Are you aware that my best friend is a gorilla?” I ask. “You would make fantastic ape chow, dude.”

Nutwit reaches for a dangling acorn and yanks it free. “I thought gorillas were vegetarians.”

“Ivan eats termites,” I say. “He might make an exception for you.”

“Face it, Bob. You’re soft. You’re one step away from your own pink rain boots.”

“He has a point,” says Minnie, one of the family’s guinea pigs, from her cage next to the TV.

“No, he doesn’t,” says Moo, her cagemate.

“Yes, he does,” Minnie squeaks.

“Doesn’t.”

“Does.”

“Does.”

“Doesn’t . . .” Minnie pauses. “Wait, you tricked me!”

The guinea pigs rarely agree on anything.

Nutwit leaps over to the window ledge, acorn in paw. He presses his tiny, twitchy nose to the screen. “You couldn’t last a day out here, Bob. Some of us have to live by our wiles.”

“Hey, I lived on the street longer than you’ve been alive.”

Nutwit nibbles his acorn. He’s quite the prissy eater. “Whatever you say, Bob.”

“I say scram.”

“Fine. Hint taken. Anyway, storm’s en route. I should be stocking up on my nut stash while I can.” Nutwit gives me a wise-guy look. “That’s how we do it in the real world.” He scampers off with an acrobatic flourish.

Squirrels never do a simple jump when a quadruple-backflip-cartwheel is an option.

“You’re full of it,” I say to nobody in particular.

“We’re full of it!” says Minnie.

“Yes, we’re extremely full of it!” says Moo, and they popcorn in agreement.

Guinea pigs hop up and down when they’re happy. It’s called popcorning. And it’s totally ridiculous.

You’re happy, wag your tail like a real mammal.

“I am not soft,” I mutter, nosing my protruding belly.

I leap, with effort, off the couch. Then I head to the bathroom for a good, long drink from the water bowl of power.

spoiled

I know Nutwit has a point.

I've become a creature of habit, spoiled after a stretch of being my own dog. For a long time, I was Bob the beast, cunning and streetwise.

As a stray, I lived off leftovers at the mall while Snickers dined on her fancy-pants kibble. Man, how I loved that cotton candy stuck to the floor. The unexpected UFOs. The ends of ketchup-covered hot dogs, scattered under the bleachers like, I dunno, big toes or something.

Ivan offered to share his gorilla food with me, and Stella and Ruby were always ready to pass along a carrot or an apple. But I refused. I needed to stay in shape, stay tough, stay true to my wild nature.

Okay, so maybe every now and then I'd sneak a banana chunk from Ivan's breakfast.

But then things changed. I became civilized. Domesticated. A *pet*.



Don't get me wrong. There are definitely some perks. Julia, who's an artist, painted my name on a food bowl. She gave me this wonderfully mushy

blanket, the kind where you can bed boogie forever till it's squished to perfection and you can curl up just so.

I love that blanket. But I simply cannot sleep without Not-Tag, Ivan's raggedy old toy gorilla.

Course, just when I get my blanket and Not-Tag imprinted with the right amount of Eau de Bob, Julia's mom does the unthinkable. Puts them in the washing machine and removes every last bit of . . . me.

There are other indignities I tolerate.

The daily walk on a tug-of-war string, after going stringless my whole life.

The attempts to train me. Like that'll ever happen.

The kisses and cuddling.

Well, the cuddling's okay, I s'pose.

But the kissing I just don't get. If you wanna kiss your dog, why not just give him a big old lick on the face and be done with it?

Anyways. So what if I've gotten a little spoiled? A tad soft around the edges?

There's a difference between being soft and being afraid. Being a coward.

another confession

Too bad I know the truth.

I'm both.

cricket bully

When Julia returns from walking her charges, I race over and give her a good ol' Bob-style hello. Lots of yipping and twirling, followed by some attempts to jump into her arms.

Humans love that stuff.

Julia looks at me sternly and says, "Robert, down."

I leap some more because I'm determined to convince her I'm incorrigible. Untrainable. It's part of my charm. My Bobliness.

"Down," she says again. From her coat pocket, she pulls out her little metal clicker, along with some treats.

I hate that clicker. It's meant to help train me. But it's like a cricket bully.

Here's the theory. I do something right, Julia clicks. Gives me a treat. The clicks tell me when I'm behaving, and the treats reinforce it.

If that happens enough, before your very eyes I'm supposed to transform into a Good Dog.

Well, I ain't that easy.

"Down, Bob." Julia tries again.

I want a treat, but not enough to cave. So I opt for a playbow. A compromise.

Julia sighs. "You are definitely a challenging student." To my annoyance, she puts the treats back in her pocket.

I think Julia may be onto me.



trust

A while ago, Julia got it into her head that I needed to improve my manners. We went to a dog-training class.

I wasn't really into the whole Sit and Stay and Do the Tango stuff.

The worst command of all? The truly inexcusable, only-a-human-could-come-up-with-it order?

LEAVE IT.

"Leave it" means Walk on by, Bob. Sure, there's a piece of bacon just inches from your drooling piehole, but do me a favor and just pretend it's not there, okay?

Uh, not okay. Where I come from, you never pass up a free meal. UFO drops to the carpet, it's mine. And I'll be chowing it down before you can say, *Where the heck is my meatball?*

Within minutes, I was accused of being an undermotivated student, which is totally unfair.

I am highly motivated.

Just show me some cheese, please.

Anyways. I may or may not have been a little unruly. Class-clown stuff. Tailspinning, a little random peeing, some zoomies, just for show.

"Class, you see that crazy dashing around he's doing?" said the teacher, pointing at me with an accusing finger. "We call that a FRAP. Frantic Random Activity Period."

She pulled Julia aside. “He’s a smart dog,” she said. “But he’s messing with you.”

Which was true. But I hated getting caught in the act. I’d thought I was more subtle.

“Bob needs to know who’s boss,” said the teacher. “He needs to see you as pack leader. Give him some time. I see this a lot with former strays. Takes them a while to trust people.”

Like forever, in my case.

As we left the class early, I yelled, “So long, suckers!” to my classmates.

Couldn’t help rubbing it in just a little.

my car thing

I s'pose the real reason for the training stuff isn't my bad manners. Although they leave a bit to be desired.

It's my car thing.

I've always had a hang-up about cars and trucks. Also riding lawn mowers. Go-karts. Anything with four wheels, an engine, and a driver.

Don't like 'em. Don't want to ride in 'em. Don't want anything to do with 'em.

Those copilot dogs with their heads hanging out the window, flying their drool flags? Boneheads.

First of all, it ain't safe. And second of all, bad stuff can happen after you climb into a car.

Take it from me.

When Julia and George and Sara realized I have transportation issues, they tried to lure me into the back seat of their car with treats.

But you'd be surprised how stubborn I can be.

I yelped so loud, the neighbors came running out to see what was happening to the poor little doggie.

Score one for the poor little doggie.

click

That's when they started clicker training me.

Click, here's a treat.

Come closer to the car, Bob.

Click, here's a treat.

Watch while I open the car door, Bob.

Click, here's a treat.

Come right up to the seat, Bob.

Click, here's a treat.

Come on in, Bob.

Bob?

BOB?

WHERE ARE YOU, BOB?

Yeah, it was like that a lot.

options

Still haven't been in a car—or a truck or a tractor, for that matter.

When I have to go to the rhymes-with-pet-threat, Julia and her parents walk me there.

They say elephants have long memories. Well, so do dogs, people.

It's not like I'm afraid. I'm just . . . exercising my options.

full wag

“Are you ready to head over to the park?” George asks as he passes through the living room. He’s carrying two flashlights and a roll of masking tape.

“Yep,” Julia says, and I do a head tilt to show I’m intrigued by the conversation.

The place where Ivan and Ruby live is called Wildworld Zoological Park and Sanctuary. But everybody just calls it “the park.”

George works at the park as head groundskeeper, which means I’ve got some sway. And everyone who’s employed there loves Julia.

“Gimme a minute. I just need to grab my coat,” says George.

“Straight home after that, though, Julia,” says Sara. “Just in case the weather gets worse. One minute the weatherman’s saying we’re going to have a little shower. Next minute it’s the storm of the century.”

Julia scratches my head. “I thought Hurricane Gus wasn’t coming till tomorrow.”

“Sometimes they change course,” says Sara. “They can be unpredictable.”

“You know,” George says with a wink, “in the old days, they only named hurricanes after women.”

Julia groans. “That is so sexist!”

“It’s not just the wind that I’m worried about on this one,” George says. “It’s the storm surge that could be a problem. Flooding.”

Julia tries to make me wear her mom's latest creation, a knitted dog sweater with *SECURITY* written on it.

Which I suppose is an ironic reference to my petite size.

I politely decline.

"All right, you win." Julia sighs. "Ready for your walk, Bob?"

At the mention of the word "walk," I go all crazy-mutt so it's clear I'm on board with the idea.

Humans love it when we get silly. I think they're so weighed down by people problems that sometimes they need to be reminded what happy looks like.

Julia attaches my string. I try for a little tug-of-war, but she refuses to buy it. "Let's go see Ivan and Ruby," she says.

Just hearing those names sends my tail into full wag.

good words, bad words

I've never met a dog who didn't get a big ol' grin on his kisser when "walk" slipped into a conversation.

Dogs understand more than you might think. The nature channel says we're about as smart as the average human toddler. Two-year-olds, my fuzzy rump! We're a million times brainier than some babbling rug rat.

There was a dog on that *Man's Best Friend* show who supposedly understood like a thousand human words. Border collie, I think. Those guys need to switch to decaf.

The narrator was gushing about this wonder dog, and I'm like, *Well, duh, brainiac, of course we understand people.*

Not everything, mind you. And some of us are more attentive than others. Depends a lot on just how interesting your humans happen to be.

Certain words will really cause our ears to perk up. The classics: *Treat. Walk. Frisbee. Bacon.*

And don't forget the swear words: *Vet. Bath. Fireworks. Vacuum cleaner.*

We *always* hear those.

clock versus moon

Julia and I wait by the front door while George says goodbye to Sara.

I think maybe the hardest thing for me about being domesticated—a “pet,” if you insist—is that I can’t control my own schedule. If I had my way, I’d hang out with Ivan and Ruby all day, every day.

Unfortunately, humans love their clocks.

Dogs, we use the sky to tell time, like any sensible creature. Sky says it’s dawn? Time to eat. It’s noon? Time to eat. It’s afternoon? Time to eat. It’s dusk? Time to eat. It’s midnight? Time to eat.

Point is, it’s always time to eat.

Dogs have a thing for the moon, too, like wolves and coyotes and our other relatives. No calendars for us.

Moon looks like a claw, moon looks like half a pancake, moon looks like a tennis ball. Moon looks like a claw again? A chunk of time has passed.

But humans, nope, that’s not enough. It’s not a chunk, it’s a month. It’s not just dawn, it’s 6:32 a.m. on a Thursday, and boy oh boy, we’d better hurry up and go to school or the office, or change the baby, but who gives a woof about feeding the poor, starving, sad-eyed, grumbling-tummied dog?

After a spell, I got used to the comings and goings of Julia and her mom and dad. But it keeps changing. Julia leaves early for school and is gone most of the day. She returns home excited and energized, good scents mostly. But every now and then she comes back smelling a little like me after a visit to the dog trainer—battle weary and ready to crawl under the covers.

Sara, who was pretty sick for a while, is feeling fine again, thank goodness, but she went back to work and she's away all day, too. And George, who has a job at Ivan's place, works five, sometimes six days a week.

That means it's just me and the guinea pigs a lot of the time. I have a doggie door and an outside run, but it's not the same as touring the neighborhood with your person. Peeing without a potential audience is like talking to yourself.

Sometimes I'm the teensiest bit jealous of Ivan and Ruby. They always have someone around.

Which is crazy, I know. I'm free and they're not. But there it is.

Told you I'm not a saint.

the shelter

I know our route to Ivan and Ruby by heart, and I can't help tugging a bit, even though I'm not supposed to. It's been a couple days since I've seen my pals, and I need my friend fix like I need air and water and belly rubs.

We don't live far. Down to the end of the street, around a corner (good news source there), then a few more blocks.



When I walk Julia—well, okay, I suppose it looks like she’s walking me, but I beg to differ—there’s a place we pass that always makes me jumpy and bummed.

It’s the animal shelter. And I know it’s a good place. A space for pets who don’t have a safe home of their own. When I was abandoned on the

highway, just a few weeks old, a nice cage with a soft towel in it and a bowl of fresh water . . . well, I woulda given just about anything for that.

Still, when I walk by and hear all those desperate barks and meows and squeaks, it gets to me.

Sometimes having great hearing is a pain.

Thing is, I realize I have a home and the gang in there doesn't, and I try not to think about stuff like that, you know?

I mean, it's not like I can do anything about their tough breaks, right? And in fairness, maybe those animals aren't like me. I've always been a resilient, hardworking sort. Maybe some of those guys even made their own bad luck.

Don't get me wrong. I try to be a nice guy. I do what I can to make the world a better place, sure. Chat with the guinea pigs. Lick the strawberry jelly off Julia's hand. Do my wag-and-dance when the 'rents come home to make 'em feel good. You scratch my back, I scratch yours.

But it's like I said before. You gotta look out for numero uno.

Guess that's why the shelter harshes my mellow. It's just . . . you know. I'd rather not have to hear those guys every time I walk by. Makes me sad.

Reminds me of the bad old days.

droolius

I knew this guy, back when I hung out at the mall with Ivan and Ruby. Nice dog named Droolius. Basic mutt, maybe some Lab and golden in there somewhere. He'd done some hard time at a couple shelters. One of those dogs you knew had seen more than his share of the bad stuff the world can throw your way. One ear bitten off. Scars. A limp.

Droolius lived in his backyard. Winter, spring, summer, fall. Chained up mostly. Flies on his food. Empty water bowl way too often.

Still, he always had a nice word to say when I'd pass him on my daily rounds, checking out the neighborhood trash cans.

Once I saw his owner—again, that word!—step onto the back porch. Droolius was barking, but he had a good reason. A stranger had just passed by. Barking is what we're supposed to do in that circumstance, right?

Maybe he's the UPS guy, maybe he's a serial killer. I mean, c'mon, we're not the FBI.

So anyways. Owner came out, big guy, mean-looking, gave Droolius a hard kick with his boot, yelled, "Shut up, you fool," disappeared.

Droolius looked at me, kinda embarrassed. We kept talking. A few minutes later, the owner came out again. Put some towels on a line.

Droolius headed over, tail between his legs, cowering, saying, *I'm sorry I love you I am yours yours yours* with his whole dog being.

Guy completely ignored him, headed back inside.

"He's having a tough time," said Droolius when the guy was gone.

“He’s a jerk,” I said, because subtlety is not my strong point.

“No. He loves me. He does.”

“He has a funny way of showing it.”

“Humans,” said Droolius, licking a sore on his leg. “You know how they can be.”

“Do I ever.”

“But we gotta stay true. Love ’em. Forgive ’em.”

I thought about that. Thought about it a lot.

“Why, though?” I finally asked. “Why do we have to forgive them?”

Droolius looked shocked, then confused. As if I’d just asked why cheese tastes good. It just *does*.

“That’s the way it is,” he said. “That’s what we do, Bob.”

I started to reply, but I managed to hold my tongue, which is not easy for me. It’s a very long tongue with a mind of its own.

There was no point in making Droolius feel worse than he already did.

Later that morning, I found half a turkey sandwich. Gave the whole thing to him.

Well, okay, I had a taste first. But still.

forgiveness

Seems like forgiving humans is one of those doggie things we're all supposed to do. Like having zoomies or doing bed boogies.

It's written into our canine souls.

Well, somehow I didn't get the memo, the one that apparently went out to every other dog on the planet, about forgiveness.

Why should I forgive the humans who tossed me and my siblings out into the night? When you forgive, you lose your anger, and when you lose your anger, you get weak.

And when you're weak, you can get hurt all over again.

the art of human watching

By the time we reach the park, the sky is definitely in a bad mood. Gray clouds galloping like panicked horses. The nervous scent of rain on the way, the kind that makes you antsy in your own skin.

When we get near the employee entrance, I hop into Julia's backpack, like always. We enter through the special gate, where George shows his ID, checks in, and says hi to the staff.

Pet dogs aren't allowed at the park, natch. Foxes, wolves, jackals? My dog cousins? They are. But in my opinion, even though they're technically part of my extended family, they're nothing like dogs.

Only dogs have perfected the art of human watching.

The smartest thing we ever did was figure out how important the human gaze is. So often when we follow our owners' eyes, we're rewarded with something amazing.

A smelly sock!

A glazed doughnut!

A glazed doughnut that's fallen on a smelly sock!

We follow every blink, every sidelong glance.

We see it, whatever it is, before humans do.

We understand before they do.

And if there's a glazed doughnut involved, we eat it before they do.

puppy eyes

It's midmorning, still pretty early. There aren't many visitors around yet. "We've got a meeting in twenty," George tells a couple workers, Hank and Sonia, who groan. "Just a quick one. Going over contingency plans one last time, in case there's any flooding."

During the last hurricane, a small part of the park flooded, mostly near Reptileville. George helped move cages. He came home smelling like cottonmouths and copperheads. It was all I could do not to barf.

"Weather service just issued a tornado watch," Hank says.

"I thought we were having a hurricane," Julia says.

"We are. Gus. But sometimes tornadoes are spawned during hurricanes," George explains.

Julia frowns. "But a watch means 'maybe,' not 'for sure,' right?"

"Yeah, but I want you to head home," George says, "just in case."

"Please, Dad? Just ten minutes?" Julia says. She's using the special voice she reserves for moments when she really, really wants something from her parents.

I guess kids manipulate their moms and dads the same way dogs manipulate humans.

"I don't know—" George begins.

"I promised Bob."

I figure that's my cue to pop my head out and look adorable. So I do.

“Hey, Bob,” says Hank. Sonia reaches over and scratches my ears.

I’m pretty popular around the park.

I give George my best puppy eyes, and he caves.

“Ten minutes, tops,” he says. “Meet me back here.”

Puppy eyes.

Works every time.

mr. oog

Here's how I figure puppy eyes got their start.

Cave humans were sitting around a fire, wearing mammoth fur and grunting about how there was nothing on TV because TV hadn't been invented yet, and some wily wolf thought, *Whoa, they've got leftover mammoth meat!*

And he probably whimpered and cowered and did a tummy display and looked pathetic enough that Mr. Oog finally tossed him a bone. And soon enough, a few zillion years later: voilà! Man's best friend.

After all that time, there's a thing, like a magnetic attraction, between dogs and humans. We've studied them for so long we can read every twitch and sigh.

S'pose it was easier than chasing down mammoths.

And I get it. I do.

The behind-the-ear scratch. The food in a fancy bowl. The bed by the fireplace.

Gotta admit that Julia's pretty fun to hang out with. And I'm grateful, really I am, that her family took me in.

Still, I don't *need* them.

You need someone, eventually they let you down and you end up feeling like a real doofus.

the park

As Julia walks, I sneak peeks out of her backpack, like I always do.

We pass the meerkat family, poking out from their den holes like the Whac-A-Mole game they used to have at Mack's mall. I see the flashy flamingos, with their one-legged balancing act. And the terrifyingly beautiful tigers. Even their cute cubs give me the willies.

Families, I've noticed, take a lot of different shapes. Jim and Joe, the penguins, adopted an abandoned egg, and they are the sweetest doting parents you ever saw. I see it with humans at the park, too. Families of all shapes and sizes and colors and genders and yep, they all seem to do just fine.

We round a corner past Sea Otter Alley. Oliver and Olivia are floating calmly on their backs, holding each other's paws. It's pretty adorable, I have to admit. But me, I don't need the trouble that comes with family.

Babies puking. Toddlers whining. Spouses nagging.

Talk about a design flaw.



change

The park's pretty big. Lots of twisty paths and fascinating smells. All the parts have names. There's the African Aviary. The Outback. Penguin Cove. Lemur Land.

It's like puzzle pieces of the world—a little Africa here, a little Asia there.

Dogs, you can find us pretty much everywhere. Our territory is Earth. As long as we're hooked up with humans, that is.

Along the shady paths, volunteer guides will answer your questions. They'll tell you about how animals used to roam one part of the world or another until things changed.

Things change.

That's one thing I've figured out. Don't ever assume a little patch of the planet belongs to you.

Things change. Boxes go flying.

my inner wolf

On our way, we always stop by the wolf habitat. Julia loves wolves. Probably because they remind her of me.

You have to look hard, maybe squint a little, but if you try, you can catch a hint of my inner wolf.

It's in the eyes, mostly. Also in my distinguished profile.

I dream I'm a wolf sometimes, and when I wake up, I'm panting and my fur's on alert and I'm feeling *Yeah, the world could hurt me, but I could hurt the world right back even harder*. Like there's a dangerous, hard part of me chained inside, struggling to go free and just, I dunno, get even.

Then I go see what's for breakfast.

kimu

There's a gray wolf at the park who makes me a little jittery.

Jittery, as in I sometimes worry he might like to eat me.

His name is Kimu, and we struck up a conversation when a mutual acquaintance of ours, a mockingbird called Mitch, introduced us one day.

Like Nutwit, Mitch likes to taunt me because I'm domesticated. Gives me a lot of grief about how free he is, soaring stringless over the whole town.

"I'm not the only one who's pampered," I said one day. "I mean, look at Kimu. He's not exactly running wild."

As soon as the words were out of my mouth, I regretted them. And when I looked at Kimu's *I could kill you with one quick bite* expression, I really regretted them.

"In any case," I said, moving the subject along, "I've lived wild. It ain't a picnic for a dog."

"What was it like?" Kimu asked. He moved closer to the edge of his domain. He had a strange odor, intense and scary and a little bit intoxicating.

"Well, I was just a pup," I said. "Abandoned by the side of the highway."

Kimu was listening intently. "Must have been tough."

"All I could think of was food, water." I didn't like the catch in my voice. "Owl got me."



“Those guys are fierce,” Kimu said. “Can’t hear them coming.”

“I know, right?” I relaxed a little.

“I hate owls,” said Mitch. “Hate them with a passion. They eat birds, you know.”

“So do wolves,” said Kimu, giving Mitch a meaningful look.

“So you were . . . wild once?” I asked Kimu.

“Never. Born and raised in captivity. Suzu, over there? She was. She’s told us stories that would curl your fur.”

“Honestly, it’s nice to have a roof over my head. It’s tough out there, man. Really tough.”

“I suppose,” said Kimu.

I looked at him and, for the first time, wondered if I really did have any wolf in me. He was a majestic animal, with teeth that could shred a tree trunk.

I am also majestic. But more portable. With teeth that could mangle a pencil with enough time and effort.

“Hey, Bob,” Mitch said, “do dogs howl the way wolves do?”

“Of course we do.”

“So let’s hear something. A duet maybe.” He fluttered his wings, revealing startling patches of white. “Do you know ‘Talk to the Animals’? They play that on the carousel.”

“Go away, Mitch,” said Kimu, with just the right amount of menace in his voice.

“C’mon. Just a little howling. Pretend there’s a moon. Pretend you’re free. Pretend—”

Kimu growled, and so did I. His was pretty impressive. Guttural, deep. It spoke of death and dismemberment and all kinds of unpleasant bird nightmares.

I growled too. It spoke of . . . me being mildly peeved.

Still, Mitch got the message. He disappeared, a blur of wings.

“Actually, I’ve never howled at the moon,” I admitted.

“Me, neither,” said Kimu. “I’d feel kind of silly, doing it here.”

enrichment

We're almost to my favorite spot in the park.

The great thing for me is that one corner of Gorilla World juts up against Elephant Odyssey, the area where Ruby lives. A low stone wall separates the two spaces, and there's a moat on the elephant side. The sections connect like two slices of pie, and my secret spot is right at the center, where I can hang out with my crew. Ivan and Ruby both have access to indoor habitats, which is great when the weather isn't cooperating.

The indoor space for gorillas ain't bad. I call it the "gorilla villa." It has tons of ropes and hammocks and branches to climb. Humans watch through a thick wall of glass while the young gorillas run around like kids at recess.

But whenever Julia and I visit, we can almost always find Ivan and Ruby outside.

We trudge up a little rise, though it isn't much of a hill. We live in a pretty flat part of the world. From there I can see just about everything: the park, the parking lot, the creek. Far beyond that, every now and then, I can even catch a glimpse of the ocean.

My secret place is a little hard to get to, right near the keepers' shed, nicely hidden by trees and bushes. Under a big magnolia tree there's a bench shaped like a gorilla holding out his arms. Julia likes to sit there and draw.

Sometimes she does her homework, which smells like frustration with a hint of eraser.

Whenever I visit, Julia props me up on the stone wall that separates Ruby's world from Ivan's. Visitors can't see me, and the keepers pretend not to see me.

If they caught any other dog there, he'd be out in a heartbeat. But Ivan and Ruby and I have a history. I make them happy.

I'm what you might call "enrichment."

At the park, they try to keep the animals engaged with surprises and challenges and changes to their environment. That's what enrichment is all about. The gorillas get watermelons to demolish and boxes to hide in and markers for drawing. The elephants get sprinklers and flavored water and elephant-sized rubber balls.

Not exactly like a day in the real jungle, of course. But the keepers try as hard as they can to make life interesting.

For Ivan and Ruby, I'm the ultimate enrichment.

I'm their best pal.

walls and bad guys

Julia takes me out of her backpack and I settle onto the wide stone wall. It's my fave place on the planet 'cause it means I can see Ivan and Ruby. But I also kinda hate it.

Walls will do that to you.



Ivan, being Ivan, is a mellow kinda guy. Takes the good with the bad, only gets angry when he really needs to. When I complain about the walls at the park, he says, “Walls keep the animals in. But they also keep the bad guys out.”

Of course, gorillas don’t have a whole lot of bad guys to deal with. Elephants either. So humans step in to fill the void.

Dogs? Sometimes it feels like we have enemies galore.

Everyone wants a piece of us. Humans treat us badly. Cars really have it in for us. We even get eaten by coyotes, which is kinda like having your cousin invite you over for dinner, then inform you you’re the main course.

Although I’d probably just be the appetizer.

Anyways. After those twenty-seven years stuck in a mall, Ivan is one of those “glass half full” kinda guys when it comes to the walls surrounding him. Glad to be with others of his own kind. Cared for by smart and loving humans.

I’m more of a “water bowl of power half empty” kinda guy.

Every time I leave Ivan and Ruby, I am painfully aware that I *can* leave. Ivan’s address is “Gorilla World.” Ruby’s is “Elephant Odyssey.”



And me? I guess my address is the same as Julia and George and Sara's.
1249 Hinman Avenue.

I mean, of course it is. I've been living there a whole year now.

It is.

And yet, sometimes I still wake up at night and think, *Gotta find shelter,
gotta find safety, gotta find somewhere to belong.*

Guess I don't want to get too comfortable.

gift

Once I'm in my spot, I don't have to do a thing, because Ivan and Ruby always know when I'm there.

Gorillas and elephants have great schnozzes, too.

Also, I pride myself on staying extra fragrant.

It's a gift.

ivan

Ivan gets to me first.

“Bob!” He knuckle walks up the hill—knuckle runs, actually—and he looks as glad to see me as I am to see him.

It seems like I’ve known Ivan forever. And yet every single time I see him I feel kinda awed. He’s so powerful. So huge. Like this magnificent silver mountain that just happens to be my best buddy.

“Hi, Ivan!” Julia calls, waving. He cocks his head and makes a soft belch, which is gorilla for *I’m happy*.

Maya calls out to Julia from the door to the gorillas’ indoor space. Maya’s a zoologist, which is a hoity-toity way of saying she has a thing for animals.

It was Maya, and a lot of other good folks, who helped get Ivan and the rest of the mall animals moved to better places.

Julia unhooks my string and gives me a stern look. “No funny business, you,” she says, and then she kisses me on the head. “And stay out of sight.”

Ivan sidles up as close to the stone wall as he can get. “I was worried you wouldn’t come today,” he says. “Weather and all.”

“Another hurricane,” I say. “It’s freaking everybody out.” Above me, magnolia branches sway. Leaves rustle and shiver. Even the trees seem uneasy.

“What’s new?” Ivan asks. He lies back on the grass and wriggles contentedly. Scratching an itch, no doubt.

“Not much. Had a weird dream last night.” I pause. “You were in it, and me and Ruby, and Stella, too.”

Ivan gazes at the darkening sky. “Stella,” he says. “Now there was a great friend. Classiest elephant you’ll ever hope to meet.”

“The best,” I agree. “I miss the old gal.”

We fall silent. “All good with you?” I ask after a moment. No point in dwelling on sad stuff. Or bad dreams.

“Kinyani’s getting on my nerves a bit. ‘Ivan, do this. Ivan, do that.’ But she means well.”

Kinyani is Ivan’s lady friend. Girlfriend? I’ve never been sure what they call it in gorilla.

Kinyani doesn’t really approve of me. She thinks I’m a bad influence on Ivan.

I like to think she’s right.

Ivan is four hundred pounds of pure power. But Kinyani is four hundred times scarier. Trust me. I’ve seen her in a bad mood. I’ve also seen her teeth. Make mine look like toothpicks.

Ivan and Kinyani don’t have kids, but there are a bunch of baby and juvenile gorillas hanging around. They call him “Uncle Ivan,” and he puts up with their antics.

Ivan’s always been a good sport.

If I had a gorilla toddler hanging off me, I’d be tempted to use my toothpick teeth.

marriage

Ivan and Kinyani are a lot like George and Sara, as far as I can tell.

They grumble. They cuddle.

They help each other. They tease each other.

Sometimes it looks pretty nice. Still and all, when I smell love, I almost always smell worry. Seems like they're tangled together so tightly they'll never unravel.

There's a reason I avoid all that mushy stuff.

One big difference I have noticed between the two couples: Ivan and Kinyani enjoy eating bugs off each other.

George and Sara, not so much.

tiny but tough

Ivan always seems like nothing scares him. (Not even Kinyani, who scares the heck outa me.)

On the outside, I suppose that's how I look, too. Tiny but tough.

But inside? Well. Sometimes, no matter how hard I try, I can't find that guy to save my life.

It's like he's cowering in some corner of my heart.

I hate it when that happens. I hate that I'm not the guy my friends think I am. The guy the world expects.

I keep waiting for things to go bad on me. Worrying that my nice, tidy little dog life will blow up in my face.

I think George is a worrier, too. He'll get up in the middle of the night and head to the kitchen sometimes, his old slippers scuffing on the wooden floor. I always hear him. Always join him.

When he opens the fridge, the light spills out like maple syrup on a hot pancake. Wonderful scents drift my way. Leftover meat loaf. Stinky cheese. Expired yogurt that someone might as well eat, and it seems like the dog is the safest bet.

The smells rain around me, and yeah, my tongue starts hanging out, and I nudge George's pj'ed leg. "You can't sleep either, huh?" he'll say. Or maybe: "I can't tell if you have insomnia or just a very acute sense of smell."

Both, actually.

I wait. He usually makes himself a PB&J with banana, which is good with me, because the crusts are where you really get that fun chew factor going.

Now and then, after we eat, we sit on the back porch and George scratches my ears. Especially my right ear. It's my favorite.

I understand his worry, I think. George works so hard. His wife was really sick for a long time. And he loves his daughter so, so much.

Sometimes when Julia climbs on the school bus, I'll watch George watching her. All that caring and concern is painful to smell. Especially the briny scent of the stray tear he'll flick aside with the back of his hand like sea spray.

More than once, George and I have dozed off together.

That's the best kind of snooze, if you ask me. Good, warm, safe-in-someone's-arms sleep.

not talking

Often when I'm with Ivan, we don't even bother talking.

We just look out at his domain, at the green grass and the crazy babies and the swaggering juveniles and the hardworking females, and we think of nothing and everything.

When you've been through the worst with someone, you appreciate the best.

That's why sometimes, when he says, "Hey, Bob," it's enough for me to say, "Hey, Ivan," and then we just listen to the palm trees rustle and watch the saw grass sway.

brave

Once, when we were still at the mall, I told Ivan how brave I thought he was. The way he put up with everything that had happened to him and never stopped being a good guy.

Ivan just looked at me. Cocked that big ol' head of his. Nodded a bit.

"That's not brave, Bob," he finally said. "That's just knowing what I can't change."

"I call it brave," I said. "I call it crazy brave."

Ivan held a browning banana up to the light. Like it was the most beautiful thing he'd ever seen in his long gorilla life.

I wondered whether he was going to eat it or draw it. You never knew with Ivan.

"Seems to me there are lots of ways to be brave, Bob," he said.

A tiny mouse, name of Eek, skittered across his cage floor. "Hey, Eek," said Ivan.

"Just checking for crumbs," she said nervously, because she always sounded nervous.

"Dibs on all leftovers," I reminded her.

She looked so terrified that I relented. "Over there, behind the tire. Old carrot top."

"Respect, Bob," she said, scampering off.

“Take a small creature like Eek,” said Ivan. He scratched his chin with the end of the banana. He did that when he was in a philosophical mood. “Maybe brave for a mouse is different from brave for me or brave for you.”

He looked at me fondly. “You’re the bravest dog I know, pal.”

“I ain’t brave.” I chewed on my tail, avoiding his gaze.

“You are Bob, untamed and undaunted,” said Ivan, and he chomped off a hunk of banana. He offered the rest to me, but I shook my head. I wasn’t feeling hungry.

Also, it was mostly just peel.

“That’s just my shtick. My routine.” I hesitated. “I mean, sure, I’m tough, compared to, say, Eek. But that’s setting the bar pretty low.”

“You’re too hard on yourself sometimes, Bob.”

I met his eyes. He has these dark brown, deep-set eyes, really kind ones. Eyes that make you wanna admit things. Confess to your failures.

“Once when I was little. Just a pup. I did something . . .”

Ivan waited patiently. Ivan is the king of patience.

I felt myself dashing into a dead-end tunnel I couldn’t escape. I didn’t want to go there. Not even with Ivan.

“Never mind.” I yawned. I do that when I’m anxious. “I’m rambling.”

“Bob?” Ivan said. “You okay?”

“You know me, Ivan. I’m always okay. Always.”

I slipped away before he could ask me anything more.

ruby

“Uncle Bob!”

Ruby races over—*galomph, galomph*—across the broad field that’s part of the elephant domain. She’s so cute when she runs, like she’s determined not to trip on her trunk.

Ruby adores me. I make her laugh, I read the room, I lighten the mood.

I gotta admit, I *am* kind of adorable.

When I’m with Ivan, I think: *Pal, we’ve been through a lot, you and me. We are survivors.*

When I’m with little Ruby, I think: *Girl, look at you! Hard-luck past, and here you are, so much happier. So loved.*

Ruby, like Ivan, was plucked from Africa as a baby. She ended up in a circus that went bankrupt, then got shipped off to Mack’s mall.

Ruby was taken in by dear old Stella. When Stella passed away, Ivan stepped in to play . . . well, elephant dad, I guess.

I did my part, too. Not ’cause I felt like I had to.

It just made life easier. Elephant toddlers are a handful.

You think humans are bad? Try putting a two-hundred-pound baby elephant in time-out.

ruby's family

Little Ruby seems much more content at the park, surrounded by her new herd. Old and young and in between, they spoil that adorable pachyderm like you wouldn't believe.

She deserves every minute of it. Kid had a rough start.

Seems elephants hang out in packs of females. Now that she's at the park, Ruby has adoptive sisters and aunts and grandmothers galore. (In the wild, the elephant guys head off, once they're old enough, and do their own thing.) Sometimes I lose track of who's who among the elephants, because they're always taking mud baths, scrambling their smells.

By the way, what kind of animal actually *likes* baths?

Mud, sure.

ivan's art

“How’s it going, girl?” I call to Ruby as she stops near the moat edging the wall.

“I had cantaloupe for breakfast, Uncle Bob! And it was yummy! And then I took a mud bath!” She pauses to take a breath. “Do you want to hear a new dog riddle, Uncle Bob?”

“Of course I do,” I say, and I catch Ivan’s amused glance.

“What kind of dog is always on time?” asks Ruby.



“Hmm. You got me, Ruby. I’m totally baffled. Befuddled. Bewildered. What kind of dog?”

“A watchdog!” Ruby exclaims. “*Watchdog!* Get it, Uncle Bob?”

“Not bad, Ruby. Not bad at all,” I say.

“Ivan says it’s going to rain buckets,” says Ruby. She dips her trunk in the moat and blows bubbles.

“I think Ivan is onto something there.”

“Did he show you his new picture?” Ruby asks. She grabs a tuft of grass and tosses it in the air. “I wish I could see it, but I can’t ’cause of that silly wall. But he told me all about it.”

My pal Ivan is quite the artist, just like Julia.

Ivan sits up and nods toward a spot on the wall.

“Another mud mural?” I ask.

As any good dog knows, dirt plus water equals mud, and mud means mess, and mess means let’s roll in this stuff and maybe dig a hole or two or ten.

But for Ivan, mud plus a flat surface equals a waiting canvas.

I crane my neck, edging a bit farther down the top of the wall. Don’t want to draw attention to myself.

“Hey, nice,” I say.

I mean, I’m not an art guy. To me, art is a glop of spray cheese on a cheese dog with extra grated cheese on top.

Still, I’ve always admired Ivan’s work.

“It’s—” Ivan begins.

“No,” I say. “Don’t tell me. Lemme guess.”

“You always guess wrong,” Ivan says.

“Not always.”

“You thought my palm tree was a dandelion.”

“Art is in the eye of the beholder,” I say.

“You thought my blackberries were giant ants.”

Kinyani ambles up to join in the conversation. “And need I remind you that you thought his portrait of me was a chimpanzee with gas?”

“The resemblance was striking,” I say.

Kinyani glares at me.

She glares at me a lot.

on the subject of chimps

Probably I shouldn't have mentioned the chimp angle.

Gorillas aren't as open-minded as dogs. A lot of them have a thing about chimps. Think they're clowns. But when I look at apes and gorillas, seems to me they have a lot more in common than they admit to.

Dogs ain't perfect. But I'll tell you one thing where we rule: tolerance.

For us, a dog is a dog is a dog. I see a Great Dane, I say howdy. I run into a puggle, it's *Glad to meet ya, how's it goin', smelled any good pee lately?*

Go to a dog park and you'll see. We are equal opportunity playful. You sniff my rear, I sniff yours.

You don't see that with humans, obviously. Constantly seeing differences where none exist. All those things like skin color? Dogs could care less. You think I won't hang with a dalmatian 'cause he's spotted? Or a shar-pei 'cause she's wrinkled?

I'm not saying I love every dog I meet. (Snickers comes to mind.)

But I'll always give a dog the benefit of the doubt. Life is short. Play is good. And there are plenty of tennis balls to go around.

a very handsome dog

“Hi, Aunt Kinyani!” Ruby calls.

“Once again, Ruby,” says Kinyani, “I am not your aunt. I am a primate. And you, my dear, are not. More’s the pity.”

“But if Ivan is my uncle, then you *have* to be my aunt,” Ruby declares.

“Ahem,” says Ivan, pointing to the wall. “My painting, Bob?”

I consider. “It looks like . . . like a dog?”

Ruby flaps her ears. I can tell she is trying very hard to stay quiet.

“A very handsome dog,” I add. “Is it—”

“It is!” Ruby exclaims. “It’s you, Uncle Bob! Uncle Ivan told me!”

“But who’s that?” I ask, pointing to another set of mud strokes.

“I thought you needed a companion,” says Ivan. “I know you must get lonely at home, by yourself all day.”

It’s true. But I’ve never mentioned that to Ivan. Guy’s like a mind reader.

“I think Snickers and Bob would make a cute couple,” says Ruby.

I blink in disbelief. “Bite your trunk!”

Ruby starts to reply, but her voice is drowned out by a sharp clap of thunder.

“Storm’s getting close,” says Kinyani. “Ivan, dear, come on. You know how you hate the damp.”

It's true. He carries around old burlap bags so he won't have to sit on wet grass.

Ivan looks at me sheepishly. "She knows me so well."

Kudzoo, one of the baby gorillas, bounds over and leaps onto Ivan's back. Ivan loves all the youngsters, but Kudzoo is his favorite. I think she reminds him a little of his twin sister, Tag, who died when she was still a baby.



"Ride!" Kudzoo commands.

Julia appears, her backpack at the ready. “Bob,” she calls, “we need to get going.”

“Ride, *now!*” Kudzoo repeats, yanking on one of Ivan’s ears.

“Looks like it’s time to go,” says Ivan. “Good to see you, buddy. Stay dry, okay?”

“Will do, big guy.” I turn to Kinyani. “Enchanted, as always, my dear.”

A trumpeting noise cuts through the air. “Uh-oh,” says Ruby. “That’s Aunt Akello.”

Akello, the oldest of the elephant aunts, lumbers over. “Come on, Ruby. Weather’s getting bad.”

“Just one more minute?” Ruby pleads.

“Now.”

“But I need to tell Uncle Bob one more riddle.”

“Now,” Akello repeats.

“Nobody ever listens to the littlest elephant,” Ruby complains.

“You can tell me the riddle next time, kiddo,” I say, winking at Akello.

Ruby brightens. “Okay. Gotta go or I’ll be in big trouble! Love you, Uncle Bob! See you later, Uncle Ivan and Aunt Kinyani!”

“I’m not your—” Kinyani begins, but Ruby is already galloping back to her herd.

the beginning

In the distance, thunder growls, long and low and not giving up. Reminds me of my stomach, pre-breakfast.

I test the air. Weird. Something isn't right.

"Julia!" It's George, rushing over. "Hurry up! You need to get inside."

George has an odd scent, like he's on guard. I've only smelled it a few times on him.

I look up. The clouds have turned strange shades of green and yellow and gray, clustered together like rows of fat marshmallows. It's so ugly it's beautiful. I can't stop looking.

The air goes still, like a cat before it leaps on its prey.

Kinyani and Ivan and Kudzoo are racing toward the gorilla villa.

A fat raindrop hits my nose. It tastes wrong. How can rain taste dangerous?

People are yelling, running. Opening umbrellas. Covering their heads with maps of the park.

More drops.

At the far end of the field, I can just make out Akello herding Ruby along.

Another drop. A dry one. Like a pebble.

"Hail," George says. "Julia. Now." He grabs her hand.

Rumbling. The sky boils and swirls.

“Bob!” Julia calls. “Come on!”

I move to leap off my perch. To run to Julia.

I’ve done it a thousand times. But this time, I lose my footing.

I never slip. I am as nimble as Nutwit.

But the rain, the hail.

I let out a yelp as I land on Ivan’s side of the wall, splat in the mud.

“Bob!” Julia screams.

“He’ll be okay,” George says.

I can smell Julia’s fear, and George’s doubt, as he drags her away.

torn apart

Noise.

It's all noise.

Noise that hurts. Noise like a massive truck bearing down on us, the power of its engine, the inescapable wheels, the relentless roar.

Nothing to see, nothing even to smell.

Just the terrible sound of the world disintegrating.

no way

I'm flying.

airborne

Not far, just into the nearby giraffe domain.

Not high, just enough to buzz the tops of trees.

Not long, just long enough to stop breathing.

But I *fly*.

I'm not alone. Half the world seems airborne. Trees, boards, bicycles, chunks of roofs, umbrellas, chairs, bits and pieces of life: it all levitates past like some horrible magic trick.

Something hits my head—a toy truck, maybe?—and I yelp in pain.

And I'm terrified, so scared I pee myself, and I'll be the first to admit it—you try it and see how dry your underwear stays—but still.

I fly.

Not like in the box, the box with my brothers and sisters. Not like with the owl.

This is different.

This is me, Bob the dog, spending a moment as Bob the bird.

landing



It's over.

I land—*umph*—hard, on my rear, and slide to a stop directly underneath Stretch, the oldest giraffe in the place.

The roar—and by now I've realized we're talking a real, live tornado—vanishes as quickly as it came, leaving a vacuum.

A silence that hurts even more than the noise.

bad dog

And this is why I'm a Bad Dog.

Not Bad Dog, like I chewed your favorite slippers. Bad Dog, like I'm not a good representative of my species. Of any species.

I don't think, *Ivan! Ruby! Julia! Are they all right? I've got to find them.*

That's what a hero dog would do, one of those guys on the *Man's Best Friend* show. Hero dogs dash into flames and dig into rubble. Hero dogs are fearless.

Nope. Not my style.

What do I do? Bob, untamed, undaunted?

I howl like a newborn puppy.

honest

I'm not hurt.

Banged up a little, sure. But nothing major.

And I don't howl for long.

But it's what I do.

Like I said, I ain't a saint. But at least I'm honest about my failings.

stretch

Slowly, with some difficulty, Stretch peers down between his two front legs. His body partially shelters me from the rain. A piece of canvas has draped itself around his neck like an ugly scarf.

I swallow my howls. We look at each other, too stunned to form actual words.

Finally Stretch clears his throat. “Hello,” he says in a strangely calm voice. “What kind of animal might you be, if you don’t mind my asking?”

“Dog.”

“Didn’t think you guys flew.”

“We don’t. As a rule.”

I pick myself up, move out from under Stretch, and take in my surroundings. The pelting rain has slowed some, and the wind has dulled.

“What was that?” Stretch asks, trying and failing to yank the canvas off his impressive neck.

“Tornado, I think.”

I’ve seen tornadoes on the Weather Channel. They looked like water swirling down a drain. If the water were black and full of trucks and trees.

They looked like death.

I gaze up at him. I have to crane my neck. “You okay?”

“Yep,” says Stretch. “But from what I can see, a lot of other folks aren’t.”

aardvarks

Across the way, I hear something.

A small squeak.

“Who lives over there?” I ask Stretch.

“The aardvark family,” he replies. “Lovely neighbors.”

Carefully, I venture across Stretch’s domain. The sky is dark as dusk.

I hear a flutter of wings overhead. It’s Mitch, the mockingbird. He’s missing some feathers.

“Bob,” he calls, settling on a fence post. “Was that you I saw up there?”

“Yep. How are things looking?”

“Not good. Lotta damage.”

“Well, take care of yourself,” I say.

“Likewise.” He pauses to straighten a wayward feather. “Little hint, by the way. Next time you fly, try flapping your paws.”

I make my way over a broken wooden barrier, tiptoe over some scattered glass and twisted metal, cross the paved path, and arrive at the aardvarks.

More sounds. They’re coming from what looks like a demolished keepers’ shed. I hesitate, not sure what to do. It’s a big mess, and I’m a small guy.

Also, my head hurts. I feel dazed. Fuzzy. My ears are ringing.

I yank off some small stray boards with my mouth.

For the record, small stray boards have small stray nails in them.

Underneath the boards are three shivering aardvarks, two babies and a mom. They're strange looking, I gotta say, with their long piggy snouts and bunny ears.

"You good?" I ask.

"W-w-w-what was that?" the mother manages to ask.

"Some seriously bad weather."

"Is it over?"

I consult the wind. "Doubt it."

"You think everybody's okay?" she asks.

"Dunno. Sure hope so."

And then it hits me.

Ivan. Ruby. Julia. George.

"Look, I gotta go," I say in a strangled voice. "Any part of your indoor den survive?"

She nods. "Think so."

"Go there. Lie low."

"Where's Pedro?" the littlest aardvark asks.

I feel my head with a front paw. A nice bump is forming. "Who's Pedro?"

"Our keeper."

"He'll come," I promise.

“Are you sure?” the baby asks.

“I’m sure,” I say, but of course, I’m lying.

sounds

The eerie quiet doesn't last. Before long, the squeals and shrieks and brays and squawks of the animal kingdom crowd the air.

Terror. Confusion. Pain.

From far off comes the wailing of sirens. Car alarms blare from the parking lot. Now and then, people shout.

Cries for help translate into any language, human or animal, fish or fowl.

Never want to hear those again.

Never, ever.

smells

And the smells! Like I said, feelings have a scent.

I figured I'd smelled pretty much everything there was to inhale in this big ol' world.

But the smell of sheer terror.

Of helplessness.

Of blood.

Of broken bones.

Of torn wings.

Well.

Turns out there are a whole lot of smells I've never encountered. Didn't know how lucky I've been.

surveying the damage

I pick my way past the devastation. The tornado has left a random path of misery.

The African Aviary is gone, simply gone.

The Kids' Farm nearby? Untouched. Although there are some very flustered chickens clucking like all get-out from the safety of their henhouse.

I see few people. Hopefully, a lot of potential visitors were scared off by the threatening weather.

It looks like some of the animals listened to their early warning systems—those little voices inside telling them something bad was coming their way. Quite a few seem to have taken cover before the brunt of the storm.

Wish I'd paid more attention to my own internal weatherman.

I pass the penguin viewing window, the one that allows visitors to watch their graceful swimming. Several penguins are underwater, swooping and swiveling.

"Joe! Jim!" I call, and they both swim over.

"Bert okay?" I ask.

Baby Bert pops his little head out of the water. "Hey, Bob! Did you know we're having a storm?"

"Yeah, I noticed."

"All good here, Bob," Joe says. "You?"

“Yep. Took a little flight, though.”

“Daddy,” says Bert, “can I fly?”

“In the air? Nope,” says Joe. “You fly underwater. You’re a penguin.”

“Bob flew. And he’s a dog.”

“Bob is a very special dog,” says Joe, and he gives me a look, a grown-up, just-between-us look, that says, *We’re all right, but what about the others?*

baby sloth

I say goodbye to the penguins and continue on my way. So much has simply vanished. Walls. Fences. Barriers. Netting.

The orderly world of the park, with its careful lines defining territory, isn't so defined anymore. Many of the habitats are still entirely intact. But not all.

What will this place be without fences and walls? You didn't need to watch the nature channel to know that certain animals like to eat certain other animals.





I pass two squirrel monkeys swinging happily from the children's carousel. A pelican watches from her perch on a popcorn stand.

I see a camel and a zebra together, looking stunned to be standing side by side.

I notice a red lemur, Merlin, on a picnic table. Lemur eyes are always big, if you ask me. But Merlin's eyes look like they're about to pop right out of his head.

I make my way through splintered wood and glass shards and approach the gift shop. It's roofless. Stuffed toy animals are scattered here and there like they tried to make a break for it. An *I LOVE KOALAS* T-shirt dangles from a tree branch.

Around a corner I see a baby sloth—Sylvia, I think her name is. She's resting on a muddy plush giraffe.

"Hey, there," I say.

She makes a tiny noise. A sloth sob, I guess it is.

"Let's find your mom and dad." I'm not one for hugging and licking and such, but I give her a little nudge with my nose.

Sylvia somehow manages to grab the giraffe, then looks up at me like she expects to hitch a ride.

How the heck do you pick up a baby sloth? It's not exactly part of my job description. And sloths are so . . . you know, *slothy*.

Carefully, I pick her up by her scruff, the way you do with a puppy. She puts that silly toy in her mouth, and off we go.



Takes a few minutes, but I find her mom, Selma. I deposit Sylvia on a patch of wet grass.

“How can I thank you?” Selma cries.

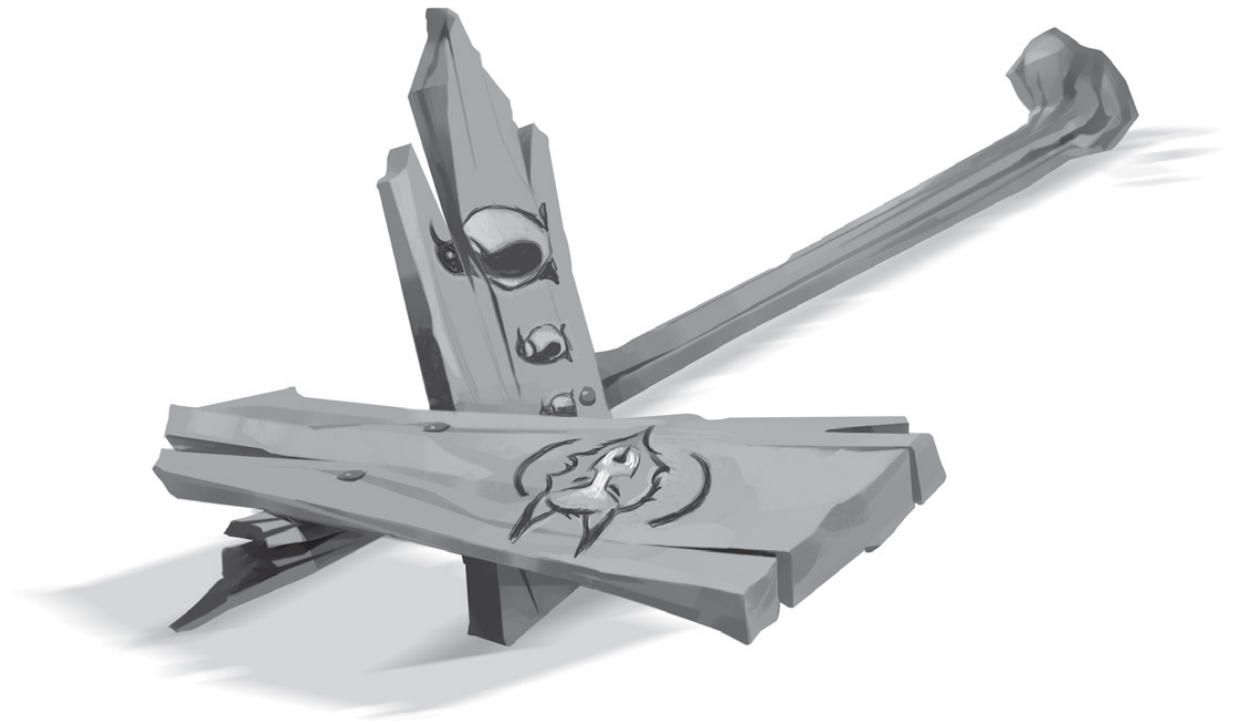
“No biggie,” I say, and I head on, with fear in my belly and the odd taste of sloth fur in my mouth.

make no sudden moves

I've ridden around the grounds of the park in Julia's backpack enough to know every inch of the place. I've even chatted with many of the residents. But now everything is topsy-turvy. I keep finding myself in places I don't want to be.

Like the wolf exhibit.

Near the entrance, a sign lies crushed on the ground. It has a picture of a gray wolf with an arrow pointing one way, and another arrow with an emperor penguin on it.



To my right I see a piece of hay, stuck deep in a tree trunk like a pencil in a cupcake.

To my left, water gushes from a pathside ditch. A broken pipe.

The boiling sky has settled into a solid blanket of gray, and the rain's quieted to a steady drizzle. Still, I smell more bad weather menacing in the distance.

Tossed into a bush is a large informational display with a photo of two gray wolves. I don't see any fence or barrier or intact wall. And it dawns on me that grumpy wolves and tiny dogs might not make the best of pals, especially under these trying circumstances.

Just as I start to leave, a wolf on the sign seems to move. To blink.

Oh.

He isn't part of the sign. He's *next to* the sign.

It's Kimu.

"Hey," I say.

No answer.

Something tells me I should hightail it outa there. Something else is saying, *Make no sudden moves.*

I hate it when my brain disagrees with itself.

I split the difference, crouching meekly. Doing the whole submissive dog thing.

Kimu locks his gaze on me. I try not to make direct eye contact. Lotta animals find that threatening. But his eyes are mesmerizing. Glowing amber and way too smart.

He moves again.

Two paws appear.

Big paws. Nothing like my feeble, shrimpy feet.

These paws are the size of hamburger buns.

Hamburger buns with lethal claws attached.

mutt versus wolf

I wait for him to launch into his pounce. Maybe if I time my escape just right?

Yeah, sure. In a battle of Chihuahua mutt versus wolf, even *I* wouldn't bet on the dog.

Do they break your neck before they eat you? That only seems fair.

My heart's doing this crazy tap dance in my chest, and I wonder if he can hear it. I sneak a peek at him. Strangely, he just keeps staring at me.

Quickly I avert my gaze. Those eyes. Those chilling, dangerous eyes.

"It's me. Bob," I say.

Kimu says nothing. He's panting hard. Maybe he's disoriented, even hurt?

I try to speak again. My voice seems to be hiding somewhere deep in my throat.

Another try. "Um . . . Kimu?"

He blinks.

"Are you all right?"

No response.

"Anyone else hurt?" I ask.

This time he seems to hear me. "I don't know." His voice is a low whisper.

"Can I help?" I ask, really hoping the answer is no.

“Suzu. I can’t find her.”

“All right, then,” I say. “I’ll, uh . . . I’ll take a look.”

I poke around a bit, careful not to get too close to Kimu. A sour smell pours off him like sweat off a human.

“I don’t . . . I don’t see her,” I say after a few minutes. “But I’m sure she’s fine. Just a little shook up, probably. Hiding somewhere.”

He doesn’t answer.

“I should go. I’m, um, looking for some friends,” I say. “Is there anything else I can do?”

He looks up at the ominous sky as if there’s an answer waiting there.

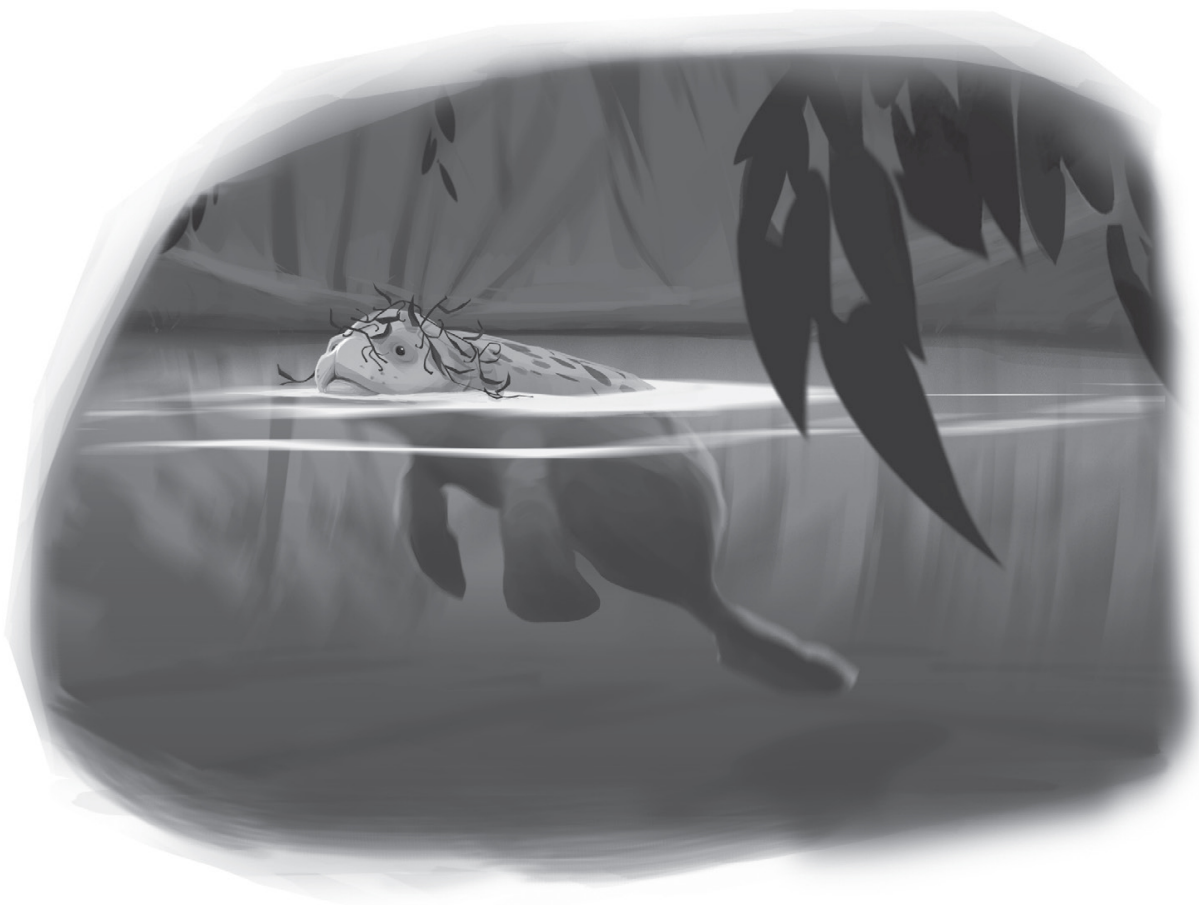
“I don’t know,” he says. “I don’t know. I don’t know.”

gorilla world

I move on. I have to find my friends. Have to. But where am I?

I leap over another mangled signpost with bent arrows. One way to Reptileville. One way to Lion Land.

I pass the Mangrove Swamp. A manatee pokes up her big head, draped with Spanish moss like a silly wig.



Two workers in yellow raincoats trot past me. One has a bloody bandage on his cheek.

I need to stop. Regroup. *Cool it, Bob*, I tell myself. I'm panicking, not taking in the right data. I try to blot out all the horrible smells, all the awful noise.

I concentrate, let my nose do the real work.

A whiff of something familiar. Gorilla? It has to be gorilla.

Full run now. I cut my back left paw on a shard of glass. Trip. Fall hard on my nose and cut it, too.

Dripping blood, I carry on. *Find them. Find them. Find them.*

A massive old oak lies on its side at the entrance to Gorilla World. Huge tangled roots grope into the air like frozen snakes.

And just beyond, where Ivan lives, is nothing but devastation.

help us!

The stone wall separating Gorilla World and Elephant Odyssey is gone. Pieces of both domains mingle: an elephant toy here, a gorilla nest there. Part of the indoor gorilla space has crumbled to the ground.

I scan the area where Ruby and her herd like to hang out. Nothing.

No gorillas, either.

Out of nowhere, the rain picks up, coming sideways, blinding me. The wind howls like a hurt dog.

This storm isn't over, not by a long shot.

I leap over a pile of cement blocks, catch my hurt foot on something sharp, yelp, keep going.

"Ivan!" I call. "Ruby!"

Nothing.

I get to a slight rise, leap onto another overturned tree, and try to make sense of the damage.

Red and blue lights cut through the rain. Police, fire engines. Good. We need all the help we can get.

I take in several lungfuls of the hideous air. It's too wet, too full of conflicting odors, a mishmash of scents I can't decipher, especially with my busted nose.

The wind gathers speed, pushing at me with incredible force. Feels like it'll tear my ears right off my sore noggin. I can barely stay upright.

Wind like that, storm wind, doesn't carry scent. It obliterates it.

“Help! Help us!”

It's a tiny, desperate voice.

Maybe even Ruby's voice.

kudzoo

I pick my way through the debris, trying to lock on the sound. It ain't easy.

“Please help us!”

Climbing over the remains of the wall, the one I was sitting on what seems like moments ago, I find myself at the bank of the moat.

“Ruby?” I call at the top of my lungs.

“Uncle Bob!” The sound of my name cuts through the gloom like a shaft of sun. Ruby runs to the opposite edge of the water. She's maybe eight feet away, but I can barely make her out in the torrential rain.

“You stay there,” I yell, trying to be heard over the wind. “I'll come to you.”



I follow the bank until I come to a spot where several chunks of wall have tumbled into the water. Three careful leaps and I'm across.

Ruby runs to greet me. She wraps her mud-coated trunk around my neck, and boy oh boy, am I happy to see that sweet little elephant.

"You hurt, Ruby?" I ask. "Is everyone all right?"

Ruby snuffles. "Yes, but—come quick." She dashes off before I can ask anything more.

Five of Ruby's aunts stand by the elephant side of the moat. Each one has her trunk plunged deep in the dark, muddy water. They look like a bunch of

kids trying to find a lost toy in a swimming pool.

It's almost funny. Until I see what they're reaching for.

A baby gorilla is in the moat.

The tiny gal keeps grabbing for a trunk to hold on to, then slipping free. Her terrified screeches fill the air.

It's Kudzo. Ivan's favorite.

an idea

“I’m going in,” says Masika, one of the younger aunts.

“Might make things worse,” Akello cautions. “Displace the mud, pull her down toward the bottom.”

“I could go in,” I suggest, the words popping out before I can swallow them.

“It’s more mud than water, Bob.” Akello shakes her head. “You’ll get as stuck as Kudzoo.”

I don’t exactly argue the point.

“I’ve got an idea,” comes a small voice.

All the aunties turn to Ruby, and she looks startled to have their complete attention.

“A couple of us get on the other side of the moat,” Ruby says. “Grab trunks. We’ll make like a, whaddy call it—”

“A sling!” I exclaim. “A hammock, like the gorillas have.”

“I don’t know, Ruby.” Akello sounds doubtful.

Kudzoo grabs for Masika’s trunk with both hands. “Wait,” Masika says. “Think I’ve got her this time.”

Masika lifts her trunk with deliberate slowness, carefully trying to support the baby gorilla, but once again, Kudzoo can’t hold on. She lets out a despairing cry.

Down she goes, lower this time, her nose and eyes just visible.

“Okay,” Akello says, with a nod at Ruby. “Let’s give Ruby’s idea a try. Masika, Laheli, Elodie, cross over to the far side. Zaina, Ruby, and I will take this side.

All three elephants move with surprising quickness to the spot where I crossed. They gallop back until they’re facing us.

It’s strange to see them on the other side of the moat. With the wall destroyed, they’re technically in Ivan and Kinyani’s domain.

“Move down a bit,” Akello instructs. “That way.” She motions with her head. “We want to scoop her out, not push her down.”

Three on one side, three on the other, the elephants reach out for each other’s trunks, creating a kind of cradle.

“Okay, now,” says Akello, “lower carefully!”

Down they go into the muddy water. Ruby nearly loses her footing, so I grab her tail with my teeth.

It doesn’t really help, and she yelps, “*Ouch!*” but my heart’s in the right place.

Kudzoo thrashes her tiny arms. “Stay calm,” I call. Easy for me to say.

She looks over at me, and I’ll never forget the fear in her dark eyes.

Then she vanishes below the surface.

team elephant

“Hurry!” Ruby cries.

The elephants bend lower, moving like a giant elephant shovel.

“Where *is* she?” Masika asks.

“Lower,” says Akello. “Lower, sisters!”

“There!” Ruby yells. “No . . . wait! There!”

“Up!” Akello commands, and the interlocked trunks rise from the muddy water to reveal a tiny, trembling baby gorilla, sitting in their makeshift sling.

“Kudzoo,” says Akello, “stay calm, baby. We’re gonna toss you to safety, okay?”

Kudzoo gives a little nod.

“On my count,” says Akello, “start swinging. One, two, three!”

Up and over go the trunks, and up and over goes Kudzoo. She lands with a little *plop* on the gorilla side of the moat, right next to Masika’s rear legs.

“Good work, everyone!” says Akello. “And good thinking, Ruby!”

“Th-thanks, elephants!” says Kudzoo, wiping mud from her eyes. “That was fun. Can we do it again?”

Akello takes a deep breath. “Maybe later, sweetheart.”

Quickly I make my way back over the moat. “Kudzoo,” I say, “follow me. Let’s go find your ape peeps.”

“Can I go with Bob?” Ruby asks Akello.

Akello touches Ruby’s back with her trunk. “I’d much rather have you stay here, dear. And it’s ‘*may* I.’”

“But Uncle Ivan!” Ruby pleads.

“I’ll keep an eye on her,” I tell Akello.

“I’m going,” Ruby says in her most determined voice. “Maybe I can help. I helped just now.”

Akello hesitates but finally gives a slow nod. Probably she figures there’s no arguing with Ruby.

She’s right on that one.

Ruby crosses the moat and joins Kudzoo and me. “Be careful,” Akello warns. “There’s more of this storm coming.”

“I got her, Akello,” I say.

“You’d *better* have her,” she warns.

“I think I flew, Bob,” says Kudzoo as we weave our way through the wasteland that was Gorilla World.

“Yeah, me too,” I say. “It’s that kinda day.”



what's out there

A handful of humans—firefighters and police, mostly—have begun to roam the grounds, checking out the damage. We pass a park employee with a weapon slung over his shoulder and a net in one hand.

“Tranq gun,” he tells a passing police officer. “We don’t know what’s out there.”

She nods. “How fast do they work?”

“On something like a big cat?” He shakes his head. “Not fast enough.”

I look over at Ruby. “Stay close, kid.”

As we near the gorilla villa—what’s left of it, anyways—a screech hits my ears that makes the wailing police sirens sound like mewling kittens.

It’s Kinyani.

She’s frantically knuckle running back and forth near the collapsed gorilla villa. Chunks of cement, shredded wooden beams, and bent metal lie everywhere. A cluster of gorilla females and juveniles huddle not far from some rescue workers.

“There’s Mama!” Kudzoo cries, dashing toward a gorilla named Jodi.

I’m so horrified by the destruction that I’ve almost forgotten my muddy little charge.

I really shouldn’t be trusted as an ape-sitter.

Kudzoo darts over to her mother’s waiting embrace. Jodi nuzzles her and strokes her and says soothing, motherly gorilla things. “Thank you,” Jodi

mouths to me.

“Don’t thank me,” I say, looking over at Ruby. “Thank this little gal. She figured out how to save Kudzoo.”

“Thank you—Ruby, isn’t it? Ivan’s friend?”

Ruby gives a shy nod. “We all helped.”

“I provided moral support,” I add.

“I flew, Mama,” says Kudzoo.

“Of course you did, dear,” says Jodi.

Kinyani’s fresh wails focus my mind. “I gotta go,” I say. “Ruby, you should stay here.” I’m going for a no-nonsense voice, the one Julia uses on me when she calls me “Robert.” “Lemme see what’s what. I’ll be right back.”

“No way, Uncle Bob,” Ruby replies, just as firmly.

I give up. But I’m afraid of what she might see. Of what we both might see.

“Any sign of Ivan?” I ask Jodi.

She shakes her head, a grim look clouding her eyes.

With Ruby by my side, we approach the pile of wreckage that used to be the gorilla villa.

At the same moment, Ruby and I gasp.

There’s Ivan’s hand, barely peeking through the rubble.

not moving

I know that hand like the back of my own paw.

“No!” Ruby screams. “Uncle Ivan!”

I check the crowd. No sign of Julia or George. Nothing. No Maya, either, or other keepers I recognize. Just a few employees, several rescue workers, and two or three dazed-looking visitors.

“Is he alive?” a firefighter asks.

“Hand—whatever it’s called—isn’t moving,” says another.

Weaving my way through the tangle of legs, I climb up the rubble pile, sniff a bit, and bark my loudest *Yes, he’s alive, get your rears in gear* bark.

Just like those overachieving rescue dogs in the *Man’s Best Friend* show.

I listen for a sound from Ivan, a grunt, a cry for help. Nothing.

Still, he smells alive.

At least I think he does. And that’s good enough for me.

xena

Another dog races over, a tough-looking German shepherd wearing an impressive glow-in-the-dark vest and some bootie things to protect her feet from the rubble, but I hold my ground.

This is *my* friend we're talking about.

I lick Ivan's hand. His fingers twitch.

Well, that's all it takes to get both of us barking like maniacs.

More people gather. I see Maya next to Ruby, which makes me feel better.

"Name's Xena," says the shepherd.

"Bob."

I nudge Ivan's fingers with my nose. Nothing.

"And this is Ivan. My best bud."

"Sorry to hear it," she replies, and I don't like the sound of her voice.

With great care, and far too slowly for my taste, rescue workers begin removing chunks of the wreckage and tossing them to one side.

Xena and me, we mostly stay outa the way, but every so often I lick Ivan's hand, just so he knows we've got him covered.

I glance over at Maya and Ruby. Maya is wiping tears from her eyes while she strokes Ruby's ears. Ruby is giving Maya a comforting trunk-hug.

Good ol' Ruby. Wise beyond her years, that gal.

I check the crowd again. Still no sign of Julia or George. And that's when a sickening thought hits me like a bite to the belly.

What if Ivan isn't the only one under the rubble?

dragon

More police cars and ambulances arrive at the park. A handful of keepers stream in, too, looking frantic and confused.

The weirdest thing of all? Wandering through all the destruction are random park residents. Animals. Birds. Reptiles.

Residents who most definitely do not belong in Gorilla World.

A police officer is chasing an armadillo.

A great blue heron watches the mayhem from her position atop a giraffe statue.



A wallaby pokes his nose out of a bush, his saucer eyes catching the fire engine lights.

“Nets!” someone yells. “We need more nets!”

An older gentleman holding a blue umbrella lets out a bloodcurdling scream. “Dragon!” he cries. “I swear to you I just saw a baby dragon!”

“Sir,” says a keeper named Malik, “no worries. That’s actually a Gila monster. His name is Gilligan.”

A paramedic raises his hand. “They have, like, venom, don’t they?”

“They say a healthy adult won’t die from it.” Malik shrugs. “Although they’ll be in some serious pain.”

“Wonderful,” the paramedic mutters.

I glance over my shoulder to see Sara running toward Maya. I can’t hear her words, but I can definitely see the worry in her eyes.

Xena’s ears tip forward. “They’re getting the cutters and the jaws of life.”

“Jaws?” I repeat. Don’t like the sound of that.

“Spreads metal. They’re probably getting close. C’mon. We need to get outa the way.”

“I ain’t going anywhere.”

“I hear ya,” she says, and I can tell from the weary sound of her voice that she’s had this conversation before. “But the best thing for Ivan right now is to let the humans do their thing.”

I think about it. Figure she’s right. I give his fingers one last lick. They don’t move.

Nothing. Nada.

We pick our way to the bottom of the debris pile. “Hang in there, Ivan!” I call. “We love ya, buddy!”

I know it’s crazy, but I listen anyways, hoping for a sign, any sign, that he’s still with us.

hugging

I run to Kinyani. “Don’t worry,” I tell her. “He’s gonna make it.”

I can tell she doesn’t believe me.

From there, I head over to Maya and Sara and Ruby. Maya has a radio handset in one hand and, for some reason, a young, squirmy meerkat in the other.

Sara kneels down and hugs me tighter than any sweater she’s ever knit. “Bob,” she cries, “what happened to your nose? And look at your paw!”

Some dogs don’t like to be hugged that way.

I’m one of them.

But Sara needs to do it. I can tell somehow. So I let her.

Isn’t so bad, really.

loose

A new police officer joins us. “Officer Williams.” She nods at Maya. “You’re with the park, right?”

“Yes. I’m Maya.”

“This . . .” Officer Williams pauses. “We need to get this under control ASAP. Winds are gonna pick up, and we haven’t even hit the eye. Storm surge could be an issue. This one’s moving slow.”

“We’ve got a skeleton staff here,” says Maya as the meerkat attempts to eat her earring. “Early reports say maybe a third of the habitats are damaged or destroyed.” She shakes her head. “We’ve got some injuries, some possible fatalities, too.”

“Human?”

“Don’t think so.”

“Anything loose that could be a . . . you know, problem?”

Maya presses her lips together. “Yep.”

“Such as?”

“A couple Florida panthers. Gray wolves. Python, maybe. Possibly an alligator or two. American alligators, not Chinese.”

“I don’t care if they’re from Canada. If they eat people, we’re in trouble.”

“They don’t. Typically.”

“Typically,” Officer Williams repeats. “Well, that’s reassuring.”

Sara loosens her grip on me ever so slightly. “Maya,” she asks, voice trembling, “have you heard anything on the radio from George and Julia? I keep calling, but the cell towers are down.”

“Nothing yet,” Maya says. “But I’m sure they’re fine.”

“Nearest shelter’s over at Lincoln Elementary,” says Officer Williams. “You could check there.”

Sara frowns. “They were probably here right before the tornado hit.”

“We’re searching the park, ma’am,” says the officer. “We’ll find them if they’re here.”

“Everybody, clear out,” a firefighter with a megaphone yells from a spot near Ivan. “Could be danger of more collapse. We’re working on this last metal beam.”

I look to see if Ivan’s fingers are moving.

Nothing.

“Hold on, Ivan!” I yell.

Nothing.

Sometimes nothing is the worst sound in the world.

Ruby lets out a little elephant cry, and then I realize maybe *that’s* the worst sound in the world.

cpr

The wind dies down to a whisper, as if the world is holding its breath along with the rest of us.

“Do you have any vets standing by?” asks Officer Williams as two more ambulances screech to a halt nearby.

“Yes.” Maya nods. “Not sure when they’ll get here, though.”

Officer Williams waves down an ambulance crew member. “You ever give CPR to a gorilla?”

“Primate’s a primate, I guess,” he says, but he doesn’t look too sure. “What’s going on?”

“We’re waiting on equipment, but we’re stretched pretty thin. Lot of structural damage on the north side of town,” says Officer Williams. “They’re going to get a chain on that last beam, try pulling it free with one of the cars.”

“Somebody under there?”

“Gorilla, we think. Not sure what else. Or who else.”

I look at all the cement. All the wood and metal. Nobody could survive that. Not even a silverback gorilla with the strength of eight men.

And yet. Ivan’s fingers moved.

And then they didn’t.

Several minutes pass. The rain slows a bit, along with the wind. The crowd watches as three firefighters attach a long chain to the metal beam next to

Ivan, then hook it to a tow bar on the rear of a police car.

“Back up, folks!” calls the megaphone guy. “Farther!”

The chain clanks, the car growls, the wheels squeal.

Grinding. Groaning.

Progress. Just a bit.

The big chunk of metal has definitely moved a whisker or two.

More grinding. Wheels dig holes in the ground. Mud flies like thick brown rain.

A lurch. A snap.

Clanks and rumbles as the big beam jerks free.

The rescue workers move in, digging with their bare hands. Cement and dust and metal and bits and pieces of Gorilla World are everywhere.

But where is Ivan?

no

No movement, nothing.

But after a few more minutes, one thing is clear.

A gorilla-shaped mound has appeared. Covered by dust and dirt and debris and splattered with rain.

It just lies there.

I've lost a lot in my life.

My whole family. Stella.

But Ivan? No. It can't happen.

Not Ivan.

miracle

The mound sits up.

gorilla ghost

Ivan emerges from a cloud of dust like a jumbo-sized ghost.

He blinks several times. Coughs. Shakes. Stretches a little.

He's holding a banana.



Which he proceeds to eat.

Everyone, and I do mean everyone, cheers.

wolf on the run

I scramble over to Ivan, and he gives me a look that says, *You're the best, Bob.*

"I thought you were a goner," I say, licking some banana goo off his chin.

"Me too." Ivan seems a little dazed. His eyelashes are white with dust. "What happened, anyway?"

"Tornado."

"Ruby okay? Kinyani? Julia? George?"

"Haven't seen Julia or George yet. Kinyani's over there, carrying on."

A paramedic holding a box of medical equipment approaches us nervously.

"I've got this!" calls a woman I recognize as one of the park veterinarians. The paramedic looks happy to step aside.

The vet gently but firmly pushes me out of the way. "I'll be back," I tell Ivan.

I run to Kinyani. "He's good, totally good." The look of joy in her eyes makes me want to give her an affectionate nose nudge.

Almost.

From there I join Ruby and Maya. "I was so scared, Bob!" Ruby whispers.

"Me too," I admit. "Me too. But he's fine. I promise."

We watch a pair of otters dart past, chased by a guy with a net. One of the firefighters who'd been clearing debris yells, "We're clear here. No sign of other victims."

Sara closes her eyes and I can smell her relieved tears.

While Maya listens to her walkie-talkie, trying to take stock of the damage to the park, Officer Williams's police radio hisses and crackles with new problems, new flooding, new dire predictions.

"Copy that," she says into her radio. Even with the chaos and noise, I'm close enough to the radio to catch the tinny sound of frantic barking.

"We've got a unit reporting the animal shelter down the street's flooding," Officer Williams says. "Also we've got trailer park damage on Twelfth Street, an oak down at Nelson Avenue blocking traffic, and a big rig overturned near the fairgrounds. And that's just for starters."

Out of the corner of my eye, I notice something airborne. It's graceful and bold, like a huge, wingless bird.

The crowd gasps.

It's Kimu.

He lands on the hood of Officer Williams's squad car. His eyes are glazed, his coat wet and shimmering.

"We've got a 10-91 here," Officer Williams whispers into her receiver. "Confirmed. Seems there's a, uh, wolf on top of my vehicle."

Slowly she reaches for the pistol on her hip. "Please advise."

shots fired

Several officers raise their guns. The tranquilizer dart guy takes aim too.

“No!” Maya yells. “No guns!”

Kimu blinks, eyes darting right and left, then leaps off the car with such grace and speed it’s like he owns the wind.

Two shots ring out. Silence follows.

“Was he hit?” someone asks.

Maya closes her eyes. “I sure hope not.”

“I sure hope so,” someone else says.

jungle

As I watched that leap, watched Kimu fly, I didn't know what to think.

Part of me was like, *Go for it, dude.*

And the other part of me was thinking, *It's a jungle out there.*

a situation

Officer Williams climbs onto a picnic table. Someone hands her a megaphone so she can be heard over the din.

“Folks,” she yells, “listen up. We’ve got a handful of animal control workers coming over, but several roads are already flooded out, and the weather guys are saying Gus is gonna take his sweet time. Meantime, park supervisors, call in more help, but only if your workers can get here safely.”

The unmistakable roar of a big cat rolls over us like slow thunder.

“Any more tranq guns?” Officer Williams asks the park director, who’s just arrived.

“Three in reserve,” she answers.

“Nets?”

“We have a dozen.”

“Okay, then.” Officer Williams’s radio crackles. I can hear more shouting, more barking dogs. “Shelter’s flooding,” she says.

“Yeah, that’s happened there before,” the director says. “Usually just a foot or two of water.”

“Okay, public safety is where we start.” Officer Williams wipes rain from her forehead. “We need to get the word out that these animals are on the loose.”

“Of course,” says the director. “We have protocols in place. But we need to be careful how we word this. People might overreact, might—”

“Ma’am,” a firefighter interrupts, “I see a python in my backyard, I’m sure as heck gonna overreact.”

“First things first,” says Officer Williams. “Triage in the main office. Check wreckage for any survivors, human or animal. Fan out with tranq guns, get an inventory on how many animals are loose.”

I wonder how it’s possible that Officer Williams can seem so composed. The air reeks with fear, from animals, birds, people.

From me.

And yet she doesn’t seem worried about herself. Just other people. Weird, the way some humans stick their necks out for others. Doesn’t make a whole lot of sense, does it?

Again, the crackle, the hiss, the barking. My ears perk up for a minute. Was that a familiar voice? Maybe someone I know is in the slammer?

“I’m going to the shelter at the elementary school,” Sara says. Her hands are trembling, but her voice is firm. “To look for George and Julia. Just in case.”

She strokes my head and I’m happy to let her. I wonder if I should tag along with her, see if I can help out. Now that I know Ivan and Ruby are safe.

Hiss. Crackle. Meow. Bark.

I hear it again. My ears go on alert. My body goes rigid.

No. It’s impossible.

never

Some barks you never forget.

one place

I know what I have to do.

Despite the turmoil all around me, the noises, the smells, the fear, the confused humans, the frantic animals. Despite my worry about Julia and George.

I know there's one place I need to be.

a split second

I want to tell Ivan and Ruby. But Ivan is still being poked at by the rhymes-with-pet-threat.

Although, come to think of it, she doesn't seem like much of a threat. In a movie, she'd be one of the good guys.

To my annoyance, Sara picks me up. I hate being picked up. Unless it's my idea. Then it's totally cool.

"Maya," she says, "you let me know, first sign of George and Julia, okay?"

"Promise," says Maya, and she places her hand on Sara's shoulder.

Humans, always with the touching. Although I kind of get it, under the circumstances.

"You can't take Bob to the school shelter. They're not allowing any more pets," Maya points out. "And the animal shelter is flooding, it sounds like. Why don't you leave him here? I'll put him my office. He'll be safe."

No way is that on my agenda.

Sara nods. "Good idea."

She starts to hand me over but hesitates when she realizes Maya still has a meerkat wrapped around her neck.

It's just a split second, but a split second is all it takes to escape when you're Bob, untamed and undaunted.

on my way

“Bob!” Sara cries.

“Grab that dog!” Maya yells.

I spent a good part of my life running from a certain guy named Mack, and I still have my moves. I twist and spin and dip, and before you can say *Yes sirree Bob*, they’ve given up.

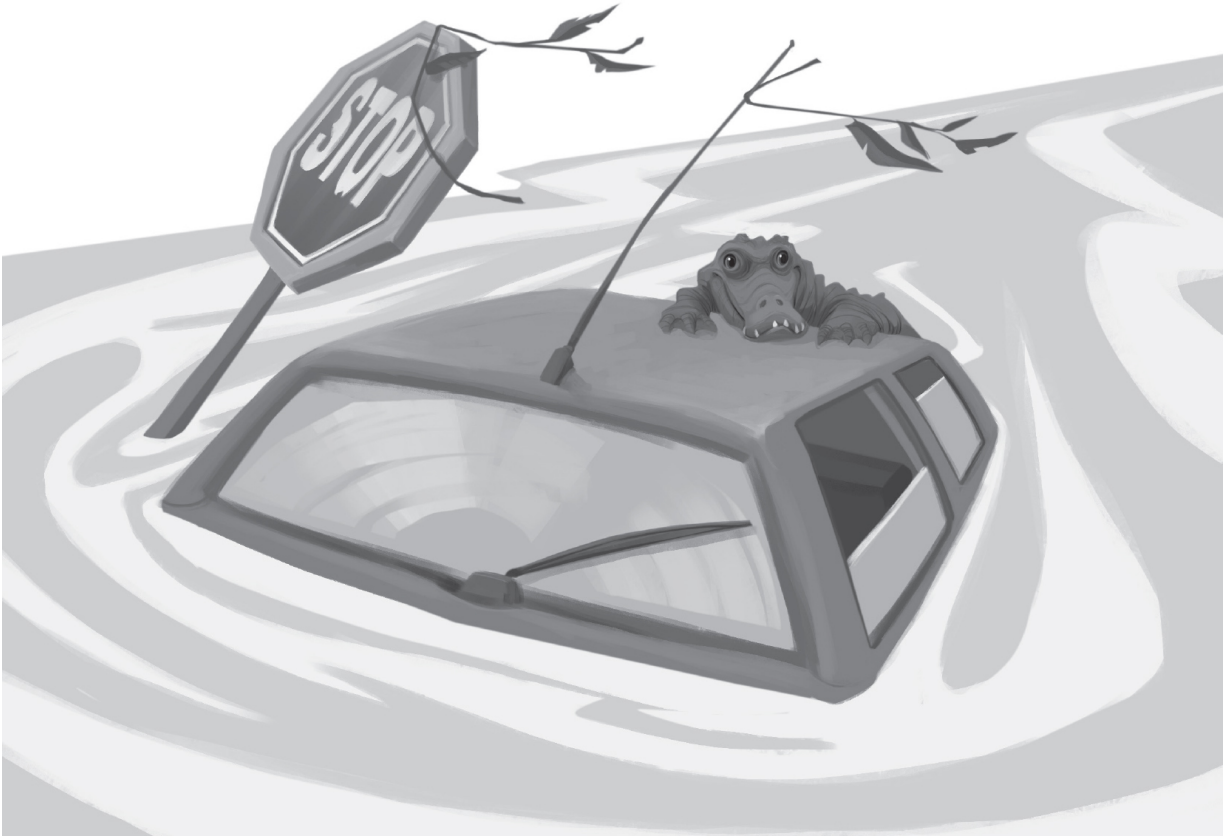
I backtrack, slip under a bench, and make my way to Ruby. “Ruby,” I whisper, “I gotta go. Something important’s come up. You and Ivan see if you can find George and Julia.”

“I want to come!” Ruby says, stomping her right front foot in a huge puddle.

“You need to keep an eye on Ivan,” I say. “Make sure Kinyani doesn’t drive him loco with her sobbing. I’ll be back before you know it.”

I don’t wait for an answer.

I’m off into the wild, into the world filled with wind and rain, with wolves and alligators, with a voice that could rip my heart in two.



Three

looking

Ivan used to ask me what I did when I wasn't hanging out at the Exit 8 Big Top Mall and Video Arcade.

I wasn't like the rest of the animals. Caged, trapped.

I told him I was scrounging for food. And he never questioned it.

When you think about it, though, where's a better place to find food than the floor of a mall at the end of the day?

Yeah. I wasn't looking for food.

I was looking for her.

For Boss.

what if

At first, I didn't admit it to myself.

You know how it is when you wish for something so bad you're afraid to say it out loud, 'cause what if it never happens?

It was like that.

I knew the odds were crazy long. I knew I was nuts.

And yet.

I went out, day after day, searching for her.

six

There'd been six of us in the litter. So why was I only looking for her?

Because it was *her* bark I'd heard.

After the box landed. Even after the truck roared past.

I heard it. A whimper-bark-howl-cry, something I've never heard since.

She survived, at least at first.

I survived.

The rest of them didn't.

relieved

And what did I do, when I heard that bark? Did I run toward it? Did I try to find her, to save her?

No.

No.

I was just a few weeks old. Helpless. Useless.

The cries stopped almost as soon as they'd started. And you know what?

Part of me was relieved.

I didn't want to have to go back onto that highway. I couldn't bear wanting to rescue her and not knowing how.

I didn't want to see her die.

But mostly, I was afraid.

coward

I was afraid. A coward.

There's a certain freedom that comes with owning your faults.

the wind

Every day I went looking for Boss. Up and down that same barren stretch of highway.

Sometimes I'd catch a hint of something hopeful on the air and think it was my sister's scent. I'd be certain the breeze had brought me her voice, like an invisible gift.

The wind can really mess with your head.

enough

After a while I stopped going to the highway.

Stopped looking.

It was a relief to give up. I had enough to worry about.

my paddles

As I run from the park, I keep hearing my sister's yelp in my head. Still, with every step, my doubts grow.

Sometimes we hear what we want to hear.

The animal shelter is close, just down the street, but there's nothing quick about the trip. Water rushes past like a raging river. The sun's been swallowed by black clouds.

I pick my way through muddy front yards, avoiding the worst of the water.

I ain't much of a swimmer. Doesn't come up much in my line of work, though I do a passable dog paddle.

The problem is my paddles. My paws are tiny. Not much to work with when you're fighting a flood.

I see a couple humans with flashlights, carving tunnels in the sheeting rain. But mostly the street seems eerily abandoned, especially after the chaos of the park.

The shelter is at the bottom of a slight hill. Rain's pooled outside the front door, despite a pile of sodden sandbags. A police car is out front, parked at an odd angle.

I find some footing on a large rock near the door. Takes me three slippery tries, but I manage to leap onto the topmost sandbag.

I bark, bark with all I've got. But I might as well be voiceless, between the wind and the rain and the howling animals begging for escape.

inside

I pause to listen. I hear humans shouting, and I can make out what sounds like police radio chatter.

But I don't hear Boss. I'm right here, right at the source. Nothing.

It wasn't her bark I heard.

She's dead and I'm crazy and hearing things and drenched and shivering and where is Julia, where is George— "Hey, little guy." The door eases open, just a crack.

Every bone in my body, every smart part of my doggie brain, says *RUN*.

This is an animal shelter. A flooding one, apparently. My sister isn't here. And I still have to find George and Julia.

The door moves.

Swoop.

The loop comes down around my neck so fast that for a moment I don't know what it is. It's like a cowboy's lasso, the kind in old Western movies I used to watch with Ivan.

But this lasso is at the end of a long metal handle.

And at the end of the long metal handle is a man.

"Stay calm, buddy." The man eases me, gently but firmly, off the sandbags and through the door.

I'm inside the bow-wow big house.

The hound pound.

The pet pokey.

Oops.

the return of snickers

The man pulls me along with his lasso. I decide not to argue.

We enter a small room stacked with animal-filled metal cages, and I'm assaulted by howls and hisses. The cold water on the floor sloshes as we walk, just skimming my belly.

As bad as my smeller is, I instantly pick up on one distinctive odor.

It's like the world's worst perfume, the kind old ladies emit. The kind people spray on their dogs to camouflage their lovely dog stink. The kind—
The kind Snickers wears.

I catch a glimpse of her in an upper cage. Bedraggled bow in her droopy hair.

"Snick baby, fancy meeting you here," I say. "You look good behind bars."

"Harebrain," she replies.

"Hey," calls a rabbit two cages down. "Watch your language."

"Mack couldn't deal with you?" I ask Snickers.

"He brought me here because he thought it would be safer."

"Seems he may have been mistaken," I say.

Carefully grabbing my scruff, Cowboy lifts me into an upper cage. He pulls the lasso loose and shuts the barred door. I'm not happy. But it's a relief to be out of my noose.

“Oh, great, another one?” calls a woman wearing tall rubber boots. She pauses in the doorway. “I thought we were turning people away.”

“People, yes,” says Cowboy. “But this pup came solo.”

“Tick-tock, folks,” says an older, ruddy-faced officer. He’s holding a radio in one hand and a flashlight in the other. “You are running out of time.”

“We hear ya. But first we’ve got to move everybody who’s lower level.” Boots sighs. “Last hurricane we had two feet to deal with. I swear they’re getting worse.”

“Climate change,” says the officer. “What’re ya gonna do?”

“More than we’re doin’,” says Boots. “That much is for sure.”

“I’ll move the dogs from room two,” Cowboy offers. “There are only a couple on the bottom level. We’re outa cages, though. We’ll have to double up.”

“Put that little female in with the new guy,” says Boots. “They look like twins.”

I’m shivering. And it’s not because I’m cold.

I press my hurt nose to the metal bars.

I smell something. I do.

I hear something. I do.

Cowboy returns, dog in arms.

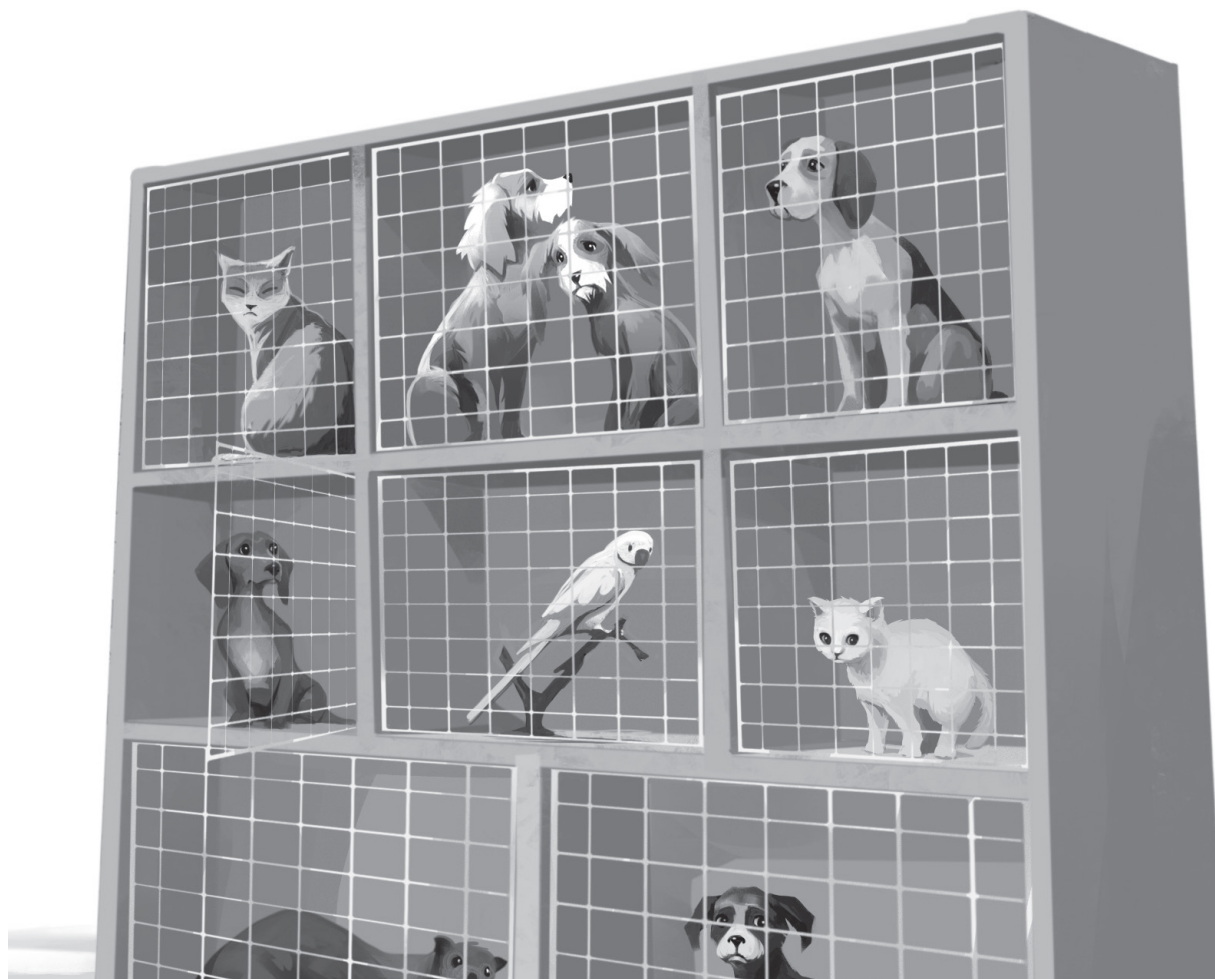
A bark.

That bark.

The door to my cage opens.

“Hey,” I say automatically, even as my heart is already whispering the truth to me, “they call me Bob.”

“They call me Boss,” says the voice, but by now I know, of course I know, and I’m howling with joy.



alive

Thunder claps. Shutters fly. Windows rattle. Water rushes. Dogs whimper.
Cats howl. People yell.

And all I can hear is my sister's voice.

catching up

We lick each other, sniff, yelp, circle, wrestle.

Neither of us was ever the touchy-feely sort.

But sometimes you just gotta let it all out.

“Wow,” says Cowboy, watching us. “You’d think they knew each other.”

tough

Boss isn't anything like I remember. She's scrawny and flea covered. Her left ear has a big notch in it. Her fur is dull, her body scarred, her tail cut short.

I'm afraid to ask how *that* happened.

She's clearly had it tough, really tough.

"I thought I heard your bark," I say, "but then it stopped. Figured I was crazy."

"I was napping."

"In this chaos?" I ask.

"I can sleep anywhere. It's a gift." Boss nibbles on a toenail. "Funny thing is I was having a dream about you. Must've caught a whiff of you in my sleep."

I can't stop staring. Boss. Here. With me.

"What?" she asks when she catches me looking at her.

"I was just wondering," I say, "about your life. Do you have . . . you know, anybody?"

"You mean like humans? Nope." She gives a little flick of her stubby tail. "Never have. Never will."

"You've been on your own this whole time?" I flash on my cushy bed, my lovely food bowl, the way everyone knows just how I like my ear scratches.

“Yep.”

“How’d you end up here?”

“I was out scrounging for food. Just had another litter and I was tired, off my game. Animal control got me.” She licks a nasty cut on her front paw.

“Wait.” My ears prick up. “So . . . you have puppies?”

That would make me an uncle. A dog uncle, on top of being an honorary elephant uncle.

“Had the last batch seven, maybe eight weeks ago.” She scratches at a flea.

“Last batch?” I repeat. “You mean you’ve had others?”

“Yep.”

“What happened to them?”

“Dunno. It’s not like they come home for the holidays, Bob.” Boss lies down on the old towel lining our cage. “Or should I call you Rowdy?” She considers. “Nope. No, I like the sound of Bob.”

“Me too.”

“Anyway,” Boss says, “mostly they’re dead, I’d guess. You never know, though. Maybe a few got rescued.”

She’s so matter-of-fact. So resigned.

“This last litter, well, I thought I was onto something. Found this little car, you know those ones that look like a big ol’ bug? Abandoned. Right down by the creek, near that bridge. Easy access through a hole in the floorboard. Blanket in the back seat.” She pauses. “All the amenities.”

“How many puppies?” I ask.

“Three. But only one survived, a male. The other two were pretty sickly, and, well . . . you know.”

Something crashes into the front office. Sounds like a window has broken.

“We gotta get outa here!” an orange-striped cat howls. He throws himself against the front of his cage, then pokes out his paw, grabbing for the latch. “I’m too young to die!”

“When they caught me,” Boss continues, ignoring the cat, “I barked for the puppy to sit tight, wait. Told him I’d be right back.” She sighs. “Nice. Last thing he’ll ever hear was a lie.”

“What’s his name? The puppy?”

She looks at me like I asked her if she’s ever been to the moon. “I don’t name them, Bob. Just makes it harder.”

Below us, the water’s slowly rising, filling the empty lower cages. We watch the humans rush back and forth, carrying buckets, as if they can stem the tide.

There’s nothing to do. Nothing to say. And nowhere to go.

not right

I stare at my sister and try to imagine all the pain she's endured.

And here I thought *I'd* gotten the raw deal.

To lose your pups. To wander alone. To struggle for every drop of water, every crumb of food.

I mean, I experienced a little of that. But Ivan and Stella kept me going. And then Julia and her family.

Why me? What's so special about me?

Is it really that I'm more resilient? That I've made my own luck?

Am I somehow better than Boss? More deserving?

"It's not right," I blurt. "Not right you shoulda had it worse than me."

"Well, if you want to talk about 'not right,' you and I both had it a whole lot better than our siblings," Boss says.

"I will never forgive those people for what they did to us," I say through clenched jaws.

"Really?" Boss seems surprised. "If I held on to that much anger, I'd never get out of bed. Not that I've ever had a real bed." She sniffs at the towel beneath her feet. "This towel's kinda nice, actually."

I look at her in disbelief. "You're one of those? Those 'dogs must forgive no matter what' types?"

She almost looks amused. "Well, it is kind of our thing, right?"

“When someone does something hurtful, they have to admit it,” I say. “Then they have to be punished for it. And maybe then, if they apologize and change, maybe—maybe—*then* they get forgiven.”

“All I know is, I’ve done lots of bad stuff in my life, Bob. I’ve had to forgive myself plenty, just, you know, to get through the day.” Boss gazes at me with her wise, weary eyes. “And I figure if I’m going to forgive myself, I’d better be ready to cut everyone else some slack, too.”

evacuate now!

“Look,” says the officer, “you need to evacuate now. It’s mandatory.”

“We can’t just leave these animals.” Cowboy sticks his finger in the orange cat’s cage. The cat rubs against it, purring like his life depends on it.

Which it maybe kinda does.



The officer sighs. “You don’t have a choice.”

“We can’t just leave them,” says Boots, and I have to applaud her enthusiasm, even as I wonder why she’d risk her life for us.

There is no explaining humans.

“Just got word the bridge over Big Fork Creek collapsed,” the officer says.
“You guys gotta move.”

Boots snaps her fingers. “Wait, you have a cop car, right?”

“Yes, I have a vehicle, ma’am,” says the officer. “But the way the roads are looking, probably not for long.”

“Okay,” says Boots, “so we evacuate. We evacuate every last dog and cat and gerbil we can get in your car.”

The officer purses his lips. “And take them where, exactly?”

“Shelter at the high school. That’s where we’ve been sending people. They’re not really set up for it, but once we started flooding and the elementary school stopped taking pets, they agreed to do what they can.”

The officer grumbles, considers, goes for it.

The three humans load cats and dogs, parakeets and hamsters, one after another, into the police car. Some are in cages, and some, including a couple of unhappy cats, are on tug-of-war strings. Finally, it’s our turn. Looks like there are nine of us left.

“Car’s full and then some,” the officer reports, struggling to shut the shelter’s front door against the rising water. “We are officially out of room.”

Cowboy looks at us, his eyes teary. “Don’t worry, fellas. We’ll be back.” He snuffles. “I promise.”

“You think we should leave the cages open, at least give ’em a fighting chance,” asks Boots, “in case . . . you know?”

“Sure. But they couldn’t handle this current. I can barely stand up.” Cowboy shakes his head. “Look, I’ll borrow my brother’s bass boat. We’ll come right back. Hopefully the water won’t get much higher than this.”

“Okay, then.” Boots gives a grim nod. “Stay calm, friends.”

Like that’s an option.

preparing for the worst

The wind slows for a moment and the room goes silent. We stare at the black pool swallowing the cages below.

A chew toy shaped like a pink turtle floats past.

It's just us and a whole lot of water.

I check out the group. Two cats. One bunny. Six dogs, including Snickers, Boss, and me. There's nowhere to jump. No tables, no cabinets. No space above the upper cages.

And as Cowboy pointed out, the current is probably too strong for us to tackle, anyways.

"Folks, don't give up hope. You heard them," I say. "They're coming back for us."

"No way are they coming back," says a sad-faced beagle mix. "Gimme a break."

"You never know," I say. I am such a lousy liar.

"Oh, yes we do," my sister mutters, just loud enough for me to hear, and we share a look.

"Look, chances are the water won't get too much higher," I say. "But just to be on the safe side, pile up anything you have in your cage. Bowls, toys, towels."

"Who died and made you pack leader?" asks a big mutt with a graying snout.

“Well, it beats howling like babies,” I say, and instantly I remember landing in Stretch’s domain. Howling like a baby is exactly what I did.

“I had a dog biscuit this morning bigger than you,” says Gray Muzzle.

“What about me?” someone squeaks. “Does the bunny get a vote?”

“Hold on, Thumper,” says the orange cat. “This clearly is a job for a higher feline intellect.”

“No!” A sharp voice rises above the din. “Listen to Bob. He’s annoying. And his hygiene leaves a lot to be desired. But I’ve seen him get himself out of all kinds of scrapes.”

“Thanks for the props, Snick,” I say. “Especially the kind words about my odor.”

The wind groans, and something metallic hits the side of the building. We fall silent again, waiting for more.

The windows rattle. The walls shudder. It’s like the building is as scared as the rest of us.

“So,” Snickers says, breaking the gloom, “you heard Bob. Start stacking!”

“How about my litter box?” asks a small, white cat with dark green eyes. “Would that work?”

“Sure,” I say. “Use anything. The goal is to get as high as you can.”

“And then what?” asks a young dachshund.

“Worst case, we swim for it,” I say.

“That’s actually *not* the worst case,” says the bunny.

No one asks what is. We already know.

a question

We do all we can do. Which isn't much.

The rain hammers. The wind shrieks. Sirens come and go in the distance.

I wonder what Ivan and Ruby are doing. And what about George and Julia? Where are they? *How* are they?

Boss seems scary calm. Tough as old jerky. She looks the way I want to feel.

Before long, the water is lapping onto the floor of our cages. It's ice-cold. And moving quick. One inch, two.

Every now and then someone whimpers or moans. But mostly, we're quiet.

"If you can stand on your hind legs, guys, do it. Climb on anything you got," I suggest.

I turn to Boss. "When I say go, I want you to climb on my back. It'll buy you a little time, maybe."

"No way."

"Please. I need to do this."

Boss just stares at me. She's so thin. I can see every rib.

"To make it up to you," I add.

"What are you even talking about, Bob?"

I look away. “I’m sorry,” I say, not sure where my words are taking me. “I could’ve . . . I should’ve saved you, Boss.”

“Saved me?”

“The thing is . . . I heard you on the highway. And I should’ve—”

My voice trails off. I stifle a sob.

“Bob, we were puppies. Tiny puppies. Don’t be ridiculous. How exactly were you going to save me?”

“I dunno. But I should have tried.”

“We both did what we had to do.” Boss nudges me gently. “Bob. This is crazy.”

“I just . . . I can’t seem to forgive myself.” I whisper it, but I know she hears me.

Beneath the water, I feel a paw on mine. “I forgive you. Okay? Not that you need it, mind you. One condition, though.”

I nod, wait.

“You have to forgive yourself, too.”

Again I nod, and slowly but surely something fine and warm begins to fill my heart.

romeo

Before I can say anything more, Snickers calls my name. “Bob, dear? There’s something I want you to know.”

Boss winks at me. “Listen up, brother.”

“Um, sure, Snickers,” I call. “What’s up?”



“Ahem.” Snickers makes a little throat-clearing noise. “I’ve kept this locked inside me all this time, but now, facing the end, I feel the need to unburden myself.”

“Really, Snick,” I say quickly, “there’s no need for that.”

“The thing is”—Snickers pauses for dramatic effect—“I love you, Bob. I always have. I love the way your cute little tail gets all curled between your legs when you’re embarrassed. I love the way you hum to yourself when you chew your kibble. I love the way you drool when you take a nap. I love —”

“I think I’m gettin’ the picture, Snick. Thanks. That’s awfully nice of you to say.”

“And?” Snickers says.

Boss can’t hide her amusement. “Go ahead, Bob,” she whispers. “What can it hurt? We’re all gonna die, anyway.”

“Bobbo?” Snickers calls.

“Um, yeah. Yeah, sure. I, uh, think you’re pretty swell, too, Snick.”

“And what is it that you love about me?”

I close my eyes. Take a deep breath. “Well, um, those pink boots of yours, those are cool.”

“And?”

I swear I’m trying, but I’m totally drawing a blank. In fairness, the water’s up to my belly and my teeth are chattering so loud I can’t hear myself think.

“And, uh . . . ,” I begin.

“Oh, c’mon, how hard is it?” yells the bunny, who’s perched on a pile of wet timothy hay. “She’s a looker and she’s smart and she’s way too good for the likes of you. Try that, Romeo.”

“You’re a looker and you’re smart and you’re way too good for the likes of me,” I repeat.

Snickers lets out a contented sigh.

“That wasn’t so hard, was it?” Boss asks.

I groan. “Sis, you have no idea.”

an interesting life

An awful noise comes, like a tree trunk splitting in two. While we watch in disbelief, a piece of the roof, the size of a Great Dane, simply vanishes. Rain gushes through the hole in torrents.

“Boss,” I say, “it’s time. Jump on my back.”

“And that’s a good idea because . . . why, exactly?”

“Because maybe you’ll get your turn,” I say. “Your chance to have things go your way. I’ve had an interesting life. I want you to have one, too.”

“Bob, at best you’re buying me a couple extra minutes,” Boss says.

“Sis.”

“I’m like thirty seconds older than you. You’re not the boss of me.”

“Please?”

“Why? Just because you’re a guy? I could take you down in a second with three paws tied behind my back.”

“And if you get outa here and I don’t?” I continue, ignoring her. “There’s a place I want you to go. Sit on the front porch. Wait for the humans who live there.”

“Who are you kidding, Bob? We’re both about to die.”

“Three blocks up, four houses down on the left. Look for a big oak tree. Guy named Nutwit lives there.”

“Nutwit.” She’s suppressing a smile.

“Say it,” I command.

“Fine. Whatever. Three blocks up. Four houses down. Nutwit.”

We go back and forth like that, arguing, bantering, trying not to hear the terror of our cagemates, and I think maybe I’m starting to hallucinate a little. I’m starving and freezing and I feel kinda dizzy. All the smells and sounds are mingling together, and, crazy as it seems, I actually think I catch a whiff of Ivan.

Well, that’s kinda cool, I think. At least I’ll be remembering my best buddy when I die.

There are worse ways to go.

hey

The water laps at my mouth, foul tasting and frigid. “Now,” I say to my sister. “Get on my back *now*. I’m saving you, whether you like it or not.”

Something in my choked voice scares her, I guess, because she leaps right onto my back with a horrified yelp.

I blink back muddy water. A silver presence looms before me.

Still, I’m not entirely sure it’s him until I get a real big ol’ whiff of banana.

“Hey, Bob,” says Ivan.

giant monkey and sea monster

The screeches of terror are earsplitting. And my poor ears have endured plenty by this point.

“Folks!” I cry. “Relax! He’s here to save us!”

“Monkey!” screams the orange cat. “Giant monkey!”

“I beg your pardon,” says Ivan.

The bunny cowers in a corner of her cage. “If King Kong is here to eat us, I’d rather drown!”

“Sea serpent!” screams the beagle.

An arched gray trunk glides past.

“Ruby!” I exclaim. She’s just tall enough to keep her head above the water.

“Ivan! Ruby!” Snickers calls in a delighted voice. “Over here, dears! Long time no see!”

“Hey, Snickers!” Ruby says.

Snickers wags her drenched tail puff. “My, how you’ve grown, sweetie!”

“Excuse me,” says Gray Muzzle, “but maybe the happy reunion could wait till we’re, you know, not underwater?”

Ivan taps his chin. He’s always slow, always deliberate. I like that about the guy.

Except when I’m about to drown.

“We need to get all of you to higher ground,” he says at last. “But the current’s tough to fight, even for Ruby and me.”

“There’s always the roof,” I say. “But it’s damaged.”

Ivan nods. “Seems there’s a tree on it.”

“Look, Uncle Bob!” Ruby says, paddling back and forth. “I’m an ele-mermaid!”

Kid always makes me smile. “Good work, Ruby!”

“I’ve got an idea,” says Ivan. “It’ll take multiple trips, so I’m going to start with the smallest creatures and work from there.”

My sister gazes down at me from her perch on my back. “You actually know this . . . ape?”

“He’s my best pal. Ivan and I go way back.”

A long pause follows.

“Bob,” Boss finally says, “you weren’t kidding. You really *have* had an interesting life.”

to safety

One thing about being a silverback. That strength-of-eight-men thing can come in handy.

Ivan starts with the bunny and the dachshund, one in each arm, along with the two cats perched on his shoulder and head.

One more trip, this time with the beagle and Snickers, and then Boss and me are on our way. Ruby holds tight to Gray Muzzle's collar and he manages to paddle alongside her, using Ruby as ballast.



It takes us a while to cross the street—the current's swift, and the water's up to Ruby's neck in places.

“Ivan,” I ask as we approach the other side, “did they find George and Julia?”

“They're okay. A little banged up, but fine. They made it safely to a keepers' shed. Tree fell and blocked the door.”

I choke back a sob of relief.

“George was out looking for you when Ruby and I left.”

“How . . . how did you find me?”

“Ruby saw which way you were running,” says Ivan. “And don’t forget that gorillas and elephants have great noses, Bob. Maybe not dog level. But not bad.”

“We followed your stink, Uncle Bob!” Ruby exclaims.

When we reach the far side, I see where Ivan has deposited our fellow inmates: the parking lot of a doughnut shop. The lights inside are off, like everywhere else, but I glimpse a few flickering candles, and people are milling about.

“C’mon, everybody,” Ivan calls. “Let’s get you inside. I’m hoping these folks won’t mind a bit of company.”

As we gather at the entrance, Boss pauses. “I’m, uh, gonna head out,” she says, avoiding my gaze.

“What?” I demand. “I just found you! You can’t leave now!”

She hesitates. “The puppy. Thought maybe I’d check. I mean, I know he’s probably . . . gone.” She looks at the muddy pavement. “It’s crazy, I know.”

“Yes,” I say firmly. “It is crazy. Besides, you’re too weak. And your paw is injured.” My voice grows urgent. “Think about it, Boss. What are the odds he stayed in that car and waited for you? Who knows where he is by now?”

“Yeah.” She looks defeated. “I suppose you’re right.”

“What’s wrong, Bob?” Ivan asks.

“My sister—”

“Whoa! Wait! This is your sister, Uncle Bob?” Ruby interrupts, turning to Boss. “Then that means you’re my aunt!”

“Boss had—has—a puppy,” I explain. “Stuck in a car near the bridge.” I point with my nose. Ivan doesn’t know his way around town the way I do. “That way. Not far. She wants to try to find him, but, well, you know . . . he’s probably long gone by now.”

I know my words are harsh, but I’m trying to protect Boss.

No way that puppy is still alive.

Ivan strokes his chin. “Why don’t we get everyone settled inside?” he suggests. “Then we can figure this out.”

“Never mind,” Boss says. “Bob’s right. It’s nuts. Way too dangerous. And probably too late, anyway.” She takes a deep breath. “He’s not exactly the first pup I’ve lost. You’d think I’d be used to this by now, wouldn’t you?”

I don’t know what to say. I want to make her pain go away. But what can I do?

I’m no bigger than Boss is, and certainly no smarter. And I’ve got my own problems. My busted nose, my aching foot. My angry stomach.

Look out for numero uno. That’s my motto for a reason. It’s kept me alive this long.

then, to my surprise

Some fool blurts, “I’ll go find him.”

And apparently it’s me.

yay

“We’ll go,” Ivan says.

“Yay! More swimming!” Ruby cries.

“It’s not safe, Ruby,” I say. “You have to stay here. I promised Akello I’d watch out for you.”

“I made it this far,” she says, donning her elephant pout face.

Ivan and I sigh. It’s exhausting, all this responsibility, this worry. This love.

“Promise to stay close?” I ask.

She holds up her trunk. “Elephant’s honor.”

“’Cause Akello will make dog soup outa me if anything happens to you.”

“Yuck!” Ruby giggles. “Hey, did you know I can almost do a somersault in the water, Uncle Bob?”

Ivan taps politely on the door to the doughnut shop. But even a polite knock from a gorilla sounds like a visit from a wrecking ball.

The door opens a crack.

I think two or three people may have fainted, but we can’t stay to find out.

I hop onto Ivan’s shoulder, and the three of us head off. I glance behind me to see Boss standing on the pavement, watching us.

In the darkness and rain I can’t read her eyes. But I’d like to think there’s hope in them.

traffic stop

We slog up a slight hill and round a corner. The traffic lights are out, and nobody seems to be on the streets—that is, until we cut through a stand of palm trees and come across some police officers in a slow-moving squad car, its blue and red lights circling.

“Attention,” one of the officers announces over a loudspeaker. “This area is under a mandatory evacuation order. Do not—”

The announcement stops, and so does the car.

“Uh-oh,” says Ruby.

“I think they spotted us,” I say.

“We’re kind of hard to miss,” Ivan points out.

The car moves closer, so close that I can see dropped jaws and bulging eyes.

The car brakes to a stop. The driver’s side door flies open and one of the officers jumps out.

The other officer, a skinny young guy, follows suit, but he looks annoyed. “What are you doing?” he says. “Don’t be a hero! We coulda stayed in the car where it’s safe.”

“I am looking,” says the driver into her radio receiver, “at a gorilla and an elephant, and the gorilla has a tiny dog on his shoulder, and no, I have not been drinking.”

“They said the park got hit by the tornado,” says the skinny officer, carefully aiming his pistol.

“We can’t exactly shoot a gorilla,” the driver says, and I like the way she’s thinking.

“Try me.”

“What’s his crime, exactly?”

“Jaywalking?”

“Thing is, I love elephants,” says the driver. “My daughter collects stuffed elephants. I mean, you know. Stuffed toys. Not stuffed real ones.” She listens to her radio for a moment.

“Get animal control out here,” says the skinny officer. “Get a van. Get a moving truck. Get a 747, I don’t care.”

“Ivan,” I whisper in his ear, “this is not looking good. You and Ruby gotta stay put. Don’t make any sudden moves. No funny business, okay? These guys are freaking out.”

Ivan sits down on the ground. Slowly. Very, very slowly. Ruby settles next to him.

The driver smiles. “Aww, that’s so cute.”

Skinny officer nods. “Yeah, in a deadly kind of way.”

“I gotta do this,” I say to my friends. “If you stay calm, they won’t mess with you.”

“But Bob.” Worry clouds Ivan’s face. “You need us.”

“What I need is for you to stay alive,” I reply.

I can see he isn’t going to listen to reason, so I try a different approach.

“Ivan,” I say, “it’s like this. Boss is my sister. I let her down once, and now, well, I have a second chance. I’ll explain it all later, but . . . I need to do this.”

Ivan looks at the officers, guns drawn, then nods. “You are the one and only Bob,” he says. “You got this, pal.”

I leap into the air, into the vast unknown, just like Kimu did.

Well, maybe not quite so elegantly, but I do my best.

lightning and fireworks

It isn't far to the bridge. But far is relative when the wind is blowing down houses like the big, bad wolf.

I watch a stop sign fly past. I navigate around trees scattered like Popsicle sticks. I keep an eye out for gators and pythons.

Lightning strikes a tree. I brace for the thunder. It shakes the earth, the air, my teeth, my bones.



A branch falls on a power line. Sparks dance like fireworks.

I hate fireworks.

I move with more care after that. I know enough to stay away from downed power lines, thanks to the weather channel and *Storm Chasers*.

Man, I love TV. I'd give anything to be watching it from my nice, cozy bed right about now.

Good thing I know where the bridge is. My swollen nose throbs. What's the point in owning a top-of-the-line sniffer if it's not working right?

When I pass a bird's nest on the ground, I offer to help the owner, a jay. She swears at me. At least I think she does. I hear "nuts" and some other interesting words.

I tend to forget that in some circles, dogs are considered predators.

I wonder how Kimu and the other escapees are doing. One thing I know for sure, having been on the inside and the outside, is that way too much of the world ain't made for wild animals.

How would a meerkat cross a highway? How would a panther face down a city block? How would a wolf survive an encounter with a gun?

For that matter, who do I think I am, playing hero? Nutwit was right. I'm soft. I'm slow. I'm not a street dog anymore. I'm a pampered, lazy pooch.

I hear the rush of water, a different sound from the pouring rain, and out of nowhere, there it is: the creek.

Boss mentioned that the car was near the bridge. But when I get close, I remember what the officer at the shelter said. The bridge had collapsed.

And then I see it.

A little car, round topped, floating, caught in a dislodged tree at the edge of the roaring creek, not far from the crumbled remains of the bridge.

And on top of that car, even though it's completely impossible, is a puppy.

Waiting.

And all I can think is: *That dog is a nincompoop.*



another bridge

The creek is filled with pieces of trees, boards, trash cans, plastic chairs, everything you can imagine. It's moving way too fast for me to try to cross.

I stare at the far side of the creek, at the collapsed bridge. I really wish I hadn't seen that puppy.

I know there's another way to cross the creek, of sorts, downstream a bit. An old pedestrian bridge made of wood and metal and rope. No one uses it anymore.

No one with any sense.

When I reach it, the little bridge is swaying like a cradle. It's blocked off by a rusty metal gate to keep people from using it, but I can easily squeeze through the bars.

I run halfway across, lose my footing, run some more.

Gulp. What am I doing?

A fresh gust pushes the bridge with such force that I slip. Half my body is dangling off the edge. I dig my claws into the wet wooden slats, and oh am I glad my nails are long and sharp because I fight off Sara's clippers whenever I can.

Pulling, pulling, pulling—man, I wish I hadn't eaten so much cheese over the years—and then *umpph*, one last effort and I'm back on the bridge.

It feels good, so good, to return to that little stretch of swinging slats. I want to live. Really I do.

I don't care about the puppy anymore.

I just don't want to die this way, not like this.

The fear's in my throat, my heart, my gut. I've gotta get off this rickety bridge, get back to Ivan and Ruby, back to my wonderful, Bob-smelling bed.

I'm not a hero, never have been, never will be.

I can live with that, 'cause at least I'll be alive.

I turn, moving snail-slow because the stupid bridge just won't stay put, crawling on my belly so I won't lose my footing again.

Almost to the end, I glance back, like a fool.

Just in time to see the car with the puppy lurch loose from its mooring in the tree, swirling into the middle of the creek like a toy boat in a bathtub.

The puppy isn't howling or anything. He's just lying on his belly, same as me, waiting.

What a nincompoop, I think yet again, and I'm honestly not sure whether I mean him or me.

hero

I will not lie. I am not thinking, *Oh yay, now I get to be a hero.*

Nope.

I'm thinking, *You have got to be kidding me! Just a few more seconds and I woulda been outa here.*

I may or may not use a few other choice words. Way worse than anything that jay came up with.

Then I run back to the middle of the bridge and wait a split second, maybe two, maybe three, and I jump.

cartoons

And I ain't proud of this, but halfway down I remember that I really, really, really don't like riding in cars.

I'm sort of dog paddling the air, thinking I can slow things down—maybe even reverse direction—like Wile E. Coyote in those old cartoons.

Cartoons are ridiculous for a reason.

not a movie

So in a movie, I'd land all graceful and tough and grab that little guy.

But this isn't a movie.

I kinda land on top of him. Legs splayed like a bug on a windshield.

Not enough to smush him.

But definitely enough to annoy him.

The car spins, dips, rights itself.

"Hi," I say. "I'm your uncle Bob."

"If you're my uncle, why are you trying to kill me?" he asks.

Pup has a mouth on him, for being so tiny.

"I'm saving you, dude." I grab his scruff with my teeth.

"Ouch," he says.

The car seesaws. I scrabble, clawing at the slick skin of the roof. My nails make a horrible scraping sound.

It's like trying to hug a whale.

"Can you swim?" I ask out of the side of my mouth. It's hard to talk with a puppy between your teeth.

"No. Can you?"

“Yes. But I suspect the degree of difficulty will go up considerably with a puppy in my mouth.”

The car lists, recovers, lopes along like a jackrabbit in tall grass. My claws make tracks in the paint.

“How’d you get on top of the car?” I ask.

“Wasn’t easy. Branch broke through one of the windows. I climbed out that way.”

“Impressive.”

“By the way,” says the puppy, “I think we may be sinking.”

“No kidding, Sherlock.” I don’t mean to sound unkind. I’m a bit stressed.

“I don’t have a name, actually.”

“How about Rowdy?” I suggest. “I hear it’s available.”

“Sure, what the heck? So what’s your plan?”

“You tell me,” I say. “What’d you think was going to happen?”

“I figured someone would come along and save me. Some human, maybe.”

“Dog’s best friend?” I say.

“If you say so.”

Another lurch. We’re going down.

“Hang on, pup,” I say. “Man’s best friend is gonna save you instead.”

do not let go

The water's cold, so cold it burns. I paddle frantically. Nothing happens. It's like pawing air.

I keep my teeth tight on Rowdy. *Do not let go. Do not let go*, I tell myself, but the water's churning into my nose and throat, and if I cough, he'll be a goner.

We hit something hard and metal straight on. I'm underwater, submerged, as bits and pieces of the world rush past.

It's like the tornado, only wetter.

I dig at the darkness. I think of all the things I'll miss when I'm dead.

Cheese tops the list.

Well, okay, maybe Ivan and Ruby and Julia and George and Sara top the list.

But then totally cheese.

My back paws graze the bottom. My nose burns. My lungs burn. Everything burns.

I have to cough.

I can't cough.

Mustering all my strength, I struggle to the surface for a moment, fighting the water with my paws.

Rowdy is dead weight in my mouth.

I hit bottom again, and this time I use it like a springboard, lurching toward the edge of the water, toward solid land, toward grass and dirt and trees and bushes and— A whoosh of fur and pain, oh man, the pain, someone grabbing my paw, losing it, teeth, sharp, sharp teeth, the smell, even with my messed-up nose, of wildness and danger.

Something grabs my scruff, yanks, pulls me to safety.

Back to the world. Back from the brink.

kimu again

Kimu has me.

He drops me to the mud. His teeth smell of blood. My blood.

I drop Rowdy. My teeth smell of blood, too.

For a long time, no words come, just panting, coughing, panting some more.

Nothing from the puppy. I shove him with my paw, nudge him with my nose.

Nothing.

I look at Kimu, his fur spiked, his eyes wild, different, unknowable.

“I guess they didn’t shoot you?” I say.

“They tried,” he says, eyes on the puppy.

“Thank you for . . .” I trail off.

He glances at me. “Didn’t do it for you.” A pause. “Did it for me.”

With his right front paw, he claws at the puppy. At Rowdy.

“Hey,” I say without really thinking. Or registering the size of his paw. Or realizing that he’s drooling, just a little.

“He, uh.” I put my paw, my puny pathetic loser paw, on Rowdy too. “He’s my . . . my nephew, and well, I—”

“Didn’t take you for the sentimental sort, Bob.”

“I’m not. Just, you know how it is.”

“No, actually, I don’t know. I’m a wild animal. Not a pet.”

“Still.” I clear my throat and remind myself that rolling over and peeing myself is not an acceptable option. “Still and all, he’s scrawny, might even be dead, who knows? You got better breakfasts at the park.”

I recognize all too well the look he gives me. The look of sadness and loss and anger, the look of someone who will never forgive the world.

He’s running with the puppy dangling from his jaws before I even know what’s happened.

how

I don't know how I do it.

If I did know, maybe I could understand that other part of me. The wolf part.

I run, faster than I've ever run.

I growl, louder than I've ever growled.

I grab Kimu's throat. I clamp down.

I do not let go.



gone

He can kill me. With a sidelong glance and a half-hearted bite, he can kill me.

I know that.

But he doesn't.

He drops the puppy.

He shakes me off and pulls free.

He pauses. Looks at me like he's seeing me for the first time.

He gazes at the sky, thick with clouds. No moon. Barely any sun.

He raises his head.

His howl is long and sad and beautiful.

He runs.

first aid

Rowdy still isn't moving.

I don't know what else to do.

So I bite the heck outa his tail.

Perks the little guy right up.

the truth

It hits me then. I'm so tired. So banged up. I can't go on, even if I want to.

I carry Rowdy to a sheltering tree. Cuddle him close. Give him a couple licks for good measure.

"Now what?" he asks.

"Now," I say, "we wait."

"For what?"

"For humans," I answer. "For help."

"Are you sure they'll come?"

I think for a moment.

I remember all the people I've seen today, the police and rescue workers, the park employees, the staff at the shelter, the folks at the doughnut shop opening their door to a strange collection of animals. I remember George running to get Julia, and Julia trying to get me, and Sara struggling to find them both.

I breathe in the sweet smell of puppy. It's important to tell the truth.

"I'm sure," I say.

forever

The eye of the hurricane passes. The storm rages on.

It feels like a year. Like nine years, even.

It feels like forever.



rescue

When I hear Julia calling my name through the open window of her parents' car, I pick up Rowdy and dash over like it's my favorite place on this lonely ball called Earth.

No clickers necessary.

No treats required.

I fly my drool flag all the way home.

Four

aftermath

We've lost ten park residents total. Eight deaths, plus two still missing. No humans died, but there were some injuries.

They've already started rebuilding. It's funny the way people go right back at it after a tragedy. Everyone comes together. Lots of talk about community and *kumbaya*, *blahblahblah*.

They're a resilient species, I'll give them that.

It's been three weeks, and we still don't have Kimu back. Suzu either. There've been some sightings, nothing for sure.

I worry they can't last long. Wolves aren't native to this part of the world.

I like to think they're together, at least.

Everybody else is back, with makeshift domains. Nobody's complaining, though.

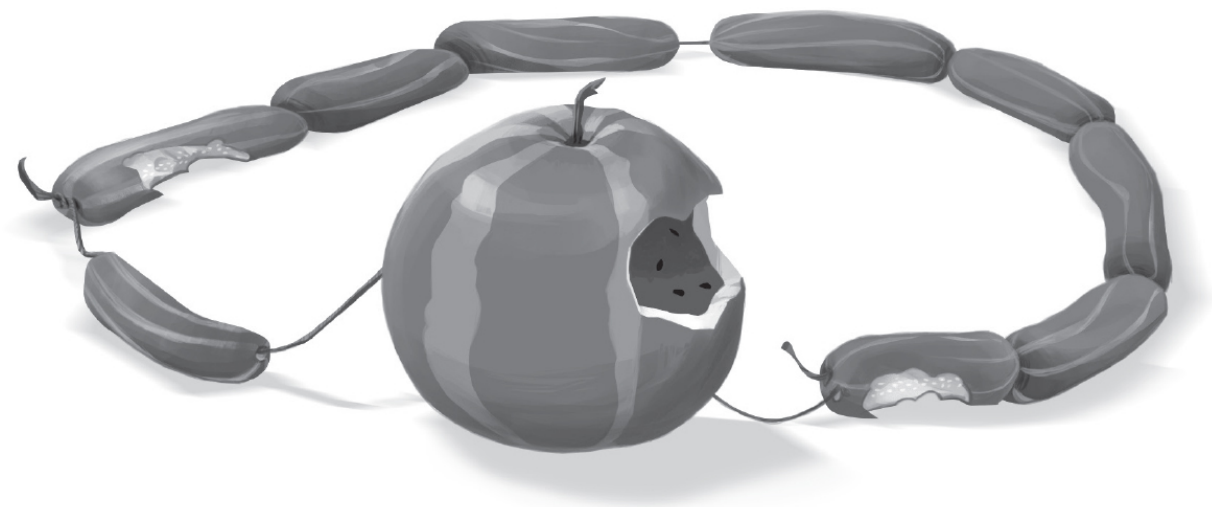
In spite of all the construction, Julia's been taking me to see Ivan and Ruby whenever she can.

Today Ivan leans on the temporary fence separating him from the elephants. Maya made him a medal for valor out of a watermelon and cucumbers. He's eaten most of it.

"It's pretty great almost everybody we saved from the shelter ended up with a home," says Ivan. "Even that annoying bunny."

"Almost everyone," I remind him.

"I'm so sorry about Boss," he says in his gentle way.



From what we can tell, Boss never went into the doughnut shop. She slipped away, and no one knows what happened to her.

I try not to feel hurt. But I had this silly fantasy about me and her and Rowdy all hanging out together like a family.

And I so wanted her to know what it's like to have a warm bed and a full bowl and a good ear scratch whenever you need it.

I wanted her to know she deserves that as much as any dog.

I guess she'd lived life too long on her own terms. Or maybe she was afraid to get her hopes up. To trust.

I understand. Been there, done that.

But sometimes humans don't let you down. Sometimes they even come to the rescue.

riddle

“Uncle Bob!” Ruby calls, galloping over.

She seems more confident these days. A little more grown up. Stella would be proud. I know I am.

“Want to hear my new riddle?”

“Absolutely I do.”

Ruby flaps her ears. She does that when she gets excited. “What has an eye but cannot see?”

“I am perplexed, Ruby. Pondering and puzzled.”

“A hurricane!” she exclaims.

“Good one, Ruby. First-rate.”

I look at Ivan. We smile at each other. We don’t need to say a thing.

It’s enough to listen to the palm trees rustle and watch the saw grass sway.

working on it

On the way home, we pass the shelter. It's been patched up pretty well, looks like. And they're back in business.

I hear the usual yelps and howls and hisses and meows, and like always, I feel lousy. I plop down on the sidewalk, and Julia stops walking.

"What's going on, Bob?" she asks.

I listen, like I always do, for her bark. *That* bark.

Nope. Nothing.

I wish Rowdy were here to distract me. But he's still learning how to walk on a tug-of-war string.

He's a pretty swell pup, even if he is a little feisty. I'm surprised how much I like having him around the house.

It's weird. I feel responsible for the little guy. Sorta like he's become my numero uno.

Julia bends down and strokes my head. I wag my tail a bit, slowly stand. I think of poor old Droolius stuck in that backyard, day and night. I think of Boss, roaming the streets. I think of my siblings, the dark night, the box, the highway.

I'm trying hard to find the forgiveness that seems to come so naturally to other dogs. Maybe that's what Boss was getting at. Maybe it's easier to forgive others once you've learned how to forgive yourself.

I'm working on it. It's like a bone. Sometimes you have to chew for a long time before you make any progress.

snickers, again

Once we're home, I head for the couch. I'm snoozing peacefully with Rowdy when a smell, a doozy of a smell, assaults my schnozz, which is finally back to working order.

It's *her*.

Snickers is back.

She's been gone for a while. After the hurricane, they had to do some repairs to Mack's house. Not sure where Snickers has been staying, but that's definitely her I smell, no doubt about it.

I dive under the couch, but not before Nutwit appears at the front window. "Oh, Bobbo!" he calls. "Someone's looking for you!"

"I'm not home," I yell.

"Yeah, I don't think she'll take no for an answer," says Nutwit.

"Shouldn't you be rebuilding your nest?"

"Naw. Watching you cower in fear is way more fun."

"What's the deal, Uncle Bob?" Rowdy asks.

"Be afraid, Rowdy," I say. "Be very afraid."

The door opens, and there's Julia with Snickers by her side.

"Well, hello there, Snickers," says Sara as she passes through the living room. "What are you doing here?"

“Mack and his wife just moved back in,” Julia says. “They called this afternoon and said Snickers was dying for a walk.”

I ease back a little farther under the couch. Can Snickers see me? Maybe not. But she can most definitely smell me.

For once I regret my pungent aroma.

Snickers darts across the living room straight to the couch, pulling Julia along for the ride.

“Snickers!” Julia exclaims. “Slow down, girl!” She kneels. “Bob, are you hiding under there?”

I move an inch, exposing my snout.

Snickers goes insane. She yanks free of her tug-of-war string. For a moment, she pauses to do a polite nose tap with Rowdy. Then she lets loose with zoomies and yips and howls of joy.

“Bob,” Julia says, “come on out and say hi.”

I pretend not to hear her. Which isn’t a big stretch, since Snickers is barking like a maniac.

“Robert,” says Julia.

Fine. I belly-crawl out until I’m exposed.

Snickers is ecstatic. She showers me with licks and nips and nudges and leaps. “Bob,” she croons, “how I’ve missed you!”

I cover my head with my paws, but there’s no escaping her adoration.

“There’s a reason we survived, Bob,” she says, her fuzzy tail in high gear. “The fates want our love to blossom.”



“Is this your girlfriend, Uncle Bob?” Rowdy inquires.

“Girlfriend today,” Snickers responds in a giddy voice. “But who knows what tomorrow may bring? Perhaps you should start calling me Aunt Snickers.”

I am relieved beyond measure when Julia finally pulls Snickers, with great effort, out the door. I try to ignore Nutwit’s teasing. I try to tolerate Rowdy’s stifled laughter.

But when Minnie starts chanting “Bob and Snickers!” followed by Moo’s “sitting in a tree!” I’ve had enough.

I head for my doggie door, ignoring the popcorning guinea pigs, and try to locate my dignity.

a visitor

This evening is like lots of other evenings.

The guinea pigs are squeaking. Nutwit is puttering in his tree. Julia and Sara and George are watching something about meerkats on the nature channel.

I've just settled in with Rowdy on the couch when George drops a cookie on the floor.

I leap into action.

"Robert," says Julia, "leave it."

Briefly, I consider my options. But not for long.

At least I share a piece with Rowdy.

"You are hopeless," Julia says. "But I love you anyway."

And that's when we hear the bark.

It's coming from the front porch.

"Hmm. That's weird," says George.

"I'll check it out." Julia runs to the door and pulls it open.

She hesitates.

She looks over at me, back at the porch, back at me.

"Bob?" she says. "I think it's for you."

And it is.



Author's Note

Dogs. Aren't they just the best?

If you answered "no," or even "yes" with a hint of ambivalence, um . . . what is wrong with you?

Sorry. Even if you're not on Team Canine, I'm sure you're a swell person. Maybe you're a cat fanatic, or a guinea pig fan. I get that. I love all kinds of creatures, right down to tarantulas and naked mole rats.

And I'll admit that some dogs are easier to love than others. My own mutt, Stan, is a case in point. Mercurial, needy, narcissistic, he's not exactly the poster dog for Man's Best Friend. Still and all, when Stan cuddles up just so (usually while I'm busy on my laptop), he somehow manages to pull off that mysterious canine magic trick: he makes me feel a little bit better about life.

Stan also serves as my muse, albeit sporadically. As a matter of fact, Bob, the narrator of this novel, was modeled on Stan, right down to the misanthropy, the gluttony, and the odor.

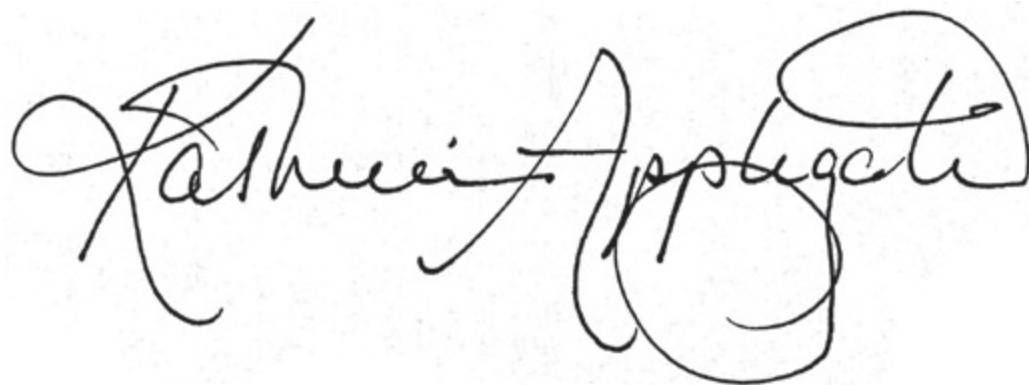
Bob originally appeared as a character in my novel *The One and Only Ivan*, inspired by the true story of a western lowland gorilla. The real Ivan spent twenty-seven years, alone and caged, in a shopping mall in Tacoma, Washington. Did he ever have a pal like Bob? I don't know. But there was a pet store at the mall where Ivan lived, and he had lots of visitors. It wasn't a stretch for me to imagine such a friendship evolving.

And so Bob was born. He had to be tiny, to fit in a hole in Ivan's cage. He had to be wily. He had to be a street dog: tough and blunt and no-nonsense. (You can imagine my delight when I learned that the inimitable Danny DeVito would be voicing Bob in the Disney *The One and Only Ivan* movie. Yep. That's Bob, all right.)

Bob's had a tough life. He's seen the darker side of humans. He doesn't really get the whole "man's best friend" thing. (His best friend, as it happens, is a gorilla.) He's carrying some pretty heavy baggage for such a little dog. And he faces down a lot in this story: tornadoes and owls, floods and wolves, terror and guilt and self-doubt.

But through it all, Bob never loses his tiny-mutt swagger. And he never stops listening to his good-dog heart.

Even if you're a devout cat person, I hope you enjoyed spending time with the guy.

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "Katharine Applegate". The signature is written in a cursive, flowing style. The first name "Katharine" is written in a more traditional cursive, while the last name "Applegate" features a large, prominent loop for the letter 'A' and a stylized 'g'.

Acknowledgments

Authors, like dogs, may seem like simple creatures. But beneath our shaggy exteriors, we require lots of support and TLC. *The One and Only Bob* would never have happened without the help of many lovely humans.

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—And finally, thanks to the many readers of *The One and Only Ivan* who told me Bob needed a story of his own.

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If you want to help homeless pets, start here: —Your local animal shelter—they always need a helping hand!

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ENDING

THE LAST



Newbery Medal-Winning Author of *THE ONE AND ONLY IVAN*

KATHERINE APPELEGATE



WHEN ONE IS ENDANGERED,
ALL ARE IN PERIL.

1. Endling

Long before I heard the word, I was used to being last.

I was the runt, the youngest and by-far-and-away smallest of my seven siblings, which meant I was the last to drink, the last to eat, the last to be protected.

As the lowest-ranking member of our dwindling pack, I accepted my place without resentment—much resentment, anyway.

It was, perhaps, only fair. My failings were many, or so I was often told.

I was too young to be clever, too small to be helpful.

My feet were large and clumsy. They tangled when I ran.

My coat was untidy, my manners dreadful. I once ate an entire leg of anteleer before my rightful turn.

I was curious to a fault. I wandered too far and wondered too often.

I was, in short, a disappointment at my only task in life, which was to do my best, like all dairnes, to stay quietly alive.

Those days, you'd have been as likely to pet a unicorn as you would to sight a dairne.

Our packelder, Dalyntor, white muzzled and frail, liked to speak of a time when our ancestors roamed in great bands, hundreds of dairnes at a time, across the Nedarran plains. At night they would form into family groups, gathering around to prepare wild grasses and berries, or perhaps cook the stray badger or cotchet.

But all that was long ago. Now there were just a few of us left in our part of the world, a single band of four families cowering together, meek as mouselings.

Hiding from humans, those most unpredictable of predators.

Hiding from the sun itself.

Some said there were more dairnes far away, living in mountain caves or on distant islands. Some said those sightings were the result of misguided hope. Dairnes were often mistaken for dogs. We share many physical similarities.

Dogs, however, lack opposable thumbs. They can't walk upright. They aren't able to glide from tree to tree. They can't speak to humans.

And dogs aren't—forgive me—the sharpest claws in the hunt, if you catch my meaning.

In any case, whether there were more of us or not, Dalyntor feared we would all be gone soon, slaughtered for our warm and silky fur.

Like the Carlisian seal, hunted by humans to extinction.

Or the red marlot, devastated by disease.

Or the blue-tufted ziguin, wiped out when its territory was destroyed in the Long-Ago War.

It seemed there were many ways to leave the world forever.

We didn't want to believe our days were numbered. But here is what we did know: once we'd been many, and now we were few.

My parents feared I would be the first among us to die when trouble came, and trouble, they knew, was fast approaching.

I was small. And sometimes disappointing.

But I knew I could be brave as well. I was not afraid to be the first to die.

I just did not want to be the last to live.

I did not want to be the endling.

2. A Visit from Some Butterbats

The end began not so long ago, the day some butterbats came to visit.

It was early afternoon when I first heard them. I tiptoed past my sleeping family, nestled together like one great animal.

Dairnes are not night creatures by nature, but we no longer ventured out until the sun was long gone. We feared the giant cats called felivets, who hunted at night. But we feared poachers and the soldiers of the Murdano, Nedarra's ruler, even more.

Still, I was restless. And I was sure I'd heard something just outside the door: the air, moving beneath wings both delicate and powerful.

My sister Lirya yawned and opened one eye. "I'm so hungry I could eat you, Byx," she murmured.

"She's too scrawny to eat," said my oldest brother, Avar.

I ignored their teasing. I was used to ignoring my siblings.

It took some effort, squeezing through the door of our latest temporary home. An abandoned mirabear hive, it resembled a huge wasp nest that had fallen to earth. It was shaped like a honeycomb, with holes the size of large boulders, and glistened in the light like raw honey, though it was rock-hard to the touch. My father said the hive was made of volcanic ash, sulfur, and sand, mixed with sap from a bulla tree.

Dairnes used to fashion circle camps on the plains, or weave tree nests when we moved through forests. We didn't do that anymore.

There were many things we didn't do anymore. Or so Dalyntor, our teacher, the holder of our history, told us. He hinted at much more, but there were parts of the dairne story too harsh for our young ears.

Tree nests were too easy to spot, too vulnerable to arrows. Instead we moved from place to place, sheltering in caves or deep gullies, or within bramble patches in the heart of the forest. We left no evidence of our passing, no hint of nests or camps. We slept at the bases of cliffs, on remote beaches, in the deserted homes of other creatures. Our little band once spent the night in a large abandoned hunter's lodge.

That was the closest I had ever come to humans, one of the six great governing species. Those six—humans, dairnes, felivets, natites,

terramants, and raptidons—had once been considered the most powerful in our land. But now all of them—even the humans—were controlled by the despotic Murdano.

I'd only encountered two of the other great governing species. I'd scented felivets, huge, graceful felines, gliding through blackest night. (No one ever hears them.) And I'd seen raptidons, lords of the air, carving arcs through the clouds.

Never, though, had I glimpsed a natite.

Never (thankfully) a terramant swarm.

And never a human.

Still, I knew more than a few things about humans. Dalyntor had taught us pups about them, drawing stick figures on a dried playa leaf. From him, I learned that humans have two eyes, a nose, and a mouth filled with blunt teeth. I learned they stand taller than we dairnes, but not by too much. I learned a great deal about their habits, their clothing, their villages and cities, their culture, their weapons, their languages, how they measure time and distance.

And I learned, most importantly, that humans were never to be trusted, and always to be feared.

I emerged from the mirabear hive into slanting sunlight.

The sound grew nearer, and then I saw them above the hive.

Butterbats!

There were four of them, easily three tails wide and almost as long, with shimmery wings that wove rainbows out of the tree-filtered light. They must have thought there were still mirabears there, butterbats being great lovers of honey—and great thieves besides.

Despite the stiff breeze, they had no trouble hovering silently overhead like huge hummingbirds.

"Byx." The voice was soft, part concern, part scold. I turned to see that my mother had joined me. She looked weary, her dark gold fur mussed, her tail listless.

"Butterbats, Maia!" I whispered.

She followed my gaze. "So beautiful. They're heading north, I expect. It's migration time for them."

"I wish I could go, too."

"I know it's hard sometimes, this life." She stroked my back. "Especially for you little ones."

“I’m not little.”

My mother nudged me with her nose. “Not so little anymore. True enough.”

I sighed, leaning into her. She was as warm and safe as a patch of sun.

“I’m bored, Maia. I want to have fun. I want to chase my tail. I want to learn new things. I want to go on adventures and be brave.”

“No need to rush toward bravery,” she said softly. “No rush at all.”

“The big ones call me runt. And whelp,” I moaned. “They say I ask too many questions.” I was rather enjoying feeling so sorry for myself. “I hate being me.”

“Byx,” my mother said, “don’t ever say that. There’s only one you in the whole wide world. And I love that you ask so many questions. That’s how we learn.” She paused. “I’ll tell you something. Something none of the other pups know yet.”

My ears flicked to alert.

“The adults had a meeting last night. We’ll be leaving here at sundown. Heading north, just like the butterbats. Myxo will be leading us. She said we’ve searched in the southlands long enough.”

Myxo was our pathfinder. She had the keenest nose and the best instincts of anyone in our pack, and she’d traveled far and wide looking for more dairnes. Still, though we’d heard rumors of dairne sightings, nothing ever came of them. Our pack was down to twenty-nine members.

“This is a big move,” my mother said. “A sort of migration of our own. We’re going to search for the First Colony.”

“But Dalyntor taught us they’re long gone.” I remembered our lessons about the First Colony, the original group of dairnes who migrated to Nedarra long ago. We’d had to memorize a poem—an extremely long poem—about them.

I love learning more than anyone in my family. But even I have to admit it may have been the most boring poem ever spoken:

*Sing, poet, of the Ancients who dared forth—
Brave dairnes, o’er mountains treacherous and cruel,
Who crossed the frigid waters of the north
To Dairneholme, living isle and floating jewel.*

That's all I recall. If Dalyntor hadn't let us draw maps while he recited it, I would have fallen fast asleep. Most of the other pups did.

"Maia?" I asked. "Do you really think there might still be a colony in the north?"

My mother looked across the meadow to the dark, wind-fretted forest, but didn't answer. "It's not impossible," she said at last.

Dairnes do not lie. There would be no point, since we can always detect an untruth, not just from our own kind, but from anyone.

No other species has this ability. Dalyntor often called it "our burdensome gift," although I didn't understand what he meant by that.

Nonetheless, although dairnes don't lie, we do sometimes . . . hope.

"But you don't think so?" I pressed, although I could already tell her answer.

"No, my love." It was almost a whisper. "But perhaps I'm wrong."

"I'm sure you're wrong. I'll bet we'll find hundreds of dairnes. Thousands, even!" I stopped myself. "It's not wrong to hope, is it?"

"It's never wrong to hope, Byx," said my mother. "Unless the truth says otherwise." She gave me another nose nudge. "Now, it's back to bed for you. We have a long night's walk ahead of us."

The butterbats still circled, dipping and twirling just beyond reach. "A few more minutes, Maia," I pleaded. "They're so pretty."

"Not too long," she said, "and no exploring." She turned, then hesitated. "I love you, my pup. Don't ever forget that."

"I love you, too, Maia."

A long time passed before the butterbats moved on. Maybe they were amazed to have happened upon some dairnes. Or maybe they were simply enjoying the waves of warm air rising from the sun-touched hive.

As I turned back toward the entrance, something strange, something I couldn't quite place, caught my attention.

Not a sound, exactly, or a scent.

More like a hunch.

I took a few steps toward the small meadow separating me from a dark line of trees. Beyond it stretched the sea.

I consulted the scents on the whipping wind. The air was heavy with stories.

Was that treefox I smelled? Brindalet? It was hard to pin things down in the zigzag wind.

The forest called to me, silent but compelling, willing me to approach. Golden ribbons of light threaded through the trees. I'd never been there in daylight, only in the dead of night.

No, I told myself. We were forbidden to leave the pack, especially during the day, and most especially without permission.

And I didn't leave—not much, anyway.

I'd ventured to a stream fizzing with green bubbles. I'd sought the company of a friendly zebra squirrel and her babies. Yesterday I'd visited a cluster of star flowers, scented like sage and sea. It was a lovely spot for tail chasing.

I never took big risks. Never went far. But how could I possibly learn about the world if I never got to see it?

I knew I shouldn't go. But before we moved on, before we trekked to the next dark place, wouldn't it be wonderful to view the sea, just once, in daylight? I had only ever seen it by starlight.

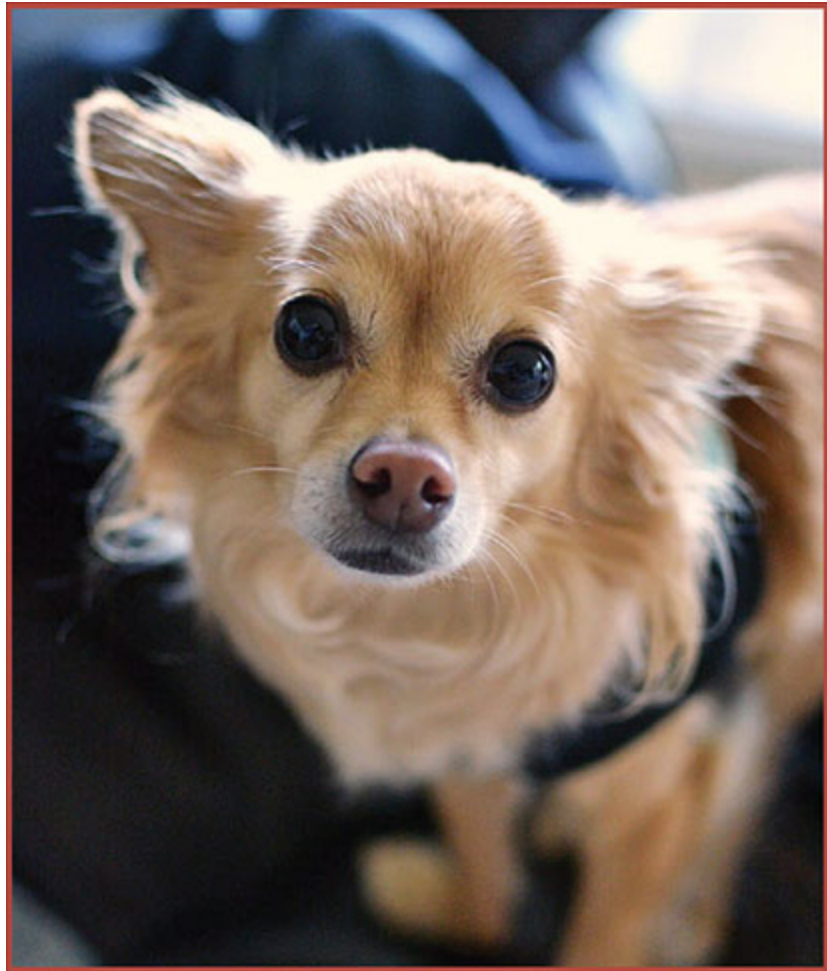
My mother was back in our nest. I checked the freshening breeze: no danger.

Only a few minutes to cross the meadow, dropping onto all fours to run. Only a few minutes more to pass through that intimidating but enticing wall of trees.

Just a moment, I told myself. Just a glimpse of the sun, dancing on water.

A moment or two, and then I'd return, having never been missed.

About the Author

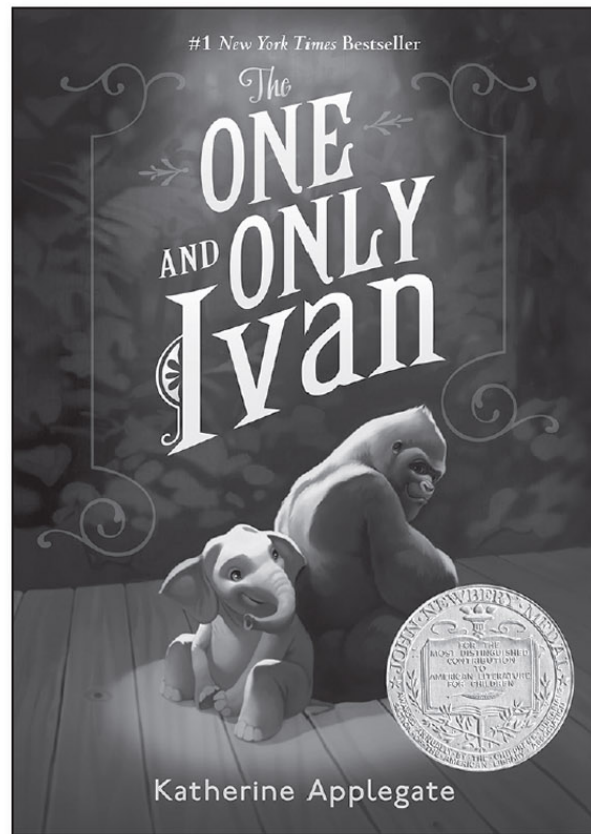


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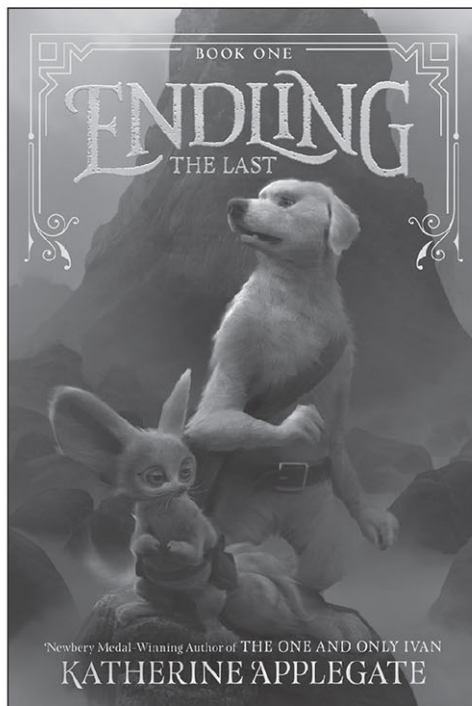
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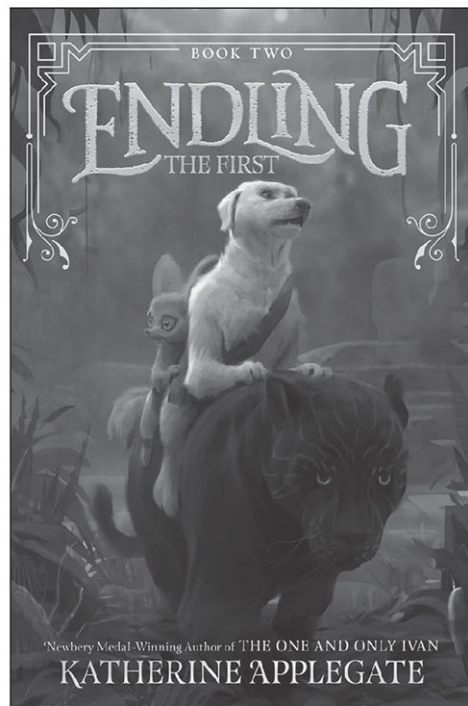
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